
DIFFICULT PASSAGES OF THE QURAN AND THE TEXT'S OWN INSTRUCTIONS FOR READING THEM

A Structural Reading of the Quran's Hardest Passages

STRUCTURAL READING · SCRIPTURE STUDIES

How the text's own citation, scoping, and boundary practices resolve its hardest passages

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MOHAMMAD F ISLAM

PhD · Independent Researcher

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ABSTRACT. For fourteen centuries a recognizable list of Quranic passages has been transmitted as difficult. Disconnected letters that open twenty-nine chapters and spell nothing. A Book that describes itself as clear and then declares part of itself ambiguous. Hands, a face, a throne, and a bared shin predicated of the One the same Book says nothing resembles. Two deaths and two lives in a text that elsewhere counts one death. A number given with no explanation. Words that the earliest lexicographers conceded they could not fix. This study argues that the difficulty in the families it takes up, which are the bulk of the transmitted list, is very largely not obscurity in the text. It is the consequence of three ordinary features of how the Quran writes, each of which the text states about itself, and each of which produces the appearance of a riddle when the reader is unaware of it. A fourth practice, distinct from those three, accounts for the residue they do not touch. The first is a **citation practice**. The Quran is in argument on nearly every page and it very rarely quotes its opponent. A rebuttal with the claim removed reads as an unprompted riddle, and restoring the missing claim dissolves the riddle. The second is a **scoping practice**. The Quran states the purpose of its hardest verses in the adjacent clause and scopes its own universal quantifiers inside the verse that carries them, so a difficulty produced by stopping the citation one clause early is a difficulty of the citation and not of the text. The third is a **lexical practice**. The Quran defines its own disputed words at other places in itself, so a dispute the lexicographers could not settle is often a dispute a concordance ends. Beside those three stands a fourth practice which does not dissolve difficulty but accounts for what is left: at a small number of points the Quran declares that something is being withheld, defends the withholding, and states what would be needed to cross it. Those points do not resolve, and this study argues that not resolving is what they are for. The method is set out in full in Part One and requires no specialized apparatus: the reader needs the text, a concordance, and the willingness to read to the end of a passage. Part Two applies it across twelve families of difficulty: the self-declared limits, the attribute verses, the decree verses, the verses about Word and Spirit, the narrative enigmas, the lexical knots, the unexplained numbers, the verses that correct the Prophet ﷺ himself, the verses the interior tradition built on, the verses that touch cosmology, the verses about death and the interval, and the account of the covenant and the trust. Part Three states what remains, and it is a short list. Where earlier scriptures and the rabbinic and patristic literatures appear in these pages, they appear for one reason only. The Quran addresses them. It names the communities that hold them, quotes their formulas to refuse or to confirm them, and retells their narratives with clauses restored or removed. Those texts are therefore evidence about the Quran's audience and never the instrument that decides a Quranic reading, and every appearance of them below is marked as such.

KEYWORDS *Quran · difficult passages · structural reading · root recovery · intertextuality · scriptural self-reference · concordance method*

HOW TO READ THIS STUDY

THE CLAIM IN ONE SENTENCE

Most of what has been recorded as unintelligible in the Quran is the product of three ordinary features of how the text writes, and the text supplies the key to each in its own words.

It is meant to be read straight through, and it is also meant to be usable in pieces. Part One is the method and everything downstream depends on it; a reader who skips it will find Part Two a list of assertions rather than a series of demonstrations. Part Two is twelve independent chapters and they may be read in any order. Each of them argues in prose and then closes on a single condensed table that carries the whole chapter in three columns: the verse and the word it turns on, the difficulty and what the commentaries left unsettled, and the root recovered with the structure read. A reader in a hurry can take the tables. A reader who wants the reasoning can take the prose. The tables are quick reference and the prose is the argument. Part One carries no tables, deliberately: it establishes a method rather than reading verses, and a method has to be followed rather than consulted. The counts it uses are gathered in Appendix B.

Nothing here requires Arabic. Every Arabic word that carries weight is given in transliteration with its meaning, and where a root matters the three consonants are given and what they name is stated. A reader with Arabic will be able to check every claim; a reader without it will be able to follow every argument. Where a claim rests on a count, the count is stated so that it can be checked: the phrase occurs twice in the Quran, the construction occurs once, the word appears at these four places and nowhere else. Those counts were executed against the full text rather than recalled, and they are the study's hardest evidence, because a count is not an interpretation.

Two conventions travel through every page. Honorifics are treated as parts of names rather than as ornaments: Allah ﷻ, the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, and the prophets, peace be upon them, marked AS. And a distinction is maintained throughout between what the text says, what a reading of the text proposes, and what is a premise the reading rests on. Those three are marked in plain speech rather than by symbols. When this study says the Quran states something, it means the words are there. When it says a reading holds, it means the reading is coherent and the reader may still weigh it. When it says something is a premise, it means it is assumed and not shown.

One thing this study does not do. It adjudicates no question of law, no question of sect, and no question about the identity of any person at the level where the Quran itself declines to speak. Where the text withholds, the withholding is reported and honored rather than filled. Several of the most famous difficulties in the list turn out to be exactly this, and a reader expecting the last door to open will find instead an account of why the text built it.

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PART ONE • THE METHOD

1 TWO INVENTORIES OF DIFFICULTY

What "difficult" has meant

There is a canonical list. It is not written down in one place, but any reader who works through the classical commentaries assembles substantially the same one, because the commentaries are longest exactly where the difficulty is greatest and shortest where the text is plain. Al-Ṭabarī gives a page to a verse and a hundred pages to another. The proportions themselves are a map.

That list has roughly a hundred and forty entries, and it sorts into twelve recognizable families. The passages the text itself declares opaque, beginning with the disconnected letters and the verse about ambiguity. The vision and theophany passages, where a prophet asks to see and is answered in a way that has never settled. The attribute passages, where a hand or a face or an establishing upon a throne is predicated of Allah ﷻ. The passages about the Spirit and the Word and the standing of ʿĪsā AS. The Adam AS narrative with its covenant and its trust. The decree passages, where human action and divine will are both asserted in the same breath. The passages the mystical tradition made load-bearing and the jurists found awkward. The cosmological passages. The narrative enigmas, from the cow of Sūrat al-Baqarah to the two-horned king. The eschatological passages and the intermediate state. The passages about the Prophet ﷺ himself and the mechanics of revelation. And the contested legal and social verses.

Those twelve are the tradition's own grouping and they are the inventory this study works from. The twelve chapters of Part Two are **not** a one-to-one map onto them, and it is worth saying so before a reader looks for one. Some of the classical families divide, since the vision passages belong partly with the attribute verses and partly with the verses the interior tradition built on. Some merge, since the eschatological family and the intermediate state are one question once the vocabulary is collated. And one chapter has no classical counterpart at all, because the verses that correct the Prophet ﷺ were never treated as a family, which is itself a fact worth having.

Two features of that list matter before anything else is said about it. The first is that the list is **transmitted**: each generation of commentators inherits the difficulties of the last, and a verse that became difficult in the third century of the tradition tends to remain difficult in the fourteenth, whatever the intervening scholarship. The second is that the list is **selected by dispute**. A verse enters it when communities fought over it. That is a real selection criterion and it captures something true, since verses worth fighting over are usually verses that carry weight. But it is not the only criterion available, and it is not the same as difficulty.

KEY POINT

The proportions of the classical commentaries are themselves a map. A page for one verse and a hundred for another is a record of where the difficulty sat.

A second inventory, assembled by a different selector

Consider a different way of finding hard verses. Instead of asking which verses generated controversy, ask which verses stop a reader who is working through the text on its own terms and who refuses to move on until a passage is coherent. That reader will halt in different places. He will halt where the classical list halts, at the

disconnected letters and the attribute verses, because those are genuinely hard. But he will also halt at places the controversy-list never marks.

He will halt at Q 8:29, *in tattaqū llāha yaj'al lakum furqānā*, if you guard yourselves toward Allah ﷻ. He will make for you a criterion, because the verse states that the faculty of discrimination is issued rather than acquired, which is a claim about how understanding works and is not treated as one. He will halt at Q 6:12 and Q 6:54, where mercy is described as inscribed by Allah ﷻ upon Himself ﷻ, because that construction occurs at exactly two places in the whole Quran and both of them are in one chapter, and because it puts the writer and the written-upon in the same clause. He will halt at Q 2:186, because it is the one question-verse in a long run of question-verses that does not carry the instruction "say", and the difference is not decorative. He will halt at Q 55:4, where the faculty of making-distinct is given to the human being, and then at Q 75:19, where the completion of the explanation is retained. He will halt at the phrase *illā bi-mā shā'* in Q 2:255, which occurs once in the entire text and which quietly opens a door in the middle of an absolute negation.

None of those is a famous crux. All of them stop a reader cold.

Assembled systematically, this second inventory turns out to be about the same size as the first and to overlap it by less than half. Three hundred and thirty-six distinct verses appear across the two lists together, and a substantial majority of the second list is absent from the first. Two selectors, running over one text, disagreeing on most of what they select.

Why the two disagree, and what each is measuring

The disagreement is informative and it is not a scandal about either list. The classical inventory measures **contested difficulty**: verses whose readings divided communities. The second inventory measures **structural obstruction**: verses at which a coherent reading cannot be assembled without doing something the reader had not planned to do. Those are different properties, and a verse can carry one, or the other, or both.

Q 3:7, the verse that divides firmly-established verses from ambiguous ones, carries both: it is a famous crux and it also stops a careful reader, because it appears to praise a feature of the text that ought to be a defect. Q 4:157 carries mostly the first: the passage is contested to the point of being a marker of community identity, and once the grammar is examined the structural obstruction is smaller than the controversy would suggest. Q 2:186 carries almost entirely the second: nobody fought over it, and a reader collating the question-verses of Sūrat al-Baqarah cannot get past it.

The second inventory has a recognizable shape, and naming that shape is the first useful result of this study, because it tells a reader where to look. Three signatures dominate it.

The stated-and-unglossed. A verse that says something mechanical outright and is passed over because it reads as exhortation. Q 8:29 states the mechanism by which understanding is granted. Q 20:15 attaches a purpose clause to the concealment of the Hour. Q 15:9 asserts preservation from inside the thing preserved. Each of these is a claim of the first importance, phrased in a way that makes it sound like encouragement.

The hinge in plain sight. A verse doing load-bearing work inside a passage everyone reads for something else. Q 33:43 sits thirteen verses above one of the most-discussed commands in the Quran and settles a question the command raises, and it is almost never read alongside it. Q 74:31 sits immediately after the most speculated-upon number in the text and states what the number is for.

The grammatical singleton. A construction the Quran uses once or twice in more than six thousand verses. These are invisible to reading and obvious to counting, which is exactly why the commentaries did not mark them. The phrase *mafātih al-ghayb*, the keys of the unseen, occurs once. The adjective *sharqiyy*, eastern, occurs twice. The word *muhaymin* occurs twice. The construction *kataba ‘alā nafsihī*, He wrote upon Himself ﷺ, occurs twice and both in one chapter. A reader cannot notice a singleton by reading. He can notice it in an afternoon with a concordance.

THE DISTINCTION THAT ORGANIZES EVERYTHING

Contested difficulty and structural obstruction are different properties of a text. A verse may carry one, or the other, or both, and the Quran does not sort them for anyone.

The claim of this study

The two inventories are treated here as one field, and the claim made about that field is single and it is testable.

Most of the difficulty in both inventories is produced by three features of how the Quran writes, and the text supplies the key to each in its own words. The first is that the Quran argues without quoting its opponents, so a rebuttal reads as a riddle until the claim being rebutted is restored. The second is that the Quran states the purpose of a hard verse in the adjacent clause and scopes its own universals inside the verse that carries them, so a difficulty produced by stopping one clause early is a difficulty of citation. The third is that the Quran defines its own disputed words at other places in itself, so a lexical dispute is often a dispute that a concordance ends.

One word in the claim above is doing quantitative work and is worth bounding before it is used. No census over all three hundred and thirty-six verses is offered here, and *most* is a claim about the families this study takes up rather than a measured proportion of the whole field. What is shown is that in every family Part Two treats, and those twelve families account for the bulk of both inventories, the difficulty resolves under one or more of the three. A reader who wants the proportion rather than the account will not find it here.

What survives all three is a residue, and the residue is small, marked, and defended, because the Quran's fourth practice is to build a limit and say so. This study treats that residue as content rather than as failure, and Part Three sets it out.

WHAT IS BEING CLAIMED, AND WHAT IS NOT

That most of the difficulty is in the reading rather than in the text. Not that all of it is. Part Three sets out what survives, and it includes several of the most famous items on the list.

2 FIVE KEYS

The five keys below are the whole method. Each is stated, each is grounded in something the Quran says about itself or does consistently, and each is demonstrated once here on a single case so that the reader knows what the operation looks like before Part Two runs it forty times.

None of the five requires anything the reader does not already have. There is no apparatus, no privileged transmission, no school. There is the text, the ability to look a word up in a concordance, and the discipline of reading to the end of a passage before deciding what it says.

Key One • The missing half of the argument

The Quran is a text in dispute. It answers, corrects, refuses, confirms, and mocks; it addresses named communities and unnamed opponents; and it very rarely reprints the claim it is answering. A reader who does not know this reads a rebuttal as an assertion, and an assertion with its premise removed is a riddle.

The Quran states this about itself, in the verse most often quoted for something else. *Wa lā ya'tūnaka bi-mathalin illā ji'nāka bi-l-ḥaqqi wa aḥsana tafsīrā*, they do not bring you a case except that We bring you the truth and a better explanation (Q 25:33). The famous half of that verse is *aḥsana tafsīrā*, a better explanation, which is regularly cited as the Quran's claim to interpret itself. The conditional half is rarely cited and it is the operative one. **The better explanation is not free-standing. It is issued against an incoming argument.** The explanation is response-shaped, and the response was printed while the argument was not.

Everything follows from that. When Q 9:30 reports that a community said a certain figure was a son of Allah ﷺ, the verse continues by typing its own claim: *dhālika qawluhum bi-afwāhihim yuḍābi'ūna qawla lladhīna kafarū min qablu*, that is their saying with their mouths, imitating an earlier saying. That is a report about a speech-act in a milieu, and it is not a census of what every member of a community formally believed. When Q 4:157 says *wa mā qatalūhu wa mā ṣalabūhu*, they did not kill him and they did not crucify him, the clause immediately before it names both the speakers and the claim: *wa qawlibhim innā qatalnā l-masīḥa 'īsā bna maryama rasūla llāh*, and their saying, we killed the Messiah. The verse is answering a **boast**, and a boast is a claim of agency.

Restoring the addressee is the single highest-yield operation in this study, and it is not speculative. In most cases the Quran names the addressee in the same passage, and where it does not, the class is usually recoverable from what is being denied.

The addressee classes are seven and they recur. The scholarly and covenantal community of Banū Isrā'īl. The Meccan cultic and mercantile establishment. The Christian communities and their monastic and delegation representatives. The internal Madinan opposition. A prior **text**, where the Quran is answering a verse or a narrative rather than a person. A **geopolitical pressure**, where an imperial war or a treaty or a tribute economy is in play. And an **authority claim**, where the question is what standing any book or any body has over the meaning of a text.

Demonstration. Sūrat al-Kawthar is three verses and its final word is *al-abtar*, the cut-off one, the man with no continuation. Read as an assertion it is a strange chapter: a gift is announced, a rite is commanded, and an insult is returned to an unnamed party. Read as a rebuttal it is transparent. Somebody in a society organized around lineage said that a man whose sons had died was cut off. The chapter answers by relocating what a

continuation is. And the Quran completes the answer elsewhere in its own words: *mā kāna muḥammadun abā aḥadīn min rijālikum wa lākin rasūla llāhi wa khātama l-nabiyyīn*, Muhammad ﷺ is not the father of any of your men, but the messenger of Allah ﷻ and the seal of the prophets (Q 33:40). The biological premise of the taunt is conceded outright and the continuation is moved to an office. The taunt said the line is cut. The answer says the line is not what was at stake.

KEY POINT

The famous half of Q 25:33 is *a better explanation*. The operative half is the conditional that precedes it. The explanation is issued **against** an incoming argument, and the argument was not reprinted.

Key Two • The sentence that follows

The Quran states the purpose of its hardest verses in the adjacent clause with a regularity that is difficult to overstate, and a large amount of classical difficulty is produced by quoting the difficulty and stopping before the purpose.

Six independent sites make the pattern, and the reader can verify each in a minute.

The number nineteen at Q 74:30 is followed at Q 74:31 by *wa mā ja'alnā aṣḥāba l-nāri illā malā'ikatan wa mā ja'alnā 'iddatāhum illā fitnatan li-lladhīna kafarū li-yastayqina lladhīna ūtū l-kitāba wa yazdāda lladhīna āmanū imānā*, and We made their number only a trial for those who disbelieve, so that those given the Book may attain certainty and those who believe may increase in faith. The count is issued with its office attached.

The trust offered to the heavens and the earth and the mountains at Q 33:72 is followed at Q 33:73 by *li-yu'adhbhiba llāhu l-munāfiqīna wa l-munāfiqāti wa l-mushrikīna wa l-mushrikāti wa yatūba llāhu 'alā l-mu'minīna wa l-mu'mināt*. The trust's stated function is that the classes separate.

The covenant of Q 7:172 gives its reason in the same breath, *an taqūlū yawma l-qiyāmati innā kunnā 'an ḥādhā ghāfilīn*, lest you say on the Day of Standing, we were heedless of this, and the next verse forecloses a second excuse, inherited association.

The change of prayer-direction at Q 2:142 is answered at Q 2:143 by *li-na'lama man yattabi'u l-rasūla mimman yanqalibu 'alā 'aqibayh*, so that We may distinguish who follows the messenger from who turns on his heels.

The transformation at Q 2:65 is typed at Q 2:66 as *nakālan li-mā bayna yadayhā wa mā khalfahā wa maw'izatan li-l-muttaqīn*, a deterrent-sign for those before it and after it.

And the act of Allah ﷻ and His angels described at Q 33:43 carries *li-yukhrijakum mina l-ẓulumāti ilā l-nūr*, to bring you out of darknesses into light. The act is described by what it does.

Three of those six state the same office. The number is a discriminator, the trust is a discriminator, the direction-change is a discriminator. That is not decoration; it is a text telling a reader what several of its hardest features are for.

Demonstration. The number nineteen has generated a literature. Read with its next verse it is not a cipher at all. The Quran says the count is a trial for one class, a certainty-producer for a second, and an increase for a third, and then adds that some will ask what Allah ﷻ intended by this as an example. A number issued as a

sorting-instrument is doing its work precisely when it produces division over itself, which is a fair description of its reception history. Whether the number carries a further significance is a separate question and this study does not settle it. What it does say is that the Quran already answered the question of what the number is **for**, one line later.

THE PATTERN, STATED ONCE

At six independent sites the Quran states the office of its own hardest verse in the adjacent clause. At three of the six the stated office is the same office: a discriminator.

Key Three • The word defined elsewhere

Where a disputed word carries the difficulty, the Quran very often defines that word at another place in itself, and the defining place is frequently one the commentaries did not consult because it is in a different chapter on a different subject.

Tawaffū at Q 3:55 has divided readers for centuries, because the verb is usually rendered as taking in death and the passage concerns ʿĪsā AS. The Quran defines it: *allāhu yatawaffā l-anfusa ḥīna mawtibā wa-llatī lam tamut fī manāmihā*, Allah ﷻ takes the souls at the time of their death, and those that did not die, in their sleep (Q 39:42). The verb means to take in full, to collect what is due, and the Quran supplies a non-death instance of it in its own voice. The lexical dispute is ended by concordance rather than by school. What the passage then means about the event is a separate question and is treated in Chapter 7.

Mā qatalūhu at Q 4:157 has the same shape. The Quran uses the identical construction of the battle of Badr, where the killing is not in dispute by anyone: *fa-lam taqtulūhum wa lākinna llāha qatalahum wa mā ramayta idh ramayta wa lākinna llāha ramā*, you did not kill them but Allah ﷻ killed them, and you did not throw when you threw but Allah ﷻ threw (Q 8:17). Men fell at Badr and a handful of dust was thrown. The construction denies **agency**, not event.

Yuṣallī ʿalā at Q 33:56 is fixed thirteen verses above at Q 33:43, in the same chapter, with the same construction and the believing community as its object.

Thālithu thalātha, third of three, condemned at Q 5:73, has exactly one sibling in the Quran: *wa Manāta l-thālithata l-ukhrā*, and Manāt the third, the other (Q 53:20), a named pre-Islamic triad. The Quran's own usage shows what form of speech is being barred.

Demonstration. Take Q 33:56 and its command to invoke blessing upon the Prophet ﷺ. A long convention holds that the specific act named by the verb is reserved to him. Thirteen verses earlier, in the same chapter, stands *huwa lladhī yuṣallī ʿalaykum wa malāʾikatuhu*, He it is who does this toward **you**, and His angels. One verb governs Allah ﷻ and the angels together at both places, so the verb cannot mean petition, since Allah ﷻ does not petition; the sense that carries both subjects is the inclining-toward that the root supplies. And the object at Q 33:43 is the believing community. The asymmetry between the two verses is real and it is about what the reader is **ordered to do**, not about what any prophet receives. The concordance settles the lexical half in an afternoon.

Key Four • The quantifier that carries its own limits

Several of the most-cited contradictions in the Quran are produced by lifting a universal quantifier out of the verse that scopes it. The scoping is not elsewhere and it is not inferred. It is in the same sentence.

Kullu nafsīn dhā'iqatu l-mawt, every soul shall taste death, is set against the fact that Allah ﷻ speaks of *nafsī*, My self, at Q 5:116, and writes mercy *'alā nafsīhi*, upon His self, at Q 6:12 and Q 6:54. Run the count. The phrase occurs at exactly three places, and **all three carry a class-marker in the same verse**. Q 3:185 continues with a recompense clause, *wa innamā tuwaffawna ujūrakum yawma l-qiyāmah*. Q 21:35 continues with a trial-and-return clause, *wa nablūkum bi-l-sharri wa-l-khayri fitnatan wa ilaynā turja'un*. Q 29:57 continues with a return clause, *thumma ilaynā turja'un*. Not one occurrence stands bare. The Quran never asserts the unrestricted proposition that the contradiction requires.

Wa mā tashā'ūna illā an yashā'a llāh, you do not will unless Allah ﷻ wills, is read as erasing human volition. Run the count. The sentence occurs at exactly two places, Q 76:30 and Q 81:29, and **at both of them the human-will clause stands immediately before it**. Q 76:29 reads *inna hādbihi tadhkiratun fa-man shā'a ttakhadha ilā rabbihi sabīlā*, this is a reminder, so whoever wills may take a way to his Lord ﷻ. Q 81:28 reads *li-man shā'a minkum an yastaqīm*, for whoever among you wills to go straight. Two occurrences, two adjacencies, no exception. The Quran never issues the sovereignty clause bare, and a citation of Q 76:30 without Q 76:29 is a citation of half a sentence.

Kullu shay'in hālikun illā wajhah, everything perishes except His face (Q 28:88), read beside *kullu man 'alayhā fān*, everyone upon it passes away (Q 55:26), and *wa yabqā wajhu rabbik*, and the face of your Lord ﷻ remains (Q 55:27), shows the same discipline at the vocabulary level: the perishing-law and the death-law are stated of *shay'* and *nafs*, and the remaining term is *wajh*, which the Quran never places under either law.

Demonstration. The most famous version of this contradiction is the one about the human will, and it can be settled in front of a reader in ten seconds by reading two verses instead of one. Every count used in this chapter, with the sites listed and the method stated, is gathered in Appendix B. Whatever the theology of divine and human willing turns out to be, the Quran states both halves in adjacent sentences at both of the two places where it states either, which is a design choice and not an accident.

THE CHEAPEST CORRECTION IN THE STUDY

Two of the most-cited contradictions in the Quran are ended by reading one more clause. Both are produced by lifting a universal out of the verse that scopes it.

Key Five • The wall with a door in it

At its most absolute negations the Quran attaches an exception, and the exception is always held on the far side. This is the most striking single pattern in the study and it is invisible to reading, because each of the constructions involved occurs once or twice in the entire text.

Man dhā lladhī yashfa'u 'indahū illā bi-idhnih, who can intercede with Him ﷻ except by His leave (Q 2:255). The key is a permission granted.

Wa lā yuḥīṭūna bi-shay’in min ‘ilmihī illā bi-mā shā’, they encompass nothing of His knowledge except what He wills (Q 2:255). The phrase *illā bi-mā shā’* occurs **once in the entire Quran**, here.

Wa ‘indahu mafātiḥu l-ghaybi lā ya‘lamuhā illā huw, with Him ﷻ are the keys of the unseen, none knows them but He (Q 6:59). The phrase *mafātiḥ al-ghayb* occurs **once**. The exception to the negation is the One doing the negating.

Lā ya‘lamu man fī l-samāwāti wa-l-arḍi l-ghayba illā llāh, none in the heavens and the earth knows the unseen except Allah ﷻ (Q 27:65). That construction occurs **once**.

Fa-lā yuzḥiru ‘alā ghaybihi aḥadan illā mani rtaḍā min rasūl, He discloses His unseen to no one, except one He has approved as a messenger (Q 72:26-27). **Once**, and the verb is a passive of approval: one who **was** approved.

Wa lā tanfa‘u l-shafā‘atu ‘indahu illā li-man adbina lah, intercession does not avail with Him ﷻ except for one He has permitted (Q 34:23). **Once**.

Subḥāna llāhi ‘ammā yaṣifūn, *illā ‘ibāda llāhi l-mukblaṣīn*, glory to Allah ﷻ above what they describe, except the servants of Allah ﷻ made pure (Q 37:159-160). The refrain *‘ammā yaṣifūn* occurs at **six** places in the Quran, and the exception follows exactly **one** of them.

Seven doors, and one word is doing two jobs in this section, so it is worth separating them. The five keys of this chapter are a reader's instruments. The keys in these seven verses are the text's own, and they are held on the far side. Every one of them is source-side by grammar and not by piety: a permission granted, a will exercised, the One negating standing as the sole exception to His own negation, one who was approved, one who was permitted, and a class named by a passive participle, *mukblaṣ*, one who was **made** sincere, which is why nobody enters that class by announcing that he is in it.

There is no handle on the near side of any of the seven. That is the whole architecture of the Quran's reticence stated as a grammatical family rather than as a doctrine, and it is checkable by anyone who declines to take an author's word for it.

The seven are gathered with their counts in Appendix B, and they recur twice in what follows: at Chapter 15, where the adversary's own oath supplies one of them from an unexpected side, and at Chapter 16, where they are read together as the text's own account of why it keeps anything.

THE SINGLE MOST STRIKING PATTERN IN THE STUDY

Seven absolute negations, seven attached doors, and the text holds every one of those doors' keys on the far side. Most of the constructions occur once in more than six thousand verses, which is why reading never found them and counting does.

3 THE THREE PARTS OF A CLAIM

The five keys of Chapter 2 handle difficulties of citation, scope, and vocabulary. A residue remains that they do not touch, and it is the residue that has produced the deepest theological argument: passages where nothing is being mis-cited and no word is in doubt, and the difficulty is that the claim itself will not compose.

This chapter supplies the instrument for that residue. It requires no mathematics and no special training. It is a way of looking at a sentence that most readers already use without naming it, made explicit so that it can be applied deliberately.

Three parts, and the test that finds them

Take any complete factual claim. *The kettle is boiling on the stove.* It has three separable parts and they cannot be reduced to fewer.

There is **what stands**: the kettle, the thing the claim says is there.

There is **what moves**: the boiling, what the thing does or undergoes.

There is **how the two are joined**: on the stove, the relation that binds them and locates the act with respect to the thing.

The test that shows the three are irreducible is deletion. Remove the kettle and *is boiling on the stove* has no subject and states nothing. Remove the boiling and *the kettle on the stove* is not a claim at all. Remove the joining and *the kettle is boiling* has lost the relation, which in this case was carrying real information about where and how. Three slots, each of which leaves an incoherent residue when removed. That is what it means to say a claim has three parts.

A second condition matters as much as the count. **The three parts must not be made of the same material.** If the words filling the second slot are just the words of the first slot restated, then the claim has two parts wearing three coats, and it will look complete and mean less than it appears to. *The boiling water is boiling* has a subject and a predicate and states nothing, because the act was smuggled into the thing.

That is the entire instrument: **three parts, genuinely distinct, and joined.** It is worth saying what it is not for. The test applies to a passage that asserts something, and a great deal of the Quran does not: an oath, an imperative, a question, a direct address, and a narrative sentence carrying the story forward are not claims, and the three-part test has nothing to take hold of in them. Where this study applies the instrument to a narrative or to a single word, what is being tested is the claim the passage is read as making and not the sentence itself; and where a passage makes no claim, the instrument is silent rather than negative. A silence of the instrument is a report about the instrument's reach and never a finding that the passage is empty. When a reading has all three and they compose, the reading closes. When it does not, the failure will be one of exactly three kinds.

THE INSTRUMENT IN ONE LINE

Three parts, genuinely distinct, and joined. Everything in Part Two is that sentence applied.

The three failures

Failure one, collapse. Two of the three parts have been folded into one. The claim then appears to say something and is actually circular. This is the failure behind a great deal of theological difficulty, and it usually happens when a relation is quietly turned into an identity. When somebody says of a text that its meaning simply is the tradition's understanding of it, the thing and the relation have been collapsed, and there is no longer a way for the tradition to be wrong about the text, which is a loss of content dressed as a gain in security.

Failure two, the smuggled fourth. A term has been introduced that belongs to a different kind of question, and the claim now has a part that does not fit the other three. The clearest cases in this material involve importing a category the text does not carry: reading a first-century Greek metaphysical term into a Semitic idiom, or reading a modern natural-against-supernatural distinction into a text whose categories are hidden and manifest. The claim does not become false. It fails to parse.

Failure three, the boundary read as a defect. Two registers that the text is deliberately keeping apart are treated as one register with a contradiction in it. **Register** is used throughout this study in one sense and it is worth fixing here, since the third failure mode is defined in terms of it: a register is a level at which a claim or a judgment sits. A text may state two things at two levels without contradicting itself, and a judgment may be correct at its own level and inapplicable at another. Both of those recur, and both are what this failure mode names. This is the most common failure in the material of this study and the most consequential. The text is not being incoherent; it is drawing a line, and the line is content. Chapter 16 is devoted to it.

Applying it: the two seas

Q 55:19-20 says *maraja l-bahrayni yaltaqiyān, baynahunā barzakhun lā yabghiyān*, He let the two seas run so that they meet, between them a barrier they do not overrun. Q 25:53 says the same with one sweet and one bitter. This has been read as a puzzle about oceanography and as a puzzle about mysticism, and neither reading is needed.

Run the three parts. What stands: two bodies of water, each with its own character, one sweet and one salt. What moves: the meeting, *yaltaqiyān*, which is an active verb and not a passive separation. How they are joined: the barrier.

The reading closes at once, and it closes in a way that inverts the usual reception. **The barrier is not what prevents the meeting. It is what makes a meeting possible at all.** Remove it and there are not two seas meeting; there is one sea, and the meeting is the thing that was lost. Two things can only meet if they remain two.

That single result generalizes across a large part of this study. Nearly every place where the Quran is accused of separating what should be joined turns out to carry the same structure: a distinction preserved so that a relation can exist. It is the structure of the intermediate state between death and rising. It is the structure of the fast at Q 2:187, where distinction is suspended by night and in force by day. And it is the structure of the negation-and-affirmation at Q 42:11, which says in one breath *laysa ka-mithlihi shay'*, nothing resembles Him ﷻ, and *wa huwa l-samī'u l-baṣīr*, and He ﷻ is the Hearing, the Seeing. The verse is not hedging. It is holding two things apart so that both can be said.

THE RESULT THAT GENERALIZES

Two things can only meet if they remain two. The barrier is not what prevents the meeting; it is what makes a meeting possible.

Applying it: what the third slot is doing in the attribute verses

Consider *yadu llāhi fawqa aydihim*, the hand of Allah ﷻ is above their hands (Q 48:10). The difficulty is famous and the classical responses ran from literalism to allegory to a refusal to specify.

Run the three parts, and note first what the verse is actually about. The clause stands inside a pledge. Men are clasping hands in a compact. What stands: the parties and the pledge. What moves: the pledging, an act performed by clasping. How they are joined: the clasp itself, and the verse's claim is about what the clasp is doing at a second register.

The claim composes without anatomy and without allegory, because **it was never a claim about a body part; it was a claim about a relation**. A hand in a pledge scene is not an appendage, it is the instrument by which an agreement is made binding, which is why English has *shake on it* and *the hand of the king* and *by his own hand*. The Quran's other uses of the term run the same way: *bi-yadika l-khayr*, in Your hand is the good (Q 3:26), stands in a verse about giving and withdrawing dominion, which is a verse about disposal and not about grasping.

This is not a softening. Nothing is being explained away and no clause is being reduced to a figure of speech. What is being said is that the third slot, the joining, is where the verse's information lives, and a reader who puts the verse's information into the first slot has moved it into the wrong part of the claim and then found it strange there.

The limits of the instrument, stated before it is used forty times

Three limits, and they are load-bearing rather than modest.

It tests coherence and not truth. That a reading composes means the reading holds together. It does not mean the claim is true, and it does not mean a rival reading fails. A perfectly coherent reading can rest on a premise a reader declines. Where this study says a reading closes, that is what is being said and nothing more.

It says nothing about direction. The instrument shows that three parts stand distinct and compose. It cannot by itself tell a reader which way a claim points, because a claim and its exact denial have the same structure. Direction comes from the words, from the sequence of the passage, and from what the text elsewhere affirms. This matters because it is the reason the study never treats a structural result as settling a doctrinal question.

It does not reach the questions the text places beyond it. The instrument works on claims. Where the Quran declines to make a claim, or declares that something is withheld, there is nothing for the instrument to operate on, and applying it anyway would produce a manufactured result. Chapter 16 handles those places, and it handles them by reporting the withholding rather than by working around it.

A CAUTION THAT IS LOAD-BEARING

A reading that closes is a reading that holds together. That is not the same as being true, and this study never treats a structural result as settling a doctrinal question.

PART TWO • THE FAMILIES OF DIFFICULTY

4 THE TEXT'S OWN LIMITS

A small number of passages are difficult because the Quran made them difficult on purpose and said so. They are the natural place to begin, because a reader who mistakes a deliberate limit for an accidental obscurity will spend a lifetime trying to open a door the text describes as locked, and because the Quran's handling of these places tells us a great deal about how it handles everything else.

The letters that spell nothing

Twenty-nine chapters open with disconnected Arabic letters. *Alif lām mīm. Hā mīm. Ṭā hā. Šād. Qāf. Nūn.* They are recited as letter-names rather than as words, they form no lexical item, and no proposal about their meaning has ever commanded agreement.

The commentaries hold, roughly, four positions: that they are abbreviations of divine names, that they are oaths, that they are attention-markers, and that their meaning is known to Allah ﷻ alone. The last of these is the majority position and it is usually stated as a concession.

There is a distributional fact about them that reading cannot show and counting can. Executed over the full text: **of the twenty-nine chapters that open with disconnected letters, twenty-five carry a reference to the Book, the Recitation, or the Pen within the opening verse and the three that follow**, usually in the very next clause. *Alif lām mīm. That is the Book, no doubt in it. Alif lām rā. Those are the signs of the Book. Hā mīm. A sending down of the Book. Šād. By the Quran, holder of the reminder. Qāf. By the glorious Quran. Nūn. By the pen and what they inscribe.* The exceptions are chapters 19, 29, 30, and 42, each of which opens on a different subject.

The criterion is worth stating exactly, because the last unit of that result moves with it. Counting the three nouns alone, *kitāb* at any definiteness, *qur'ān*, and *qalam*, the figure is twenty-five and the exceptions are the four just named. Admitting the verbs of sending down and revealing alongside the nouns raises the figure to twenty-six and removes Q 42, whose third verse says *kadhālika yūḥī ilayka*, thus He reveals to you, which is a revelation reference and none of the three nouns. Narrowing the window to the single verse after the letters drops the figure to twenty-three. The shape of the result is stable across that range and its last unit is not, and both of those facts belong on the page rather than behind it.

Twenty-five of twenty-nine, or twenty-six on the wider criterion, is a design and not a coincidence, and it tells us what the letters are doing even if it does not tell us what they mean. **They stand at the seam where the raw material meets the claim.** Here are the sounds, unassembled, the same stock every Arab poet was using; and here is the Book. That reading is reinforced by the challenge the Quran issues repeatedly to produce something comparable, at Q 2:23, Q 10:38, Q 11:13, and Q 17:88, a challenge addressed to a culture whose central prestige was command of exactly this material.

What the letters spell, if they spell anything, this study does not claim to know, and it makes no claim on that point at all. That the majority of classical readers arrived at the same silence is noted here and carries no weight, since a consensus is not evidence in either direction. What the letters **do** is visible in a concordance.

THE COUNT

Of the twenty-nine chapters opening with disconnected letters, **twenty-five** carry a reference to the Book, the Recitation, or the Pen within the opening verse and the three that follow. The exceptions are chapters 19, 29, 30, and 42. Admitting the verbs of sending down alongside the three nouns raises the figure to twenty-six and removes 42.

The verse about ambiguity, and its own reader-sorting

Q 3:7 divides the Book into *muhkamāt*, firmly established verses that are the mother of the Book, and *mutashābihāt*, verses that resemble one another. It then says that those in whose hearts is deviation pursue the ambiguous ones seeking discord and seeking their interpretation. And it closes on a sentence whose punctuation has been argued for centuries: *wa mā ya'lamu ta'wīlahu illā llāhu wa-l-rāsikhūna fī l-'ilmi yaqūlūna āmannā bih*, none knows its interpretation but Allah ﷻ, and those firmly rooted in knowledge say we believe in it. Whether the firmly-rooted are included in the knowing or begin a new sentence turns on where the reader pauses, and both readings have been held by major authorities.

Two observations settle more than the pause does.

The first is that **the verse names its own misuser inside itself**. It does not merely describe a property of the text; it describes a property of a reader, a deviation in the heart, and it identifies that deviation as the mechanism by which an ambiguous verse becomes a weapon. The ambiguity is therefore functioning as a filter, and the verse says so.

The second is that whichever way the pause falls, **what the firmly-rooted are shown doing is fixed and undisputed**. They say: we believe in it, all of it is from our Lord ﷻ. That is the conduct the verse exhibits, and it is the same conduct whether or not they are also among the knowers. The grammar leaves the pause open and the verse settles the practice by demonstration. A rule that includes its own hard case, and shows what to do at it rather than only stating it, is a complete rule.

There is a second Quranic statement about resemblance that is usually set against this one and should not be. Q 39:23 calls the whole Book *mutashābihan mathāniya*, self-resembling and doubled. That looks like a contradiction of Q 3:7 until the grammatical position is noticed: at Q 3:7 *mutashābihāt* is a **subset term**, a class standing against another class, while at Q 39:23 *mutashābihan* is predicated of the **whole** and paired with a word from the root meaning to fold. Consistency-with-itself said of the whole and mirror-facedness said of a part are two readings of one root at two positions, and the same verse calls the Book the best of discourse, which is not the language of apology.

KEY POINT

Whichever way the celebrated pause falls, what the firmly-rooted are shown **doing** is fixed and undisputed. The grammar leaves the pause open and the verse settles the practice by demonstration.

The Spirit

Yas'alūnaka 'ani l-rūḥ, quli l-rūḥu min amri rabbī wa mā ūtītum minā l-ilmī illā qalīlā, they ask you about the Spirit; say, the Spirit is from the command of my Lord ﷻ, and you have been given of knowledge only a little (Q 17:85).

The question is put and refused in the same verse, which is unusual enough. What is more unusual is a distributional fact that the refusal is not usually read alongside. At Q 70:4, Q 78:38, and Q 97:4, *al-rūḥ* is coordinated **with** *al-malā'ika*, the angels, by the conjunction *wa*. Coordination in Arabic as in English marks distinction: *the angels and the Spirit* is not *the angels, that is, the Spirit*. Three times, in three chapters, the Quran declines the identification that later readers regularly supply.

So the withholding is doubled. The direct question is refused in the text's own voice, and the identification most often used to fill the gap is declined three times by grammar. What the Quran does state is a **function**: a spirit is sent, and what it delivers is a word. *Fa-arsalnā ilayhā rūḥanā* at Q 19:17. *Nazala bihi l-rūḥu l-amīn* at Q 26:193. *Nazzalahu rūḥu l-quḍusī min rabbika bi-l-ḥaqq* at Q 16:102. And at Q 26:194 and Q 2:97 the delivery lands upon the heart. One operation, several sites, a conveyance and never an origination.

This study therefore reports the function as stated and reports the person as unstated, and it does so because the Quran does exactly that. Filling the second from the commentaries would be substituting a later consensus for a refusal the text placed in its own text.

The sleepers, and a count the text refuses

The story of the companions of the cave at Q 18:9-26 has a peculiarity that is more interesting than the story's unidentified details. At Q 18:22 the Quran itself runs through the guesses about how many they were, three, five, seven, each with the dog added, and then says *qul rabbī a'lamu bi-'iddatihim mā ya'lamuhum illā qalīl*, say, my Lord ﷻ knows best their number; only a few know them. And then it instructs the reader: *fa-lā tumāri fihim illā mirā'an ḡāhiran wa lā tastafti fihim minhum aḥadā*, so do not dispute about them except a plain dispute, and do not seek a ruling about them from any of them.

That is an instruction not to litigate the details of a story the Quran has just told. It is unique in the text and it is the model for a whole class of cases: the unfixed word *al-raḡīm* in the same passage, the identity of the two-horned figure a few pages later, the people of al-Rass elsewhere. The passage that contains the largest number of unresolvable details also contains the only explicit instruction about what to do with unresolvable details, which is a piece of design a reader should not walk past.

THE ONLY INSTRUCTION OF ITS KIND

The passage with the largest number of unresolvable details also carries the Quran's only explicit rule about what to do with an unresolvable detail.

The number

Q 74:30 says *'alayhā tis'ata 'ashar*, over it are nineteen. Chapter 2 has already given the reading: Q 74:31 states what the count is for, and no arithmetic gloss is offered anywhere in the Quran for any number. It is worth adding here what the wider survey of numbers shows, because it makes the point sharper. Across the Quran's issued counts, the eight bearing the throne at Q 69:17, the seven earths at Q 65:12, the eleven stars at Q 12:4,

the three hundred and nine years at Q 18:25, the thousand months at Q 97:3, the fifty thousand years at Q 70:4, the text does exactly two things and never a third. **At Q 74:31 it states a count's function. At Q 18:22 it refuses a count and forbids litigation of it.** Both of those are statements about counting rather than about a number. Chapter 10 develops this.

What this family has in common

Five passages, one shape. In each case the Quran does something that a text trying to appear omniscient would not do: it marks a limit, defends it, and in three of the five states what would be needed to cross it. The letters stand beside the claim they illustrate and their content is not offered. The ambiguity verse names its own abuser and exhibits the right conduct at the hard case. The Spirit question is refused in the answer's own words. The sleepers' count is refused and the refusal is legislated. The number is given with a purpose and no key.

That is a consistent policy, and a consistent policy is not an absence of one. Part Three returns to it.

THE POLICY

Mark the limit, defend it, and in several cases state what would be needed to cross it. A consistent policy is not an absence of one.

TABLE 1 | CHAPTER 4 • THE TEXT'S OWN LIMITS

Passage	The knot	What the text does with it
2:1 and twenty-eight parallels · <i>aliflām mīm, hā mīm, ṭā hā, ṣād, qāf, nūn</i>	Letter-names that form no word, recited for fourteen centuries with no agreed sense. Four classical positions, none commanding assent, and the majority answer, that the meaning is with Allah ﷻ, offered as a concession rather than as a reading	The distribution answers the question the commentaries could not. Twenty-five of the twenty-nine carry a reference to the Book, the Recitation, or the Pen within the opening verse and the three that follow , the exceptions being 19, 29, 30, and 42; admitting the verbs of sending down raises the figure to twenty-six and removes 42, and the criterion is stated in the chapter because the last unit moves with it. <i>Dhālika l-kitāb. Tilka āyātu l-kitāb. Tanzīlu l-kitāb. Wa-l-qalami wa mā yasturūn.</i> The letters stand at the seam where the raw phonemic stock meets the claim made about it, which is precisely the challenge issued at Q 2:23 and Q 17:88 to a culture whose prestige was command of that stock. What the letters do is visible in a concordance; what they spell stays where the majority left it
3:7 · <i>muḥkamāt</i> against <i>mutashābihāt</i> , and the pause at <i>illā llāh</i>	A Book that praises a feature of itself which ought to be a defect, and a sentence whose sense turns on where the reader stops. Major authorities held both pausings and neither could be established from the verse	The verse names its own misuser inside itself, <i>alladhīna fī qulūbihim zaygh</i> , so the ambiguity is functioning as a filter and the verse says so. And the pause is beside the point: what the firmly rooted are shown doing is fixed either way , <i>āmannā bihi kullun min 'indi rabbīnā</i> . What stands : two classes of verse and two classes of reader. What moves : the pursuit of the ambiguous. How they are joined : the deviation in the heart. A rule that carries its own hard

Passage	The knot	What the text does with it
		case and exhibits the right conduct at it is a complete rule
39:23 · <i>mutashābihan mathāniya</i> , the whole Book called self-resembling	Read as flatly contradicting Q 3:7, which makes resemblance a property of a subset and a source of danger	Two grammatical positions for one root. At Q 3:7 <i>mutashābihāt</i> is a subset term standing against another class; at Q 39:23 <i>mutashābihan</i> is predicated of the whole and paired with <i>mathāniya</i> , from ث-ن-ى, to fold and double back. Consistency of the whole and mirror-facedness of a part are two readings, not one claim asserted and denied, and the same verse calls the Book the best of discourse
17:85 · <i>quli l-rūḥu min amri rabbī</i>	A direct question refused in the same verse, and the refusal then routinely filled from the commentaries with an identification the Quran does not make	The withholding is doubled, and the second half is a count. At Q 70:4, Q 78:38, and Q 97:4 <i>al-rūḥ</i> is coordinated with <i>al-malā'ika</i> by <i>wa</i> , and coordination marks distinction. Three times, in three chapters, the text declines the identification later readers supply. What it does state is a function, across four sites: a spirit is sent and what it delivers is a word, Q 19:17, Q 26:193, Q 16:102, landing upon the heart at Q 26:194 and Q 2:97. Conveyance, and the origination of nothing. Function stated, person unstated
18:9-26 · the sleepers, the disputed count, and <i>al-raqīm</i>	A narrative dense with details nobody can fix, filled at length from the surrounding literature	The passage carries the Quran's only explicit instruction about an unfixable detail. It runs the guesses itself at Q 18:22, three, five, seven, refuses them, <i>qul rabbī a'lamu bi-'iddatihim</i> , and then legislates: <i>fa-lā tumāri fihim illā mirā'an ḡābiran wa lā tastafti fihim minhum aḥadā</i> . The story with the most unresolvable details is the story that tells the reader what to do with unresolvable details
74:30-31 · <i>'alayhā tis'ata 'ashar</i>	A bare number that has generated a literature of proposed arithmetic keys	The office is stated one line later: a <i>fitna</i> for one class, a certainty-producer for those given the Book, an increase for the believers. What stands: a stated count. What moves: its reception. How they are joined: the sorting it performs. A number issued as a sorting-instrument is doing its work when it divides opinion over itself, which is a fair description of its history. No arithmetic gloss is offered here or anywhere in the Quran
The family read together	Whether a text that withholds is a text that fell short	Five passages, one policy: mark the limit, defend it, and in three of the five state what would be needed to cross it. The letters stand beside the claim and their content is not offered. The ambiguity verse names its abuser and exhibits the right conduct. The Spirit question is refused in the answer's own words. The count is refused and the refusal is legislated. The number is given with a purpose and no key. A consistent policy is not an absence of one

5 HANDS, FACE, AND THRONE

No family of verses produced more theological literature and fewer settled results. A hand above hands. Two hands that fashioned. A face that remains when everything perishes. Eyes under which a vessel was built. A shin uncovered on a day of crisis. An establishing upon a throne. And through it all, a text that says *laysa kamithlibi shay*, nothing whatever resembles Him ﷻ (Q 42:11).

The classical positions are well known. Some affirmed the terms and declined to specify how, some read them as figures for power and favor and dominion, some declared the whole class of terms consigned to Allah ﷻ. Each position solves part of the problem and pays for it somewhere else. The literalist reading protects the text's wording and strains against Q 42:11. The figurative reading protects Q 42:11 and treats a large body of the text as ornament. The consignment position is honest and produces no reading at all.

Where the difficulty actually sits

Chapter 3 gave the instrument, and it locates the difficulty precisely. **Every one of these terms is being read as occupying the first slot, the thing that stands, when the verse is putting it in the third slot, the joining.**

Take the pledge verse again. *Yadu llāhi fawqa aydihim* (Q 48:10) stands inside a scene of men clasping hands to make a compact binding. In that scene the hand is not an anatomical fact about any party; it is **the instrument by which the agreement becomes binding**, which is why a clasp and not a signature is what is described. The verse's claim is that a second binding is in force above the one the parties are performing. Read into the first slot the verse produces a body. Read into the third it produces a claim about the pledge, which is what the passage is about.

Take *bi-yadika l-khayr*, in Your hand is the good (Q 3:26). The verse is about giving and withdrawing dominion, about elevating and abasing. Every clause around the phrase concerns **disposal**. A hand in a disposal context names the capacity to give and take, which is why the same idiom exists in every language with kings in it.

Take *wa-ṣna'i l-fulka bi-a'yuninā*, build the ark under Our eyes (Q 11:37). The context is a construction project undertaken against ridicule, and the clause's work is to say the building is **witnessed and underwritten**. Eyes in that position name attention and protection, not organs.

Take *yawma yukshafu 'an sāq*, a day when a shin is uncovered (Q 68:42). The idiom is one of emergency: a garment gathered up because the moment has become one in which nobody stands about. The verse's information is about the character of the day and the demand it makes, and the clause immediately following, *wa yud'awna ilā l-sujūdi fa-lā yastaṭī'ūn*, and they are called to prostrate and cannot, confirms that the passage is about a demand met with incapacity.

None of that is a softening and none of it removes a word from the text. It is the observation that these clauses carry their information in the relation and that a reader who moves the information into the thing has moved it to the wrong slot and then found it strange there.

THE DIAGNOSIS

Every term in this family is being read into the first slot, the thing that stands, when the verse is putting it into the third, the joining.

The one place where the terms are not a figure, and the Quran marks it

There is a class of verses in this family that resists the treatment above, and this study does not pretend otherwise. The Quran does not merely use occasional bodily idioms. It attributes to Allah ﷻ something with the shape of a complete personal structure. A bounded interior that holds contents, *nafs*, which can be written upon and about which knowledge is asserted. A surface, *wajh*. Instruments. A stance. Perception. And at Q 3:18, reflexive self-testimony: *shahida llāhu annahu lā ilāha illā huw*, Allah ﷻ testifies that there is no god but He.

Nothing in the figurative reading accounts for the completeness of that structure, and a study that only produced the figurative reading would be reporting half the data.

What the Quran does with it is more interesting than either classical option, and it is visible in the vocabulary rather than in the doctrine. **The text runs its mortality-law and its perishing-law on two specific words, and the word it uses for what remains is never placed under either law.**

Kullu nafsin dhā'iqatu l-mawt, every *nafs* tastes death (Q 3:185, Q 21:35, Q 29:57). *Kullu shay'in hālikun illā wajhah*, every *shay'* perishes except His *wajh* (Q 28:88). *Kullu man 'alayhā fān, wa yabqā wajhu rabbika dhū l-jalāli wa-l-ikrām*, everyone upon it passes, and the *wajh* of your Lord ﷻ remains (Q 55:26-27).

Two vocabularies, two layers, no overlap. And then, precisely at the hinge, the Quran writes mercy onto the bounded layer: *kataba 'alā nafsihi l-rahmah*, He has written mercy upon His self (Q 6:12 and Q 6:54). Executed over the full text, that construction occurs at **exactly two places and both are in one chapter.**

So the Quran attributes a complete personal structure, applies its death-law to a term it uses for the bounded layer, applies its perishing-law to a term for things, and reserves a third term for what remains, which it never subjects to either law. That is a distinction being maintained with care, over hundreds of verses, and it is the reason Q 5:116 can put *nafs* on both sides of an exchange, *ta'lamu mā fī nafsī wa lā a'lamu mā fī nafsik*, You know what is in my self and I do not know what is in Your self, without the text considering that it has contradicted Q 3:185.

Two things must be said about this reading and both are limits.

The first is that the quantifier objection dissolves before the reading is even needed. As Chapter 2 showed, all three occurrences of *kullu nafsin dhā'iqatu l-mawt* carry a class-marker inside the same verse, a recompense clause, a trial-and-return clause, a return clause. The Quran never states the unrestricted proposition. So the apparent contradiction is a citation problem first, and the layer reading is what explains why the text is careful about it rather than what rescues the text from it.

The second is that this reading is a reading and not a proof. A grammarian may hold that the two uses of *nafs* are simply two senses of one word, as English *self* is, and nothing in the grammar forbids that. What this study observes is that the vocabulary discipline is consistent across the whole text, that a great many independent passages line up on it, and that the reading which takes the discipline seriously explains more of

the data than the reading which treats it as coincidence. That is a strong reason and it is not a demonstration, and the difference is stated rather than blurred.

THE VOCABULARY DISCIPLINE

The death-law runs on *nafs*. The perishing-law runs on *shay'*. The term for what remains is *wajh*, and the Quran never places it under either law.

Establishing upon the throne

Al-raḥmānu 'alā l-'arshi stawā, the Merciful ﷻ established Himself upon the throne (Q 20:5, and seven parallel places). Mālik's reported answer, that the establishing is known, the how is unknown, belief in it is obligatory, and asking about it is an innovation, is the most famous sentence in the whole controversy.

The structural reading adds one observation to it. Every one of the eight *istawā* passages sits inside an account of **completed making followed by ordering**. Q 7:54 is the clearest: the heavens and the earth in six days, then the establishing, then the night covering the day in pursuit, then the sun and moon and stars subjected by command. The clause stands at the junction between making and governing, and a throne in every Semitic idiom is the seat from which rule is exercised and not a piece of furniture.

So what the clause carries is a **transition of register**: creation completed, government in force. That is not a metaphor substituted for the word, and it is not a claim about the *how*, which Mālik's answer already handles. It is the observation that the clause is doing structural work at the joint between two accounts, and that the reader who asks what it says about a seated body has asked a question the passage is not built to answer.

Reading the earlier scriptures here, and why they appear

The Hebrew Bible speaks in exactly these terms, and does so constantly. An outstretched arm. A bared holy arm before the nations. A hand that is not shortened. Eyes running to and fro through the earth. A face that shines. And the rabbinic tradition eventually stated a rule for it: the Torah speaks in the language of human beings.

That material appears here for one reason. **The Quran is addressing the communities that hold it.** It speaks to Banū Isrā'īl and to the Christian communities directly, quotes their formulas, corrects some and confirms others, and expects its hearers to know the idiom it is using. When the Quran says a hand is above their hands to men making a pledge, it is speaking a language its audience already read in their own scripture, and the audience's familiarity with that language is a fact about the audience.

What is not being said is that Isaiah explains the Quran. The Quran's own usage settles the Quran's usage, and it does so without external help, as the vocabulary discipline above shows. The earlier scriptures are here because they are part of the situation the Quran is speaking into, and that is the only weight they carry in this study.

THE RULE, STATED ONCE AND APPLIED EVERYWHERE

The parallels are evidence about the Quran's audience. They are never the instrument that decides a Quranic reading. The Quran's own usage settles the Quran's usage.

TABLE 2 | CHAPTER 5 • HANDS, FACE, AND THRONE

Verse, and the word it turns on	The knot the commentaries left tied	Root recovered, structure read
48:10 · <i>yadu llābi fawqa aydihim</i> , spoken over men clasping hands in a compact	An anatomical term predicated of the One nothing resembles. Three classical parties, none closing: affirm and refuse to specify how, read as power and treat the wording as ornament, or consign the class and produce no reading. What none settled is why the term is there , since a text avoiding anatomy could have said power and did not	Root ي-د-ي · the organ of taking, giving, and binding, and in every Semitic idiom the instrument by which a compact is made to hold. What stands: the parties and their pledge. What moves: the pledging, performed by a clasp. How they are joined: the clasp. The verse's information sits in the third slot and asserts a second binding above the one the parties perform. Read into the first slot it produces a body; read into the third it produces the claim the passage is making
3:26 · <i>bi-yadika l-khayr</i> , inside <i>tu'ī l-mulka man tashā'u wa tanzi'u l-mulka mimman tashā'</i>	The same term, and the figurative reading charged with emptying it. Left open: whether the reading is imposed from outside or supplied by the passage	Root ي-د-ي at its second sense, the hand as seat of disposal. What stands: dominion, honour, abasement. What moves: giving and withdrawing. How they are joined: the hand. Every surrounding clause concerns disposal, so the passage supplies its own register. The capacity is named, not the limb
11:37 · <i>wa-ṣna'i l-fulka bi-a'yuninā</i>	Eyes predicated of Allah ﷻ, and a plural at that. The commentaries reached protection or knowledge and left open why an eye rather than a knowledge-word	Root ع-ي-ن · the eye, also the spring, also the thing itself: the organ of attending and the source that issues. What stands: a builder and a vessel, under ridicule. What moves: the building. How they are joined: <i>bi-</i> , under, which names the attending. Attention is exactly what a mocked builder lacks, and the clause supplies it
68:42 · <i>yawma yuksafu 'an sāq</i> , impersonal passive, no owner named	The most disputed clause in the family, because the Arabic supplies no subject. Centuries of argument over whose shin, unsettleable from the verse. What was left tied is that the dispute was about the first slot in a clause that never fills one	Root س-و-ق · the shin, and the stem that bears a plant's weight; <i>kashafa 'an sāq</i> is the garment gathered because the moment has become one in which nobody stands about. What stands: a day, and those summoned in it. What moves: the uncovering, and the calling. How they are joined: the demand the moment makes. The next clause confirms it, <i>wa yud'awna ilā l-sujūdi fā-lā yastaṭī'ūn</i> . The subject is missing because the clause is an idiom of urgency
20:5 and seven parallels · <i>al-rahmānu 'alā l-'arshi stawā</i>	Location apparently predicated. Mālik's answer closes the question of <i>how</i> and leaves untouched the question of what the clause is doing there	Roots ع-ر-ش and س-و-ي · settling evenly, coming to rest at parity; and the raised structure, thence the seat from which rule is exercised. All eight occurrences stand at one junction: completed making, then the establishing, then ordering by command, night pursuing day, sun and moon subjected. The clause marks a transition of register from making to government. The <i>how</i> stays where Mālik left it
3:185 · 21:35 · 29:57 against 5:116	A universal death-law set against a term the Source ﷻ uses of Himself ﷻ. The commentaries distinguished senses of <i>nafs</i> , which is available but	Root ن-ف-س · the breath, thence the breathing self, the bounded interior. The count answers before any distinction is needed: exactly three occurrences, and every one carries a class-marker inside its own verse , a recompense clause, a trial-and-return

Verse, and the word it turns on	The knot the commentaries left tied	Root recovered, structure read
	was never grounded in the text's own usage	clause, a return clause. Not one stands bare, so the Quran never states the unrestricted proposition the contradiction requires
28:88 · 55:26-27 · <i>kullu shay'in hālikun illā wajhab · wa yabqā wajhu rabbik</i>	What remains, and whether it is a body part. Neither party grounded its choice of term in how the Quran distributes it	Root و-ج-ه · the face, thence the direction one faces and the aspect turned toward: a relation-word before an organ-word. The distribution is the finding. The death-law runs on <i>nafs</i>, the perishing-law on <i>shay'</i>, and <i>wajh</i> is placed under neither anywhere in the corpus. Two vocabularies, two layers, no overlap, held across hundreds of verses
6:12 · 6:54 · <i>kataba 'alā nafsihī l-raḥmah</i>	Writer and written-upon in one clause, which no reading of <i>nafs</i> as a bare reflexive absorbs. The commentaries treated it as an idiom of obligation and left the construction unexamined	Root ك-ت-ب · to bind together, to sew, thence to write; a <i>katiba</i> is a squadron, a bound body. Writing is binding before it is inscribing. What stands: the Source عَلَّامٌ . What moves: the binding of mercy. How they are joined: <i>'alā</i> , upon. A self-binding, delivered by the root before any theology. And the count marks it: exactly two occurrences, both inside one chapter , at the hinge the row above identifies
5:116 · <i>ta'lamu mā fī nafsi wa lā a'lamu mā fī nafsik</i>	Cited across the comparative field as a historical error, on the ground that no creed states the attribution the verse questions. The dispute left the verse's grammar entirely unexamined	The only verse in the Quran placing <i>nafs</i> on both sides of an exchange. What stands: two interiors. What moves: knowing. How they are joined: an asymmetry running one way only, stated in a single clause. The verse produced as evidence of error carries the text's sharpest statement of the difference between a creature's interior and the Divine
The idiom in the earlier scriptures · an outstretched arm, a bared arm, a hand not shortened, eyes running through the earth	Whether the Hebrew usage explains the Quranic one, and whether the Quran is borrowing a manner of speech	The Quran addresses the communities that read in that idiom, names them, and quotes their formulas to correct or confirm. That makes the parallel evidence about the audience and about the argument being conducted. It never decides a reading, and the vocabulary discipline above settles the Quranic usage without external help

6 DECREE AND THE HUMAN ACT

The Quran asserts both halves of the hardest problem in theology, often in one breath, and its asserting both is what produced the schools. Some verses put an act entirely on Allah ﷻ. Others put it entirely on the human being. Several put both in one sentence. The classical parties took one set as governing and read the other through it, and the argument has not closed in fourteen centuries.

This chapter argues that the Quran states the architecture rather than the doctrine, and that it states it by **adjacency** at every place where the question is sharpest.

The sentence that is always half-quoted

Wa mā tashā'ūna illā an yashā'a llāh, you do not will unless Allah ﷻ wills, is the sentence most often produced as evidence that the Quran erases human volition.

Executed over the full text, that sentence occurs at **exactly two places**, Q 76:30 and Q 81:29. At **both** of them, the clause immediately before it asserts human willing.

Q 76:29 reads *inna hādhibi tadhkiratun fa-man shā'a ttakhadha ilā rabbihi sabīlā*, this is a reminder, so whoever wills may take a way to his Lord ﷻ. Then Q 76:30.

Q 81:28 reads *li-man shā'a minkum an yastaqīm*, for whoever among you wills to go straight. Then Q 81:29.

Two occurrences, two adjacencies, no exception. **The Quran never issues the sovereignty clause bare.** Whatever the relation between the two willings turns out to be, the text places both in adjacent sentences at both of the two places where it places either, and a citation of Q 76:30 without Q 76:29 is a citation of half a sentence. That is not an argument for a school. It is a fact about the text that constrains every school.

THE COUNT

Two occurrences, two adjacencies, no exception. The Quran never issues the sovereignty clause bare.

The verse that shows what the construction means

Fa-lam taqtulūhum wa lākinna llāha qatalahum wa mā ramayta idh ramayta wa lākinna llāha ramā, you did not kill them but Allah ﷻ killed them, and you did not throw when you threw but Allah ﷻ threw (Q 8:17).

The value of this verse is that its situation is not in dispute by anyone. Men fought at Badr and men died. A handful of dust was thrown and the Quran says so in the same clause in which it denies the throwing, *idh ramayta*, when you threw. So the construction cannot be denying the event.

What it denies is efficacy assigned to the actor. The act occurred, the actor performed it, and the outcome is assigned elsewhere. Read that way the verse is not paradoxical at all; it is two claims about two different things, the performance and the result, and the Arabic keeps them in one sentence because the point is that they are not the same question.

This has a consequence for a much more contested verse, and Chapter 7 develops it. Q 4:157's *wa mā qatalūhu* is the same construction, and the Quran uses that construction where the event is undisputed.

The sealing verses

Khatama llāhu 'alā qulūbihim wa 'alā sam'ihim, Allah ﷻ has sealed their hearts and their hearing (Q 2:7). *Yuḍillu man yashā'u wa yahdī man yashā'*, He misguides whom He wills and guides whom He wills (Q 16:93, Q 14:4).

These are read as making the outcome arbitrary, and read alone they can carry that. Two features of the surrounding text govern them.

The first is that the Quran regularly states the sealing as a **consequence** with the cause named. *Bal ṭaba'a llāhu 'alayhā bi-kufrihim*, rather Allah ﷻ has stamped upon them **for their disbelief** (Q 4:155). *Fa-lammā zāghū azāgha llāhu qulūbahum*, so when they deviated, Allah ﷻ caused their hearts to deviate (Q 61:5). The order in Q 61:5 is explicit and it is not reversible: the deviation is theirs and the confirmation follows.

The second is that the Quran's guidance vocabulary splits by grammatical form in a way that carries the whole architecture. The active participle is a divine name: *wa kafā bi-rabbika hādīyan*, sufficient is your Lord ﷻ as a Guide (Q 25:31). The passive is the creature's: *man yahdī llāhu fa-huwa l-muhtadī*, whom Allah ﷻ guides, he is the guided one (Q 7:178). And the **office** of guiding others exists and is conferred, with a permission clause attached: *wa ja'alnā minhum a'immatan yahdūna bi-amrinā*, We made from among them leaders who guide **by Our command** (Q 32:24). One root, three positions, and the difference between them is the whole doctrine of secondary agency stated in morphology.

There is a further verse that ought to be read in this family and rarely is. *Innaka lā tahdī man aḥbabta wa lākinna llāha yahdī man yashā'*, you do not guide whom you love, but Allah ﷻ guides whom He wills (Q 28:56). It is addressed to the Prophet ﷺ. If guidance-agency were a thing a human could hold, this is the person who would hold it, and the verse says he does not. The clause is not about the ordinary believer at all; it fixes the register by taking the strongest possible case.

THE ORDER IS EXPLICIT AND IT IS NOT REVERSIBLE

Fa-lammā zāghū azāgha llāhu qulūbahum. When they deviated, Allah ﷻ caused their hearts to deviate. The deviation is theirs and the confirmation follows.

The erasure verse

Yamḥū llāhu mā yashā'u wa yuthbitu wa 'indahū ummu l-kitāb, Allah ﷻ erases what He wills and confirms, and with Him ﷻ is the mother of the Book (Q 13:39).

The difficulty is that a record which can be erased seems not to be a record, and a decree which can change seems not to be a decree. The verse's own structure answers it: **two registers are named in one sentence**, a working state where erasure and confirmation occur, and a source-register located *'indahū*, with Him ﷻ. The verse is not describing one register that changes its mind. It is describing two, and locating them.

The same two-register structure appears at Q 6:2, where two terms are decreed in one clause, *thumma qaḍā ajalan wa ajalun musamman 'indah*, then He decreed a term, and a term named with Him ﷻ. Once the

reader has noticed the construction it recurs: something is stated at the level a creature works in, and something else is located on the far side, and the Quran marks the far side with *‘indahu*.

The reason the Quran states both halves

A last observation, and it is structural rather than doctrinal. A text that asserted only sovereignty would produce a reader with no responsibility. A text that asserted only human willing would produce a reader with no dependence. The Quran asserts both, in adjacent clauses, at every place where either would be dangerous alone, and it does so with enough consistency that the pattern is checkable.

Whether the resulting relation can be stated as a single doctrine without loss is a question this study does not answer, and the schools that tried have each paid a price somewhere. What the study reports is that the **architecture** is stated plainly and repeatedly, that the famous contradiction rests on quoting one half of two-part sentences, and that the text’s own grammar of guidance separates the Giver, the receiver, and the delegated office into three morphological positions before any school arrives.

KEY POINT

A text asserting only sovereignty produces a reader with no responsibility. A text asserting only human willing produces a reader with no dependence. The Quran asserts both, in adjacent clauses, at every place where either would be dangerous alone.

Where the earlier scriptures stand in this family

The Quran is speaking to communities that have this problem already. The Hebrew Bible hardens a heart and holds the hardened accountable in the same narrative (Exodus 7:3 with Exodus 8:15). The prophetic literature has an axe that boasts against the one who hews with it, *shall the axe boast itself against him that heweth therewith* (Isaiah 10:15), which is exactly the efficacy-and-performance distinction Q 8:17 makes. The letters of the New Testament have a God who works both the willing and the doing (Philippians 2:13). Those texts are in the room, their holders are among the Quran’s addressees, and the Quran engages the shared problem rather than inventing it.

They are noted here for that reason and for no other. Q 8:17 settles Q 8:17.

TABLE 3 | CHAPTER 6 • DECREE AND THE HUMAN ACT

Verse	Where the difficulty sits	What carries the reading
76:30 • 81:29 • <i>wa mā tashā’ūna illā an yashā’a llāh</i>	Produced for centuries as the verse that erases human volition, and the schools divided over whether the other half of the corpus could be read through it	The count settles what the schools argued. The sentence occurs at exactly two places , and at both the human-will clause stands immediately before: Q 76:29, <i>fa-man shā’a ttakhadha ilā rabbibi sabilā</i> , and Q 81:28, <i>li-man shā’a minkum an yastaqīm</i> . Two occurrences, two adjacencies, no exception. The Quran never issues the sovereignty clause bare , so a citation of Q 76:30 alone is a citation of half a sentence. That is not an argument for a school; it is a fact that constrains every school
	Read as paradox, and the paradox left standing. What went unnoticed is that	Root <i>ي-م-ر</i> , to throw, used in the same clause that denies the throwing: <i>idh ramayta</i> , when you threw.

Verse	Where the difficulty sits	What carries the reading
8:17 · <i>fa-lam taqtulūhum wa lākinna llāha qatalabum wa mā ramayta idh ramayta</i>	the verse's situation is not in dispute by anyone	Men fought at Badr, men died, a handful of dust was thrown. What stands: an actor and an outcome. What moves: the act, affirmed. How they are joined: the assignment of efficacy, placed elsewhere. The construction denies agency , not event, and the Arabic holds both in one sentence because they are two questions. This is also the lexical key to Q 4:157, where the same construction is used and the same reading follows
2:7 · 16:93 · 14:4 · sealing and misguidance	Read as making the outcome arbitrary, which is how the hardest form of the problem is usually posed	Two features govern them. The Quran states the sealing as a consequence with the cause named: <i>bal ṭaba'a llāhu 'alayhā bi-kufrihim</i> (Q 4:155), and <i>fa-lammā zāghū azāgha llāhu qulūbabum</i> (Q 61:5), where the order is explicit and not reversible. The deviation is theirs and the confirmation follows
25:31 · 7:178 · 32:24 · the guidance vocabulary	Whether guidance is ever a creature's office, argued doctrinally for centuries	Root ي-د-ي in three morphological positions, and the positions carry the whole architecture. Active participle, a divine name: <i>wa kafā bi-rabbika hādīyan</i> . Passive, the creature's: <i>fa-buwa l-muhtadī</i> . And a conferred office with a permission clause: <i>a'immatan yabdūna bi-amrinā</i> , leaders who guide by Our command . Giver, receiver, and delegated office, separated in grammar before any school separates them in doctrine
28:56 · <i>innaka lā tahdī man aḥbabta</i>	Rarely read in this family at all, and it is the verse that fixes the register	Addressed to the Prophet ﷺ, which is the strongest possible case: if guidance-agency were a thing a human could hold, this is the person who would hold it, and the verse says he does not. The clause is not about the ordinary believer; it settles the register by taking the limiting case
13:39 · <i>yamḥū llāhu mā yashā'u wa yuthbitu wa 'indahu ummu l-kitāb</i>	A record that can be erased seems not to be a record, and a decree that can change seems not to be a decree	Root م-ح-و , to wipe out, and ث-ب-ت , to make firm. What stands: two registers, named in one sentence. What moves: erasure and confirmation. How they are joined: the marker <i>'indahu</i> , with Him ﷻ, which locates the second. The verse is not one register changing its mind; it is two registers being located. The same construction recurs at Q 6:2, <i>thumma qaḍā ajalun wa ajalun musamman 'indah</i> , and once noticed, the far-side marker appears wherever the far side is meant
The family read together	Whether the relation can be stated as one doctrine without loss	The Quran asserts both halves, in adjacent clauses, at every place where either alone would be dangerous. A text asserting only sovereignty produces a reader with no responsibility; a text asserting only human willing produces a reader with no dependence. Whether the relation reduces to a single doctrine is not settled here, and each school that tried has paid somewhere. What is settled is that the famous contradiction rests on quoting one half of two-part sentences

Verse	Where the difficulty sits	What carries the reading
The earlier scriptures · a hardened heart held accountable, an axe boasting against the one who hews, a God who works both the willing and the doing	Whether the Quran is borrowing a problem or inheriting one	The communities holding those texts are named and addressed throughout. The problem was already in the room and the Quran engages it rather than inventing it. Noted for that reason and no other: Q 8:17 settles Q 8:17

7 WORD, SPIRIT, AND THE GRAMMAR OF A CREED

This is the family where the Quran is most explicitly in dispute, and therefore the family where Key One does the most work. Almost nothing in it is an unprompted statement. Nearly every verse is an answer, and several of them quote the claim they are answering in the clause immediately before.

It is also the family most likely to be read as polemic by a reader who does not notice what the Quran is actually doing, which is running a **type-check on constructions** rather than deleting content. That distinction is the chapter's spine and it is worth stating before the verses: **the Quran does not remove a claim and leave a hole. It identifies a form of words, states in the same verse why that form fails, and writes the correct form.** Three times, in three different constructions, with the same operation each time.

The construction refused, and the same construction affirmed

Inna llāha huwa l-masīḥu bnu maryam, Allah ﷺ is the Messiah son of Maryam AS, is condemned at Q 5:17 and Q 5:72.

The Arabic here is not incidental. Definite subject, separating pronoun *huwa*, definite predicate: this is the strongest identity construction the language offers, and it asserts convertibility with no remainder. A is B and B is A.

Two things are decisive and neither is theological.

The first is that **the Quran states its ground inside the verse**, and the ground is destructibility: *fa-man yamliku mina llāhi shayʾan in arāda an yublika l-masīḥa bna maryama wa ummahu wa man fī l-arḍi jamīʿā*, who could avail anything against Allah ﷻ if He willed to destroy the Messiah son of Maryam AS and his mother and everyone on the earth. The argument offered is that the proposed occupant of the frame is destructible and the frame is not.

The second is that **the Quran writes that same construction of Allah ﷻ freely**. *Fa-llāhu huwa l-walī*, so Allah ﷻ is the Protector (Q 42:9), with the life-giving clause following directly. The frame is not the problem; the frame is reserved and used constantly.

So what is refused is an **occupant**, and the reason is available in the morphology before any doctrine is consulted. *Masīḥ* is the *faʿīl* form in a passive sense, one upon whom an act was performed, standing in the class of *qatīl*, one slain, and *jarīḥ*, one wounded. An anointed one is one whom another anointed. The Hebrew is the same shape: every *mashiah* in the earlier scripture is someone upon whom oil was poured by someone else, including a Persian king at Isaiah 45:1.

A title of that form is **asymmetric**: it points outward to an agent beyond itself. The strongest identity construction is **symmetric**: it closes the relation in both directions with no remainder. Put an asymmetric term into a symmetric frame and the sentence does not merely become false. **It fails to compose**, in exactly the way Chapter 3 described, because the term is carrying a reference outward that the frame has closed off. The Quran's destructibility argument states that failure in narrative form.

THE OPERATION, STATED ONCE FOR THE WHOLE CHAPTER

The Quran does not remove a claim and leave a hole. It identifies a form of words, states in the same verse why that form fails, and writes the correct form.

The number that is barred, and the threeness that is written

Wa lā taqūlū thalātha, do not say three (Q 4:171), and *inna llāha thālithu thalātha*, Allah ﷻ is the third of three, condemned at Q 5:73.

The apparent oddity is that Q 4:171, in the same breath in which it bars the number, supplies three designations for one referent: *rasūlu llāhi wa kalimatuhu alqābā ilā maryama wa rūḥun minhu*, the messenger of Allah ﷻ, and His word which He cast to Maryam AS, and a spirit from Him.

The Quran's own usage tells us what is being barred. Executed over the full text, the construction *thālithu thalātha* occurs **once**, at Q 5:73. Its only sibling, the same shape of an ordinal placed inside a count, is *wa Manāta l-thālithata l-ukhrā*, and Manāt the third, the other (Q 53:20), which is a named pre-Islamic Meccan triad. That is the corpus's only other use of the form, and it is used of an enumerated cult.

What is barred is enumeration as a way of stating a relation. Threeness as structure is not barred, and the same verse writes it. That is unintelligible if the verse is counting and exact if the verse is type-checking a construction.

There is a further observation that ties this chapter to Chapter 4. The same grammatical instrument runs against two entirely different audiences. The Quran bars the ordinal-in-a-count where it names the Meccan triad and again where it addresses a creedal formulation. One move, made twice, in the same form, to two audiences who had nothing in common. That is strong evidence that the target is a **form of speech** and not a community.

THE COUNT

Thālithu thalātha occurs **once** in the Quran. Its only sibling ordinal-in-a-count is *al-thālithata l-ukhrā* at Q 53:20, naming a Meccan triad. One grammatical instrument, aimed at two audiences who had nothing in common.

The third construction, and its ground

Walad, offspring in the generative sense, is denied at Q 9:30, Q 19:35, and Q 112:3.

Again the Quran gives its ground, and again it gives it before the consequence. *Annā yakūnu labu waladun wa lam takun labu sāḥibah*, how could He have offspring when He has no consort (Q 6:101). And Sūrat al-Ikhlāṣ states the reason **before** the denial: *allāhu l-ṣamad* at Q 112:2, then *lam yalid wa lam yūlad* at Q 112:3. *Ṣamad* at its physical floor is the massy thing with no hollow, the solid without an interior. A thing that begets must have an interior from which something issues. So the denial at Q 112:3 is derived from Q 112:2 inside four verses, and the chapter is an argument rather than a list.

And what stands in the barred construction's place is supplied in the adjacent clause each time: *kun fa-yakūn*, be, and it is, at Q 2:117 and Q 19:35. The Quran closes the inference at Q 3:59 with the harder case: *inna mathala 'īsā 'inda llāhi ka-mathali ādam, khalaqahu min turābin thumma qāla labu kun fa-yakūn*, the

likeness of ʿĪsā AS with Allah ﷻ is as the likeness of Ādam AS, whom He created from dust and then said to him, be. If a man with neither father nor mother requires no generation-doctrine, a man with a mother and no father requires none either.

Three rows, one operation performed three times: identify the construction, state why it fails, write the correct form. In two of the three the correct form appears in the adjacent clause.

What the Quran deposits, and why it is not a contradiction

Here is the difficulty that produced the most sophisticated arguments on all sides. The Quran predicates of its own *kalām* a set of properties it predicates of nothing created. It is *ʿaliyyun ḥakīm*, exalted and wise, with Him ﷻ, in the mother of the Book (Q 43:4). It is *majīd*, glorious (Q 85:21), and *karīm*, noble (Q 56:77). Four of those are divine names. It is inexhaustible under a hypothetical of unbounded material supply (Q 18:109, Q 31:27). It is complete in truth and justice and unalterable (Q 6:115, Q 10:64).

And then the Quran calls ʿĪsā AS a word from Him ﷻ, *bi-kalimatīn minhu* (Q 3:45), *kalimatuhu alqāhā ilā maryam* (Q 4:171).

So the same text appears to deposit divine-kind predicates on a term and then attach that term to a man, while barring every construction that would make the man divine.

The resolution is grammatical and it is clean. **The deposit and the fence occupy different constructions and the Quran never confuses them.** What is deposited is qualitative predication with the relation held open by *ladaynā*, with Us, and *ʿindahu*, with Him ﷻ. What is barred is convertible identity, enumeration, and generation. A qualitative predicate and an equational identity are not one proposition affirmed and denied. They are two different grammatical acts, and the Quran deploys both deliberately in the same passages.

A detail at Q 3:45 makes this visible. *Kalima*, word, is grammatically feminine. The verse continues *ismuhu al-masīḥu ʿīsā bnu maryama wajīhan*, his name is the Messiah, ʿĪsā son of Maryam AS, honored, with masculine pronoun and masculine accusative. **The gender agreement breaks at precisely the point where the announcement of a word becomes the naming of a man.** The classical grammarians explained this as agreement with the thing named rather than with the term, which is the correct explanation and is also the datum: the Arabic marks the transition rather than blurring it.

THE RESOLUTION IS GRAMMATICAL

A qualitative predicate and an equational identity are two different acts. The Quran deploys both deliberately in the same passages and never confuses them.

The two most contested sentences

Q 3:55 and the verb. *Innī mutawaffika wa rāfiʿuka ilayya*. Chapter 2 gave the lexical key: Q 39:42 defines *tawaffā* in the Quran's own voice and detaches it from death by supplying a **sleep** case in the same clause. The verb means to take in full. What the passage then asserts about the manner of the taking is a further question, and this study does not settle it, because the Quran's own words about it are what they are and the settling would require adding to them.

Q 4:157 and the construction. *Wa mā qatalūhu wa mā ṣalabūhu wa lākin shubbiḥa labum*.

Three observations, in order.

First, the clause **immediately before** names the addressee and the claim: *wa qawlihim innā qatalnā l-masīḥa ʿīsā bna maryama rasūla llāh*, and their saying, we killed the Messiah, ʿIsā son of Maryam AS, the messenger of Allah ﷺ. The verse is answering a **boast of agency** made by a party claiming the killing. It is not answering a creed, and no creed states the sentence being quoted.

Second, the Quran uses the identical construction where the event is not in dispute, at Q 8:17. *Mā qatalūhu* in the Quran's own usage denies **efficacy assigned to the actor**.

Third, the counter-claim is supplied in the next verse, *bal rafaʿahu llāhu ilayh*, rather, Allah ﷻ raised him to Himself (Q 4:158), which assigns the disposal elsewhere. Read with its own key, the passage refuses the boast and relocates the agency, which is what the party being addressed had claimed.

What the manner of the event was, this study does not adjudicate. It is on the far side of what the Quran states, and both the classical Muslim positions and the historical question lie beyond the reach of a structural reading.

The verse read as a historical error

Wa idh qāla llāhu yā ʿīsā bna maryama a-anta qulta li-l-nāsi ttakhidhūnī wa ummiya ilāhaynī min dūni llāh, did you say to people, take me and my mother as two gods (Q 5:116).

The objection is that no Christian creed states this. Three observations.

The verse is set at an **interrogation**, not as a report of doctrine: it is a question put to a figure at a final accounting, and its answer in the following verses is a denial. The Quran's own argument against the pair is elsewhere and it is about **practice** rather than about a written creed: *kānā yaʿkulānī l-ṭaʿām*, they both used to eat food (Q 5:75). An argument from eating is aimed at veneration of two figures, not at a trinitarian formula, which the argument would not touch. And the Arabian religious landscape of the period is known to have contained Marian veneration of forms the councils themselves condemned.

And there is a feature of Q 5:116 that is more interesting than the objection. The verse continues *taʿlamu mā fī nafsī wa lā aʿlamu mā fī nafsik*, You know what is in my self and I do not know what is in Your self. **It is the only verse in the Quran that places *nafs* on both sides of an exchange.** The verse most often produced as evidence of historical error is the verse that carries the text's most explicit statement of the asymmetry between a creature's interior and the Divine interior.

THE OVERLOOKED FEATURE

Q 5:116 is the only verse in the Quran that places *nafs* on both sides of an exchange. The verse most often produced as evidence of error carries the text's most explicit statement of the asymmetry between a creature's interior and the Divine.

The communities in the room

Everything in this chapter is addressed to somebody. The Najrān delegation is in the record as having come to Madina to dispute exactly these questions. The formulas being type-checked are formulas somebody was using. The earlier scriptures and the councils are the context the Quran speaks into, and the Quran's method

with them is neither wholesale rejection nor wholesale adoption: it confirms, it corrects constructions, and it names what it refuses.

One observation belongs here for accuracy and it cuts against a common assumption. The Quran states the denial of generation and names the parties who assert it. It does not follow that the earliest Christian writing holds the position denied, and on the plain evidence of that writing it does not: the earliest Gospel uses no begetting-verb of its figure in relation to God, and at the baptism scene it quotes the second Psalm and stops short of the clause of generation that stands in the psalm's next breath. That is a fact about a text, it is recorded here as one, and it is exactly the kind of fact this study treats as evidence about the Quran's situation rather than as an instrument for reading the Quran.

TABLE 4 | CHAPTER 7 • WORD, SPIRIT, AND THE GRAMMAR OF A CREED

The construction at issue	The dispute	Grammar, and what it decides
5:17 • 5:72 • <i>inna llāba huwa l-masīhu bnu maryam</i>	Condemned in the Quran, while the identical construction is written of Allah ﷻ freely. Read as polemic, and the question of why the same frame is refused in one filling and used in another was never put	Definite subject, separating pronoun, definite predicate: the strongest identity construction Arabic offers, asserting convertibility with no remainder. The Quran states its ground inside the verse , destructibility, and affirms the same frame at Q 42:9, <i>fa-llābu huwa l-walī</i> . The morphology decides the rest. <i>Masīh</i> is فعيل in the passive sense, in the class of <i>qatīl</i> , one slain, and <i>jarīh</i> , one wounded: anointed one is one whom another anointed, and the Hebrew <i>mashiah</i> is the same shape, including a Persian king at Isaiah 45:1. An asymmetric term points outward to an agent; a convertible frame closes in both directions with no remainder. Put one in the other and the sentence fails to compose , which is what the destructibility argument states in narrative form
4:171 • 5:73 • <i>lā taqūlū thalātha • thālithu thalātha</i>	The number barred while three designations are supplied in the same breath, which is unintelligible on any counting reading	The Quran's own usage identifies the form. The construction occurs once , at Q 5:73, and its only sibling ordinal-in-a-count is <i>wa Manāta l-thālithata l-ukhrā</i> at Q 53:20, a named Meccan triad. What is barred is enumeration as a way of stating a relation , not threeness as structure, and the verse writes the structure while barring the numeral. The same instrument runs against two audiences with nothing in common, which is strong evidence that the target is a form of speech and not a community
112:2-3 • 6:101 • <i>allābu l-ṣamad, then lam yalid wa lam yūlad</i>	Generation denied, and the denial read as bare assertion	Root م-ل-د aimed-at, and solid without hollow: a massy body with no interior. The reason precedes the consequence inside the chapter. A thing that begets must have an interior from which something issues, so Q 112:3 is derived from Q 112:2 in four verses. Q 6:101 states the mechanism outright, <i>annā yakūnu labu waladun wa lam takun labu ṣāhibah</i> , and the correct form is supplied in the adjacent clause each time, <i>kun fa-yakūn</i> , with the inference closed at Q 3:59 by the harder case of Ādam AS
43:4 • 85:21 • 56:77 • 18:109 • 31:27 • 3:45 •	The sharpest internal difficulty in the chapter: divine-kind predicates	The resolution is grammatical and clean. A qualitative predicate and an equational identity

The construction at issue	The dispute	Grammar, and what it decides
4:171 · the deposit on the <i>kalām</i> , and the word attached to a man	deposited on a term, and that term attached to a man, in a text barring every construction that would make the man divine	are two different acts , and the Quran deploys both deliberately and never confuses them: the deposit is qualitative with the relation held open by <i>ladaynā</i> and <i>ʿindahu</i> ; the fence is on convertible identity, enumeration, and generation. The Arabic marks the seam itself. <i>Kalima</i> is feminine; <i>ismubu</i> and <i>wajīhan</i> at Q 3:45 are masculine. The agreement breaks exactly where the announcement of a word becomes the naming of a man
3:55 · <i>innī mutawaffika wa rāfiʿuka ilayya</i>	Divided readers for centuries because the verb is usually rendered as taking in death	Root و-ف-ي · fullness, completion, paying in full; a <i>wafāʾ</i> is the discharge of what is due. And the Quran defines the verb in its own voice at Q 39:42 , supplying a sleep case in the same clause: <i>wa-llatī lam tamut fī manāmihā</i> . The verb means to take in full. The lexical dispute ends by concordance rather than by school; what the passage then asserts about the manner is a further question and is not settled here
4:157 · <i>wa mā qatalūhu wa mā ṣalabūhu wa lākin shubbiha lahum</i>	The most contested sentence in the comparative field, and the contest ran for centuries on the third clause while the first was read as a bare denial of event	Three observations in order. The clause immediately before names both the speakers and the claim, <i>wa qawlibim innā qatalnā l-masiḥa</i> , so the verse answers a boast of agency and not a creed, since no creed states the sentence quoted. The construction is the one Q 8:17 uses where the event is undisputed. And Q 4:158 supplies the counter-claim, <i>bal rafāʿahu llāhu ilayh</i> , which assigns the disposal elsewhere. What stands : a party and a claim. What moves : the killing, as claimed. How they are joined : the assignment of agency, refused and relocated. The manner of the event lies beyond a structural reading and is not adjudicated
5:116 · <i>a-anta qulta li-l-nāsi ttakbidhūnī wa ummiya ilāhaynī</i>	Produced as a historical error on the ground that no creed states it, and the argument over the attribution left the verse's own grammar unread	The setting is an interrogation at a final accounting, answered by a denial, not a report of a written creed. And the Quran's argument against the pair is about practice : <i>kānā yaʿkulānī l-ṭaʾām</i> (Q 5:75), an argument from eating, which is aimed at veneration of two figures and would not touch a formula. Beside that stands the feature nobody cites: it is the only verse in the corpus placing <i>naḥs</i> on both sides of an exchange
The communities in the room · a delegation on record as having come to dispute exactly these questions	Whether the chapter is polemic	The operation is a type-check and not a deletion: identify the construction, state why it fails, write the correct form, three times, with the correct form in the adjacent clause twice. One observation recorded for accuracy and carrying no weight in any reading: the earliest Gospel uses no begetting-verb of its figure in relation to God , and at the baptism it quotes the second Psalm, <i>thou art my beloved Son</i> (Mark 1:11), and stops short of the clause of

The construction at issue	The dispute	Grammar, and what it decides
		generation that follows in the psalm's own next breath (Psalm 2:7)

8 THE STORIES THAT ARRIVE HALF-TOLD

A large group of Quranic narratives begins in the middle, omits names the reader expects, gives a detail no one can identify, and then stops. A cow whose specification is extracted question by question. Sleepers whose number is disputed inside the passage. A servant who breaches a boat, kills a boy, and repairs a wall. A two-horned traveller with no fixed identity. Two angels teaching what harms. A body cast on a throne. Thousands who left their homes fearing death, in a single sentence.

The traditional response was to fill the gaps from the surrounding literature, and that literature is enormous. This chapter argues that the gaps are usually not gaps. In most of these cases the Quran is retelling material its audience already held, and the retelling's whole content is what has been **changed**, which is invisible to a reader who does not know what was there before, and which is exactly what the audience did know.

That is Key One applied to narrative. The addressee is not a person here but a **story the audience already has**, and the Quran's contribution is a restored clause, a removed clause, or a shifted emphasis.

The cow

Q 2:67-73 is the passage the second chapter of the Quran is named for, and it is strange on any reading. Mūsā AS conveys a command to slaughter a cow. The people ask what kind. The answer narrows. They ask again. It narrows again. They ask a third time. It narrows to an animal so specific as to be nearly unfindable, and the Quran ends the exchange with *fa-dhabahūhā wa mā kādū yaf'alūn*, so they slaughtered her, and they nearly did not do it.

Read as a story about a cow it is disproportionate. Read as an answer it is transparent.

The audience being addressed held a body of law containing a category of statute whose reason is withheld and whose questioning is discouraged, and the paradigm case of that category in their own tradition was a rite involving a red heifer. The passage is a **dramatization of what questioning a withheld decree costs**: a command that began as any cow ends as one cow, and the text states the price in its own words in the final clause.

There is a second feature of the retelling that only an audience holding the earlier material would notice. The rite in the earlier scripture that involves an unworked heifer and an unsolved death does not solve the death; it disposes of the guilt of an unsolved killing. In the Quran's version, the striking of the corpse with part of the animal **solves it**: *fa-qulnā dribūhu bi-ba'dihā, kadhālika yuḥyī llāhu l-mawtā wa yurikum āyātihī la'allakum ta'qilūn*. The retelling supplies the outcome the earlier rite left open and attaches a purpose clause naming what it demonstrates.

KEY POINT

The passage's final clause is its own verdict on itself. *And they nearly did not do it*. A command that began as any cow ended as one cow, and the text states the price.

The sleepers

Chapter 4 handled the count. What remains here is the shape of the telling. The Quran narrates a story that was current in the region in Christian form, declines to fix the number, declines to fix the word *raqīm*, and instructs the reader not to litigate either. What it does supply is a frame that the circulating versions did not have: at Q 18:13-14 the youths are described as having stood and said, *rabbunā rabbu l-samāwāti wa-l-ard*, our Lord ﷻ is the Lord of the heavens and the earth, and at Q 18:21 the dispute over what to build over them is reported as a dispute rather than settled.

The narrative that the tradition treats as full of unanswerable details is a narrative in which the Quran keeps the theological point and drops the identifying detail, and then says so.

Khiḍr AS

Q 18:60-82 is not obscure in its events. It is difficult because the acts are morally intolerable in the order they are given and become intelligible only after they are explained, and because the figure who performs them is nowhere named and possesses a knowledge the lawgiver AS beside him does not.

The passage states its own difficulty in advance and states it as a **matter of scope** rather than of morality. *Wa kayfa taṣbiru ‘alā mā lam tuḥiṭ bihi khubrā*, how will you have patience with what you have not encompassed in experience (Q 18:68). And it types the knowledge in the same way: *‘allamnāhu min ladunnā ‘ilmā*, We taught him a knowledge from Us (Q 18:65).

Read structurally, the episode is a demonstration of a category error being made and corrected three times: a judgment issued from one register upon acts belonging to another. The lawgiver AS is not being humiliated; the point is that the objection he raises is the right objection **at his register**, and the register is not the operative one. That is why the correction is not a rebuke but an explanation, and why the passage ends by returning the knowledge to its source, *wa mā fa‘altuhu ‘an amrī*, I did not do it of my own command.

THE DIFFICULTY IS ANNOUNCED IN ADVANCE

How will you have patience with what you have not encompassed in experience. The passage states its own problem as a matter of scope before the walk begins.

The two-horned traveller

Wa yas‘alūnaka ‘an dhī l-qarnayn, they ask you about the two-horned one (Q 18:83). The identification has been argued for centuries.

The answer's opening clause states its own genre. *Qul sa‘atlū ‘alaykum minhu dhikrā*, say, I will recite to you a **remembrance** of him. Not a biography, not a dossier: a portion selected for a purpose. And the purpose recurs inside the narrative in the traveller's own mouth, *hādhā raḥmatun min rabbī*, this is a mercy from my Lord ﷻ.

So the identity is not withheld coyly. The answer declares in its first clause what kind of answer it is going to be, and a reader who then requires an identification is requiring something the answer said it would not supply.

The two angels

Q 2:102 is among the strangest verses in the Quran on a first reading: angels at Babylon teaching people what harms them, in a passage about Sulaymān AS.

The verse's opening move is the key. *Wa-ttaba'ū mā tatlu l-shayātīnu 'alā mulki sulaymān, wa mā kafara sulaymānu wa lākinna l-shayātīna kafarū*, they followed what the satans recited concerning the kingdom of Sulaymān AS; and Sulaymān AS did not disbelieve, but the satans disbelieved.

The verse is detaching a figure from a body of material circulating under his name. That is its whole opening operation, and the operation is intelligible the moment one knows that magical literature attributed to Sulaymān AS was in wide circulation in late antiquity, which the Quran's audience did know. Once the passage is read as a disavowal of attributed material, the angels stop being an anomaly and become the named provenance of the material being disavowed. And the Quran supplies the control clause the circulating literature lacked: *wa mā yu'allimāni min aḥadin ḥattā yaqūlā innamā naḥnu fitnatun fa-lā takfur*, they taught no one until they said, we are only a trial, so do not disbelieve. The source announces its own status before it transmits.

THE OPENING MOVE IS THE KEY

And Sulaymān AS did not disbelieve, but the satans disbelieved. The verse's first operation is to detach a figure from material circulating under his name.

The body on the throne

Wa la-qad fatannā sulaymāna wa alqaynā 'alā kursiyyihi jasadān thumma anāb, We tried Sulaymān AS and cast upon his throne a body, then he turned (Q 38:34).

The Quran does not explain the body, and the surrounding literature explains it at length. What the Quran does supply is the **consequence**, in the very next verse: *rabbi ghfir lī wa ḥab lī mulkan lā yanbaghī lī-aḥadin min ba'dī*, forgive me and grant me a dominion that suits no one after me (Q 38:35). The episode is not left as a wonder; the text states what it produced, and what it produced is a request for a grant.

That request is legible against the Quran's own theory of dominion. *Qul allāhumma mālika l-mulki tu'tī l-mulka man tashā'u wa tanzi'u l-mulka mimman tashā'*, say, O Allah ﷻ, Owner of dominion, You give dominion to whom You will and take it from whom You will (Q 3:26). Ownership above, dominion conferred and withdrawn below. A throne briefly occupied by something that is not the king is a demonstration of the second half of that verse.

The thousands

A-lam tara ilā lladhīna kharajū min diyārihim wa hum ulūfun ḥadhara l-mawti fa-qāla lahumu llāhu mūtū thumma aḥyāhum, have you not seen those who left their homes in thousands, fearing death, and Allah ﷻ said to them, die, then He gave them life (Q 2:243).

One sentence, no names, no place, no date. It is followed immediately by *a-lam tara ilā l-mala'i min banī isrā'īla min ba'di mūsā*, have you not seen the assembly of the Children of Israel after Mūsā AS. Two

consecutive verses opening with the same formula, addressed to the same community, and the formula is *a-lam tara*, have you not seen, which is an appeal to something the hearer can be expected to know.

That is the signature of the whole family. **The brevity is not compression of an unknown story; it is address to an audience that holds it.** The audience being addressed had a body of interpretation in which a prophetic vision of a valley of dry bones had been historicized into an event involving a group who left early and were destroyed and revived. The Quran narrates the event that audience's own tradition had made, and attaches a clause their version did not carry, *wa lākinna akthara l-nāsi lā yashkurūn*.

THE SIGNATURE OF THE WHOLE FAMILY

A-lam tara, have you not seen. The brevity is not compression of an unknown story; it is address to an audience that holds it.

What the family shows

Read together, these narratives have one method. The Quran tells a shared story, restores or removes a control clause, and attaches a purpose. It economizes on names to the point of eliminating most of them. It declines to fix details, sometimes explicitly. And in several cases it converts an active into a passive, or supplies a permission clause, so that what a circulating version had as an achievement becomes a grant.

That last operation runs across the whole prophetic material and is worth naming, because it is the most consistent thing in it. Sulaymān AS says *‘ullimnā mantiqa l-ṭayr*, we **were taught** the speech of birds, and *ūtīnā min kulli shay’*, we **were given** of everything (Q 27:16). Both passive. The Quran's habit is to keep the exaltation and to name the Giver, and the strongest form of that habit is Q 3:49, where a series of extraordinary acts is recounted with *bi-idhni llāh*, by the leave of Allah ﷻ, repeated inside a single verse.

THE MOST CONSISTENT OPERATION IN THE PROPHETIC MATERIAL

The Quran keeps the exaltation and names the Giver. *‘Ullimnā*, we were taught. *Ūtīnā*, we were given. And the permission clause is stacked: *bi-idhni llāh*, by the permission of Allah ﷻ, stands twice inside Q 3:49, and the parallel passage at Q 5:110 carries *bi-idhni*, by My permission, four times in a single verse spoken in the first person.

THE COMMON SHAPE

One method runs through every narrative in this chapter. Tell a story the audience already holds, restore or remove a control clause, attach a purpose, economize on names, decline the identifying detail, and turn an active into a passive with the Giver named.

Where the earlier material stands

Every narrative in this chapter is addressed to somebody who already had a version of it. That is why the earlier scriptures, the rabbinic literature, and the pre-Islamic apocrypha appear in these pages: not as keys, but as the content of the audience's memory, which is the thing the Quran is speaking into. A retelling's meaning is carried by its differences, and the differences are only visible against what the audience held.

None of that material adjudicates a Quranic reading in this study. In every case above, the Quran's own added clause, purpose statement, or grammatical change is the thing that does the work, and it does the work whether or not a reader knows the earlier version.

TABLE 5 | CHAPTER 8 • THE STORIES THAT ARRIVE HALF-TOLD

The story	What was left dangling	What the retelling changed
2:67-73 · the cow, the escalating interrogation, <i>wa mā kādū yaf'alūn</i>	Disproportionate on any reading. Why a simple command becomes an interrogation, why the specification narrows to an almost unfindable animal, and why the passage ends by saying they nearly did not do it. The commentaries supplied the missing animal and did not supply the missing point	The audience held a category of statute whose reason is withheld and whose questioning is discouraged, and its paradigm case in their own tradition involves a red heifer. The passage is a dramatization of what questioning a withheld decree costs , and it states the price in its own last clause. And the retelling supplies an outcome the earlier rite withholds: the strike solves the death, <i>fā-qulnā ʿdribūhu bi-ba'ḍihā</i> , with a purpose clause attached. The earlier rite disposes of guilt; this one resolves the case
18:9-26 · the sleepers	A story dense with unfixable details, filled at length from the surrounding literature	The Quran keeps the theological point and drops the identifying detail, and then says so. What is supplied instead is the frame: the youths stand and name the Lord ﷻ of the heavens and the earth at Q 18:13-14, and the dispute over what to build over them at Q 18:21 is reported as a dispute rather than settled. The refusal at Q 18:22 is the model for the whole family
18:60-82 · Khidr AS	Acts morally intolerable in the order given and intelligible only after explanation, performed by a figure the text never names, possessing a knowledge the lawgiver AS beside him does not	The passage announces its own problem in advance and announces it as scope : <i>wa kayfa taṣbiru 'alā mā lam tuḥiṭ bihi khubrā</i> (Q 18:68), and types the knowledge as given, <i>'allamnāhu min ladunnā 'ilmā</i> (Q 18:65). What stands : two knowers. What moves : three acts and three objections. How they are joined : the register each judgment issues from. The objection is right at its own register and the register is not the operative one, which is why the correction is an explanation and not a rebuke, and why the passage ends by returning the knowledge to its source at Q 18:82
18:83-98 · Dhū al-Qarnayn	An identity argued for centuries with no settlement available from the text	The answer declares its own genre in its first clause: <i>qul sa'atlū 'alaykum minhu dhikrā</i> , a remembrance, a portion selected for a purpose, not a dossier. And the selection principle recurs in the traveller's own mouth, <i>hādbā raḥmatun min rabbī</i> . The identity was never being offered, and the answer says so before it begins
2:102 · Hārūt and Mārūt	Angels at Babylon teaching what harms, inside a passage about Sulaymān AS. Among the strangest verses on a first reading, and read as demonology	The opening move is the key: <i>wa mā kafara sulaymānu wa lākinna l-shayāṭīna kafarū</i> . The verse is detaching a figure from a body of material circulating under his name , which the audience knew was circulating. Read as a disavowal of attributed literature the angels stop being an anomaly and become its named provenance. And the Quran

The story	What was left dangling	What the retelling changed
		supplies the control clause the circulating version lacked: <i>innamā nahnu fitnatun fa-lā takfur</i> , the source announcing its own status before it transmits
38:34 · <i>wa alqaynā ‘alā kursiyyihi jasadān</i>	A body cast on a throne, unexplained by the Quran and explained at length by everything around it	The Quran supplies the consequence instead of the identification: Q 38:35, <i>rabbi ghfir lī wa hab lī mulkan lā yanbaghi li-ahādin min ba’dī</i> . The episode is not left as a wonder; the text states what it produced, and what it produced is a request for a grant. Legible against Q 3:26, <i>tu’rī l-mulka man tashā’u wa tanzi’u l-mulka mimman tashā’</i> : ownership above, dominion given and withdrawn below. A throne briefly held by what is not the king demonstrates the second half of that verse
2:243 · the thousands who left their homes	One sentence, no names, no place, no date. Read as a report it is deficient	The signature of the family, and it is a formula: a-lam tara , have you not seen, which appeals to something the hearer already holds. Q 2:243 and Q 2:246 open with it in consecutive verses to the same community, so the two are one catechism sequence. Brevity is not compression of an unknown story; it is address to an audience that holds it. And the clause attached is one their version did not carry: <i>wa lākinna akthara l-nāsi lā yashkurūn</i>
27:16 · 3:49 · prophetic capacities	Whether extraordinary powers are held or received, which the surrounding literature tends to blur	The most consistent operation in the prophetic material, and it is grammatical. Sulaymān AS says <i>‘ullimnā</i> , we were taught , and <i>ūtīnā</i> , we were given , both passive. And the permission clause is stacked: <i>bi-idhni llāh</i> stands twice inside Q 3:49, and the parallel at Q 5:110 carries <i>bi-idhnī</i> , by My permission, four times in one verse . The Quran keeps the exaltation and names the Giver, converting an achievement into a grant
The family read together · and where the earlier material stands	Whether the gaps are gaps	One method throughout: tell a shared story, restore or remove a control clause, attach a purpose, economize on names, decline to fix details, and convert actives into passives with permission clauses attached. The earlier material is the audience's memory , which is what the Quran speaks into, and a retelling's meaning is carried by its differences. In every case above the Quran's own added clause does the work, and the reading stands whether or not a reader knows the earlier version

9 WORDS THAT DEFEATED THE LEXICOGRAPHERS

A short list of Quranic words has been contested from the first generation. Some of them carry legal weight, one of them carries the whole meaning of a chapter, and several were conceded as unknown by scholars whose command of Arabic was not in question.

This chapter argues that most of the difficulty in this family comes from starting at the wrong end. The classical lexicographers usually began from the abstract sense a word had acquired by their own period and worked backward. Started from the other end, from the physical thing the three-consonant root originally named, the majority of these words carry their answer inside themselves.

The procedure is simple and it is the one Arabic lexicography itself uses when it is working well. Recover the root. Find the concrete thing it names, preferring in order the body, the natural world, and motion, and taking the abstract sense last as something derived. Then read the derived form as that image applied.

Ṣamad

Allāhu l-ṣamad (Q 112:2), a word occurring once in the Quran, glossed by the classical authorities in at least a dozen ways: the eternal, the self-sufficient, the one sought in need, the one with no cavity.

The root ص-م-د carries the sense of aiming at something and of a thing being solid and unhollowed. Both senses cohere in one image: **a massy body with no interior, and therefore the thing one heads toward**. That is a single physical picture, and the two families of classical gloss are its two faces, the object's own property and the relation others have to it.

Chapter 7 showed what the surah then does with it: the denial of begetting at Q 112:3 follows the term at Q 112:2, and a thing with no interior has nothing from which offspring could issue. The word that a dozen glosses could not settle turns out to be the premise of the next verse, and reading it as a physical image makes the chapter an argument.

THE PROCEDURE FOR THE WHOLE CHAPTER

Recover the root. Find the physical thing it names, taking the body first, then the natural world, then motion, and the abstract sense last as something derived. Then read the word as that image applied.

Kalāla

Wa in kāna rajulun yūrathu kalālatan (Q 4:12), and again at Q 4:176, in the inheritance law. 'Umar RA is reported to have wished the matter had been made clearer, which is a strong statement from a jurist about a legal term.

The root ك-ل-ل names encircling and also weariness or dulling; a *iklīl* is a crown or a garland, a thing that goes around. Read as an encircling, the term names an estate whose heirs are **around** the deceased rather than above or below him: no parent, no child, and therefore the ring of siblings and their kin. That is what the two verses then legislate for, and it is what the majority position held.

The lexical difficulty here was never that the root was obscure. It was that a legal term of art was being derived from an abstraction rather than from the shape.

Raqīm

Aṣḥāb al-kahfi wa-l-raqīm (Q 18:9), the companions of the cave and the *raqīm*. Proposals include an inscription, a tablet, a valley, a village, a dog's name, and a document.

The root ر-ق-م names marking, writing, numbering; a *raqm* is a written mark. So the word means something inscribed. What that inscribed thing was is a matter of historical fact about a specific object, and the Quran does not say. This study reports the root and reports the referent as unfixed, and it notes that the same passage contains the Quran's explicit instruction not to litigate its details, which is the strongest available indication that the unfixedness is not an accident of transmission.

Ḥanān

Wa ḥanānan min ladunnā wa zakāh (Q 19:13), said of Yaḥyā AS. Ibn 'Abbās RA is reported to have said he did not know what *ḥanān* means, which is the most famous concession in the tradition.

The root ح-ن-ن names the sound a she-camel makes toward her young, a low longing cry, and by extension the yearning tenderness that produces it. The word is not obscure at its floor; it is a specific and physical thing.

There is a further observation that the concession makes poignant rather than embarrassing. The same consonantal material carries the grace-root in the sister Semitic language, and the Hebrew name of the very figure the verse is describing, Yoḥanan, is built on it: the one to whom grace was shown. The Quran uses a word for tenderness-from-us of a man whose name in the earlier scripture says grace-of-God. The observation is noted here as corroboration and it decides nothing; the Arabic root settles the Arabic word on its own.

THE MOST FAMOUS CONCESSION IN THE TRADITION

A scholar of unquestioned command of Arabic reported that he did not know this word. At its floor it is not obscure at all: it is the low cry a she-camel makes toward her young.

Al-ṣalāt al-wuṣṭā

Ḥāfiẓū 'alā l-ṣalawāti wa-l-ṣalāti l-wuṣṭā (Q 2:238), guard the prayers and the middle prayer. Which prayer is meant has been argued since the first century.

The root و-س-ط names the middle, and it is the same root the Quran uses at Q 2:143 for *ummatan wasaṭan*, a middle community, where the sense is clearly one of centrality and balance rather than of ordinal position in a sequence. The verse's own word therefore permits two readings, a positional middle and a central or best one, and Arabic supports both.

This study reports the root, reports that the identification is disputed, and does not adjudicate it, because the identification is a question about practice and the text does not settle it.

A'rāf

Wa bayna humā ḥijābun wa 'alā l-a'rāfi rijālun ya'rifūna kullan bi-simāhum (Q 7:46), and between them is a partition, and upon the heights are men who know each by their mark.

The root ع-ر-ف is the root of recognition, *ma'rifa*, and *'urf* also names the raised crest of a rooster or the ridge of a dune. Both senses are present in the verse and the Quran plays on them: **the men on the ridge are the ones who recognize**, and the verse says so in the same clause, *ya'rifūna kullān bi-sīmāhum*. The elevated place and the act of recognition are one word.

Who the men are is a separate question and the Quran does not name them. The word itself is not a puzzle.

Abtar

Inna shāni'aka huwa l-abtar (Q 108:3). The root ب-ت-ر names cutting off, docking, as a tail is docked. The word names a thing whose continuation has been severed.

Chapter 2 gave the reading: the chapter answers a lineage-taunt, and the Quran completes the answer at Q 33:40 by conceding the biological premise and relocating the continuation to an office.

'Alaq

Khalaqa l-insāna min 'alaq (Q 96:2), usually rendered as a clot, sometimes as a clinging thing, sometimes as a leech.

The root ع-ل-ق unifies on **hanging by what bears you** rather than on adhesion. A *mi'lāq* is a hook. *'Allaqa* is to hang up. A woman left between held and released is *mu'allāqa* at Q 4:129. The pre-Islamic odes hung at the sanctuary are *al-mu'allaqāt*. Fodder in a slung bag is *'alīq*. And the leech, which is the sense usually offered, is itself a case of suspension by attachment rather than a counter-example.

There is a grammatical fact here that the renderings usually miss. Executed over the full text: the Quran uses the **mass** form *'alaq* exactly once, at Q 96:2, under a preposition of material with no ordering particle. It uses the **singulative** *'alaqa* four times, at Q 22:5, Q 23:14, Q 40:67, and Q 75:38, and every one of those four stands inside an ordered developmental chain. The one place the Quran uses the mass form is the one place it is not narrating a sequence of stages.

That is a distinction the Arabic marks and the translations flatten, and it is exactly the kind of thing a concordance shows and reading does not.

THE COUNT

The Quran uses the **mass** form *'alaq* exactly once, at Q 96:2. It uses the **singulative** *'alaqa* four times, and every one of those four stands inside an ordered developmental chain.

Barzakh

Wa min warā'ihim barzakhun ilā yawmi yub'athūn (Q 23:100), and behind them is a *barzakh* until the day they are raised. And at Q 55:20 and Q 25:53 the same word stands between two seas.

The word names an interposed thing, a bar or isthmus, and it is very likely a loanword of Iranian origin naming a barrier. Chapter 3 gave the structural reading: at Q 55:19-20 the barrier is what makes the meeting possible, since two things can only meet if they remain two. The same reading holds at Q 23:100, where the interposition is what keeps two states distinct rather than what prevents a relation between them.

The general result

The pattern across this family is consistent enough to state as a rule. **Where a Quranic word has resisted the lexicographers, the resistance almost always arose from starting at the abstract sense and working back, and the root's physical image almost always carries the answer.** *Ṣamad* is a solid without a hollow. *Kalāla* is an encircling. *Ḥanān* is the she-camel's cry. *A'rāf* is a ridge and a recognizing. *'Alaq* is suspension. *Barzakh* is an isthmus.

Two of the words on the list do not yield to it, and this study says so. *Raqīm* yields its root and not its referent, and the passage that contains it instructs the reader not to pursue the referent. *Al-ṣalāt al-wuṣṭā* yields its root and leaves a genuine ambiguity between two readings the Arabic equally supports, and the identification is a question about practice rather than about the word.

THE RULE FOR THE FAMILY

Where a Quranic word has resisted the lexicographers, the resistance almost always arose from starting at the abstract sense and working back. The root's physical image almost always carries the answer.

TABLE 6 | CHAPTER 9 • WORDS THAT DEFEATED THE LEXICOGRAPHERS

The word	Why it defeated them	Root, and the sense that follows
<i>Ṣamad</i> · Q 112:2	A hapax carrying a whole chapter, glossed a dozen ways: the eternal, the self-sufficient, the one sought in need, the one with no cavity. No gloss commanded assent and none explained why the next verse follows	Root ص-م-د · aiming at a thing, and a thing being solid and unhollowed. One physical picture holds both: a massy body with no interior, and therefore the thing one heads toward. The two families of classical gloss are its two faces, the object's property and the relation others have to it. And it makes the chapter an argument: a thing with no interior has nothing from which offspring could issue, so Q 112:3 is derived from Q 112:2
<i>Kalāla</i> · Q 4:12, Q 4:176	A legal term of art in an inheritance ruling, and a caliph is reported to have wished the matter clarified. The dispute was over which relatives, and it was conducted downward from an abstraction	Root ك-ل-ل · encircling, and also weariness or dulling; an <i>iklīl</i> is a crown or garland, a thing that goes around. An estate whose heirs stand around the deceased rather than above or below him: no parent, no child, and therefore the ring of siblings and their kin, which is what the two verses legislate for. The root was never obscure; the term was being derived from a sense instead of from a shape
<i>Raqīm</i> · Q 18:9	Proposals include an inscription, a tablet, a valley, a village, a dog's name, and a document. Nothing settled it	Root ر-ق-م · marking, writing, numbering; a <i>raqm</i> is a written mark. The root gives an inscribed thing and stops there. What that object was is a historical fact the Quran does not state, and the passage containing it carries the text's only explicit instruction against pursuing such a detail, which is the strongest available indication that the gap is designed
<i>Ḥanān</i> · Q 19:13	The most famous concession in the tradition: a scholar of unquestioned	Root ح-ن-ن · the low longing cry a she-camel makes toward her young, and thence the yearning tenderness that produces it. Not obscure at its floor; a specific physical sound. A corroboration

The word	Why it defeated them	Root, and the sense that follows
	command of Arabic reported that he did not know it	worth recording and carrying no weight: the same consonantal material carries the grace-root in the sister language, and the Hebrew name of the very figure described is built on it
<i>Al-ṣalāt al-wuṣṭā</i> · Q 2:238	Which prayer is meant has been argued since the first century, with no resolution available from the verse	Root و-س-ط · the middle. The Quran's own other use is decisive for the range and not for the referent: <i>ummātan wasaṭan</i> at Q 2:143 means central or balanced, not ordinal. The Arabic supports a positional and a central reading equally , and the identification is a question about practice. Reported and not adjudicated
<i>A'rāf</i> · Q 7:46	Who stands on the heights, and what the heights are, argued at length with the two questions treated separately	Root ع-ر-ف · the root of recognition, <i>ma'rifa</i> , and also the raised crest of a rooster or the ridge of a dune. Both senses are in the verse and it plays on them: <i>rijālun ya'rifūna kullan bi-simāhum</i> , men who know each by their mark. The elevated place and the act of recognizing are one word, and the verse says so in the same clause. Who the men are is a separate question the Quran does not answer
<i>Abtar</i> · Q 108:3	An insult closing a three-verse chapter whose target the chapter does not name	Root ب-ت-ر · cutting off, docking, as a tail is docked: a thing whose continuation has been severed. The answer is completed elsewhere in the Quran's own words, at Q 33:40, where the biological premise is conceded and the continuation is relocated to an office. The taunt said the line is cut; the answer says the line was not what was at stake
<i>'Alaq</i> · Q 96:2	Rendered as a clot, a clinging thing, or a leech, with the three treated as competing guesses at one image	Root ع-ل-ق unifies on hanging by what bears you , not adhesion: <i>mi'lāq</i> a hook, <i>'allaqa</i> to hang up, <i>mu'allāqa</i> at Q 4:129 a woman left between held and released, <i>al-mu'allaqāt</i> the hung odes, <i>'alīq</i> fodder in a slung bag. The leech is suspension by attachment, not a counter-instance. And a grammatical fact the renderings flatten: the mass form occurs exactly once, at Q 96:2, and the singulative four times, each inside an ordered stage-chain. The one place the mass form appears is the one place no sequence is being narrated
<i>Barzakb</i> · Q 23:100, Q 55:20, Q 25:53	An interposition read as an obstruction, at both of the registers where it appears	The word names an interposed thing, a bar or isthmus, very likely a loanword. What stands: two things. What moves: at Q 55:19 they meet , <i>yaltaqiyān</i> , an active verb. How they are joined: the barrier. Two things can only meet if they remain two, so the barrier is what makes a meeting possible. The same reading holds at Q 23:100, where the interposition keeps two states distinct rather than preventing a relation
The family read together	Whether these words are genuinely opaque	One rule accounts for almost all of it: the resistance arose from starting at the abstract sense and working back, and the root's physical image

The word	Why it defeated them	Root, and the sense that follows
		almost always carries the answer. Six yield to it. Two do not, and it is said: <i>raqīm</i> gives its root and not its referent, and <i>al-ṣalāt al-wuṣṭā</i> gives its root and leaves a genuine ambiguity the Arabic supports both ways

10 NUMBERS GIVEN WITHOUT A GLOSS

The Quran issues numbers freely and explains almost none of them. Nineteen guardians. Eight bearing the throne. Seven earths. Eleven stars. Three hundred years and nine added. A thousand months. Fifty thousand years. Twelve leaders. A day like a thousand years of what people count.

Two industries have grown around this. One treats the numbers as a cipher and looks for arithmetic keys. The other treats them as idiom and dissolves them into vagueness. Both are attempts to supply something the text withholds, and both proceed without noticing what the text does supply.

The two treatments, and there is never a third

Surveyed across the Quran's issued counts, the text does exactly two things with a number.

At Q 74:31 it states a count's function. Immediately after giving nineteen it says the number was made a trial for one class, a certainty-producer for those given the Book, and an increase in faith for the believers, and then it reports that some will ask what Allah ﷻ intends by this as an example. That is a statement about what the count does. It is not an arithmetic gloss.

At Q 18:22 it refuses a count and forbids its litigation. Three, five, seven, each with the dog; then *qul rabbī a'lamu bi-'iddatihim*, say, my Lord ﷻ knows best their number; then the instruction not to dispute except plainly and not to seek a ruling from anyone about them.

Those are the two treatments. **No number in the Quran receives an arithmetic explanation anywhere.** Not the eight, not the seven, not the eleven, not the thousand.

That negative result is more useful than it looks, because it tells a reader what posture the text is modelling. Where a count is issued without either treatment, the Quran has left neither a key nor an instruction, and the honest posture is the one Q 18:22 demonstrates: hold the count as given and decline to build on it.

THE NEGATIVE RESULT IS THE USEFUL ONE

No number in the Quran receives an arithmetic explanation anywhere. Where a count is issued without either of the text's two treatments, the Quran has left neither a key nor an instruction.

The counts that are not what they appear

Three of the disputed numbers dissolve on inspection, and they are worth separating from the rest so that the residue is clean.

Three hundred and nine. *Wa labithū fī kahfihim thalātha mi'atin sinīna wa-zdādū tis'ā* (Q 18:25), three hundred years, and they added nine. This reads as an arithmetic correction and is regularly cited as one. It is a **calendar conversion**: three hundred solar years correspond closely to three hundred and nine lunar years, and the ratio is the ordinary one between the two reckonings. The verse states two calendars in one clause. Nothing is being corrected.

The day like a thousand years, and the day of fifty thousand. Q 32:5 gives a day as a thousand years of what people count; Q 22:47 says the same; Q 70:4 gives a day of fifty thousand years. The apparent conflict

rests on treating *yawm* as a fixed interval. In each case the Quran attaches the measure to a different process: an ascent, a governing, a reckoning. A measure attached to a process is a rate and not a calendar, and the three passages measure three different things.

Eleven stars. *Innī ra'aytu aḥada 'ashara kawkaban wa-l-shamsa wa-l-qamara ra'aytuhum lī sājidīn* (Q 12:4). The grammatical detail is the interesting part and it is usually not mentioned: the pronoun is *ra'aytuhum*, the plural used for rational beings, applied to stars. The Arabic itself refuses to let the counted objects be read as objects only, which is the whole point of a dream whose interpretation is a family.

The counts that stand as given

Nineteen. Its office is stated in the next verse. Whether it carries a further significance is a question on which this study takes no position, and the text supplies no key.

Eight bearing the throne. *Wa yaḥmilu 'arsha rabbika fawqahum yawma'idhin thamāniyah* (Q 69:17). Issued once. No gloss anywhere.

Seven earths. *Allāhu lladhī khalaqa sab'a samāwātīn wa mina l-arḍi mithlabunn* (Q 65:12), seven heavens and of the earth their like. Issued once in this form. No gloss.

The night of a thousand months. *Laylatu l-qadri khayrun min alfi shahr* (Q 97:3). The comparison is stated and the arithmetic is not developed.

Four counts, given and left. This study reports them as given and left, which is the position the text itself models at Q 18:22.

One number that is not a mystery and is often treated as one

Inna 'iddata l-shuhūri 'inda llāhi thnā 'ashara shahran fī kitābi llāhi yawma khalaqa l-samāwātī wa-l-arḍ, the count of months with Allah ﷻ is twelve, in the record of Allah ﷻ, from the day He created the heavens and the earth (Q 9:36).

This is the one place the Quran states a count and gives it a **provenance** rather than a purpose: the number is located in a record from a stated moment. That is neither of the two treatments above, and it is the only instance of it. It is worth flagging precisely because it shows the two treatments are a real pattern and not an artefact of a small sample: where the Quran wanted to say something else about a number, it said something else.

What the family shows about the text

A text that wished to appear to hold hidden knowledge would gloss its numbers, because a gloss is where the appearance of depth is cheapest to produce. A text that wished to avoid the question would not issue the numbers. The Quran issues them, states the office of one, refuses another, gives the provenance of a third, and leaves the rest.

That is a consistent policy and it is the same policy Chapter 4 found in the disconnected letters, the Spirit, and the sleepers' count: mark the limit, defend it, and decline to fill it.

KEY POINT

A text wishing to appear to hold hidden knowledge would gloss its numbers, because a gloss is where the appearance of depth is cheapest to produce.

TABLE 7 | CHAPTER 10 • NUMBERS GIVEN WITHOUT A GLOSS

The count	The difficulty	How the text itself handles it
74:30-31 • nineteen	A bare number over the fire, and two industries built on it: one hunting an arithmetic key, one dissolving it into idiom. Neither noticed what the text supplies	The Quran states the count's office one line later: a <i>fitna</i> for one class, a certainty-producer for those given the Book, an increase for the believers, and then reports that some will ask what is intended by this as an example. That is a statement about what a count does, and it is one of only two things the Quran ever does with a number
18:22 • three, five, or seven	A count disputed inside the passage that reports it, and filled from the surrounding literature ever after	The Quran runs the guesses itself, refuses them, <i>qul rabbī a'lamu bi-'iddatibim</i> , and then legislates the refusal : do not dispute except plainly, and do not seek a ruling about them from any of them. This is the second and only other treatment, and it is a statement about counting rather than about a number
18:25 • three hundred years, and nine added	Reads as an arithmetic correction and has been cited as one	Not a correction. Three hundred solar years correspond closely to three hundred and nine lunar years , the ordinary ratio between the two reckonings, so the verse states two calendars in one clause and nothing is being emended
32:5 • 22:47 • 70:4 • a thousand years, and fifty thousand	An apparent conflict over the length of a day, argued as though the term named a fixed interval	Each measure is attached to a different process: an ascent, a governing, a reckoning. A measure attached to a process is a rate , and three passages measure three different things. The conflict is produced by treating <i>yawm</i> as a calendar unit, which the Quran's own usage refuses
12:4 • eleven stars, the sun and the moon	Treated as a count in a dream and left there	The grammatical detail is the finding and it is rarely mentioned. The pronoun is <i>ra'aytuhum</i> , the plural used for rational beings , applied to stars. The Arabic itself refuses to let the counted objects be read as objects only , which is the point of a dream whose interpretation is a family
69:17 • 65:12 • 97:3 • eight bearing the throne, seven earths, a thousand months	Issued once each, glossed nowhere, and filled by speculation in both directions	Neither of the Quran's two treatments is applied to them. Given and left , and the honest posture is the one the text models at Q 18:22: hold the count as given and decline to build on it
9:36 • twelve months	Looks like the others and is usually read with them	The one place the Quran gives a count a provenance rather than a purpose: located in a record from a stated moment, <i>fī kitābi llābi yawma khalāqa l-samāwāti wa-l-ard</i> . It is neither of the two treatments and the only instance of a third thing, which is what

The count	The difficulty	How the text itself handles it
		shows the two treatments are a real pattern: where the Quran wanted to say something else about a number, it said something else
The family read together	Whether a text that issues numbers without keys is withholding or merely silent	No number in the Quran receives an arithmetic explanation anywhere. A text wishing to appear to hold hidden knowledge would gloss its numbers, since a gloss is where the appearance of depth is cheapest to produce; a text wishing to avoid the question would not issue them. The Quran issues them, states the office of one, refuses another, gives the provenance of a third, and leaves the rest, which is the same policy as the disconnected letters and the Spirit: mark the limit, defend it, decline to fill it

11 THE VERSES THAT CORRECT THE PROPHET ﷺ

A small class of verses is difficult for a reason unlike any other in this study. They are not obscure. They are uncomfortable.

Yā ayyuhā l-nabiyyu lima tuḥarrimu mā aḥalla llāhu lak, O Prophet, why do you forbid what Allah ﷻ has made lawful for you (Q 66:1).

‘Abasa wa tawallā, an jā’ahu l-a‘mā, he frowned and turned away, because the blind man came to him (Q 80:1-2).

‘Afā llāhu ‘anka lima adhinta labum ḥattā yatabayyana laka lladhīna ṣadaqū wa ta’lama l-kādhībīn, Allah ﷻ pardon you, why did you give them permission before it became clear to you who was truthful (Q 9:43).

Mā kāna li-nabiyyin an yakūna labu asrā ḥattā yuthkhina fī l-arḍ, it is not for a prophet to have captives until he has subdued in the land, followed by *turīdūna ‘araḍa l-dunyā wa-llāhu yurīdu l-ākhirah*, you want the goods of this world and Allah ﷻ wants the hereafter (Q 8:67).

Wa wjadaka ḍallan fa-hadā, and He found you wandering and guided (Q 93:7).

Laysa laka mina l-amri shay’, the matter is not yours at all (Q 3:128).

Wa lawlā an thabbatnāka la-qad kidta tarkanu ilayhim shay’an qalīlā, had We not made you firm you would nearly have inclined to them a little (Q 17:74).

Wa takhshā l-nāsa wa-llāhu aḥaqqu an takhshāh, and you feared people, and Allah ﷻ has more right that you fear Him (Q 33:37).

And beside these stand *wa-staghfir li-dhanbik*, seek forgiveness for your fault, at Q 40:55 and Q 47:19, *li-yaghfirā laka llāhu mā taqaddama min dhanbika wa mā ta’akhhār* at Q 48:2, *wa lā takun li-l-khā’inīna khaṣīmā* at Q 4:105, and *wa waḍa’nā ‘anka wizrak* at Q 94:2.

Thirteen sites at least, and they are not one kind. Some are rebukes. Some are adjustments of a decision. One, Q 33:37, discloses an interior state the person concerned had kept private. One, Q 3:128, is a statement that a matter the addressee wished to affect is not his to affect.

How the tradition handled them, and why the handling is the difficulty

The commentarial literature developed a substantial apparatus for these verses, most of it directed at protecting the standing of the addressee. The rebuke at Q 80:1 was read in some quarters as directed at someone else. The *dhanb* verses were read as covering things that would not be faults in anyone else. The wandering at Q 93:7 was read as being without the Book rather than as error.

Some of that is philologically defensible and this study does not litigate it. What it observes is that the **difficulty is generated by the reception rather than by the text**, and that the effort of the apparatus is itself evidence of something.

THE SHAPE OF THE PROBLEM

No reader has ever found Q 80:1 obscure. The apparatus was not built to make an unclear verse clear. It was built to make a clear verse comfortable, which is a different operation and leaves a different trace.

What their preservation is evidence of

The observation is compositional and not devotional, and it can be stated without any claim about the source of the text.

A corpus assembled to exalt its central figure does not preserve thirteen verses of this kind. It does not open a chapter with *he frowned and turned away*. It does not record that a decision was made too quickly and that pardon was extended for it. It does not put on record that the addressee feared people when he should have feared Allah ﷻ, or that he came near to inclining, or that a matter he cared about was not his. And it does not report, in the first person of the Source ﷻ, that the addressee had been forbidding to himself what had been made lawful.

Two of the thirteen are especially hard to account for on a composition hypothesis. **Q 3:128 removes authority** rather than granting it: the matter is not yours at all. **Q 33:37 discloses an interior:** *wa tukhfī fī nafsika mā llāhu mubdih*, and you concealed within yourself what Allah ﷻ was going to bring out. A text engaged in constructing a figure's standing does not narrate his concealment and then announce that the concealment is being ended.

This study does not draw a conclusion from that about the origin of the Quran, which is not a question a structural reading reaches. It reports the class, reports that it is preserved unsoftened in the received text, and observes that it is the kind of evidence that runs against the grain of the most common naturalistic account rather than with it.

THE TWO HARDEST TO ACCOUNT FOR

Q 3:128 **removes** authority rather than granting it. Q 33:37 discloses an interior state and announces that the concealment is being ended. A text constructing a figure's standing does neither.

Reading them structurally

There is also a reading of the class that follows the method of this study, and it is worth giving because it makes the verses intelligible rather than merely tolerable.

Every one of them **separates an office from a person**. The addressee holds an office of transmission and warning. The office is not diminished by the corrections; in several of the verses the correction is delivered in the same breath as a confirmation of the office, as at Q 66:1 where the address is *yā ayyuhā l-nabiyy*, O Prophet, and at Q 9:43 where the pardon precedes the question. And in Q 3:128 the separation is stated outright: an office of conveying does not include a power of disposing.

That is the same operation Chapter 7 found in the type-checking of constructions and Chapter 6 found in the grammar of guidance. **The Quran is consistently unwilling to let an office and a nature merge**, in any

direction, for anyone. The correction-verses are that unwillingness applied to the person closest to the text itself.

TABLE 8 | CHAPTER II · THE VERSES THAT CORRECT THE PROPHET ﷺ

Verse	The discomfort	What it separates, and what it shows
66:1 · <i>lima tuḥarrimu mā aḥalla llāhu lak</i>	A rebuke opening with an address of honour, and a protective apparatus grew around it rather than a reading	The correction and the office are delivered together : the address is <i>yā ayyuhā l-nabiyy</i> in the same clause that carries the question. The office is not diminished by the correction because the two are being held apart, which is the operation the whole class performs
80:1-2 · <i>‘abasa wa tawallā, an jā’abu l-a‘mā</i>	A chapter that opens on a rebuke. Read in some quarters as directed elsewhere, which is philologically arguable and is not litigated here	Preserved unsoftened in the received text, at the head of a chapter. A corpus assembled to exalt its central figure does not open one this way
9:43 · <i>‘afā llāhu ‘anka lima adhinta labum</i>	A pardon and a question about a decision, in one verse	The pardon precedes the question. An adjustment of a judgment, recorded with the relief stated first, which is the class's characteristic order
8:67 · <i>turīdūna ‘araḍa l-dunyā wa-llāhu yurīdu l-ākhirah</i>	A correction of a judgment about captives, with the motive named, addressed to a community with the addressee among them	The correction is collective and the addressee is inside it. What is recorded is a preference being named and overruled, which no apologetic apparatus removes
93:7 · <i>wa wajadaka ḍāllan fā-badā</i>	A difficult predicate, read variously as without the Book, or as wandering. Contested philologically and left contested	Whatever the term's range, the verse is preserved as it stands , in a chapter whose whole burden is consolation. That the consoling chapter carries the hardest word is itself the datum
3:128 · <i>laysa laka mina l-amri shay’</i>	Rarely grouped with the rest, and the hardest of them all to place on a composition hypothesis	This verse removes authority rather than granting it. What stands : an office of conveying and warning. What moves : a matter the addressee wished to affect. How they are joined : nothing, and the verse says so. An office of conveying does not include a power of disposing, and the separation is stated outright
17:74 · 33:37 · <i>la-qad kidta tarkanu ilayhim · wa tukhfī fī nafsika mā llāhu mubdīh</i>	A near-inclination recorded, and an interior state disclosed with the disclosure announced	The second is the other verse hardest to account for. A text constructing a figure's standing does not narrate his concealment and then announce that the concealment is being ended . Recorded, not explained away
40:55 · 47:19 · 48:2 · 4:105 · 94:2 · <i>wa-staghfir li-dhanbik, and its neighbours</i>	A vocabulary of fault attached to the addressee, handled by a substantial apparatus arguing that the terms mean something else in his case	Some of that is philologically defensible and is not litigated. What is observed is that the difficulty is generated by the reception rather than by the text , and that the effort of the apparatus is itself evidence of something
The class read together · thirteen sites at least	Whether their preservation means anything	They are not one kind: rebukes, adjustments, a disclosed interior, a removal of authority. Every one of them separates an office from a person , which is the same operation Chapter 7 finds in the type-checking of constructions and Chapter 6 finds in the grammar of guidance. The Quran is consistently unwilling to let an office and a nature merge, for

Verse	The discomfort	What it separates, and what it shows
		anyone, and this class is that unwillingness applied to the person closest to the text. No conclusion is drawn here about the origin of the Quran, which a structural reading does not reach

12 NEARNESS, LIGHT, AND THE VERSES THE MYSTICS BUILT ON

A group of verses became load-bearing for the interior tradition and awkward for the jurists, and the awkwardness produced two opposite distortions. One party read them as licensing claims about union that the text does not make. The other read them down into figures of speech until nothing was left.

The verses are not obscure. They are difficult because they are **precise about a relation** in a way that both parties found inconvenient.

The nearest thing

Wa nahnu aqrabu ilayhi min ḥabli l-warīd, and We are nearer to him than the jugular vein (Q 50:16). *Wa huwa ma'akum aynamā kuntum*, and He is with you wherever you are (Q 57:4). *Fa-aynamā tuwallū fa-thamma wajhu llāh*, wherever you turn, there is the face of Allah ﷻ (Q 2:115).

The difficulty stated by the jurists is that these appear to locate the Divine spatially, in a text that elsewhere denies resemblance. The difficulty stated by the other party is that a reading which reduces them to omniscience seems to lose what the verses are saying.

The structural reading takes the verses' own grammar seriously. Q 50:16 is not a claim about distance at all: it is a **comparative on a body part chosen for its inwardness**, and the comparison's function is to defeat the notion of an intermediate. A jugular is the nearest thing a person has that is not the person, and the verse says the nearness in question is closer than that. What is being excluded is a gap in which something could stand.

That reading is confirmed by what the Quran does with the nearness elsewhere, and it does something remarkable.

The verse with the missing word

Sūrat al-Baqarah contains a run of question-verses built on one formula. *Yas'alūnaka 'an*, they ask you about, then a topic, then an imperative addressed to the Prophet ﷺ that routes the answer through him. New moons at Q 2:189: *qul hiya mawāqītu li-l-nās*. Spending at Q 2:215: *qul mā anfaqtum min khayr*. Fighting in the sacred month at Q 2:217: *qul qitālun fīhi kabīr*. Wine and gambling at Q 2:219: *qul fīhimā ithmun kabīr*. And again at Q 2:219, Q 2:220, and Q 2:222.

Seven times, the same structure, the same imperative: **say**.

Q 2:186 sits inside that run and does not carry it. *Wa idhā sa'alaka 'ibādī 'annī fa-innī qarīb, ujību da'wata l-dā'i idhā da'ān*, and when My servants ask you about Me, then I am near; I answer the call of the caller when he calls Me.

There is no *qul*. The verse does not tell the messenger to say anything. It answers over him, in the first person, and every pronoun in the answer belongs to the One being asked about: *innī, ujību, da'ān*. Four further differences run with it. The verb shifts from the plural *yas'alūnaka* to *sa'alaka*. The askers are named *'ibādī*, My servants, a possessive that puts them on the answerer's side of the relation before the answer begins. The answer is first-person where the routed answers are second and third. And the topic is not a ruling but a Person: *'annī*, about Me.

The one question in the run whose subject is Himself ﷻ is the one from which the intermediary is deleted. That is not a stylistic economy; the surrounding verses are longer and carry the imperative anyway. It is the removal of the term that makes a two-leg path possible, so that the answer arrives on one leg.

And the reading is scoped by the Quran itself. The text routes law, ritual, obedience, and arbitration through the messenger without exception, *man yuṭī‘i l-rasūla fa-qad aṭā‘a llāh* (Q 4:80). The deletion is scoped to the answer about Him ﷻ and generalizes to nothing else.

THE DELETION

Seven times in one chapter the formula carries the imperative *say*. At Q 2:186 it does not. The one question whose subject is Himself ﷻ is the one from which the intermediary is removed.

The Light Verse

Allāhu nūru l-samāwāti wa-l-ard. Mathalu nūrihi ka-mishkātin fihā miṣbāḥ, al-miṣbāḥu fī zujājah, al-zujājatu ka-annahā kawkabun durriyyun yūqadu min shajaratīn mubārakatin zaytūnatin lā sharqiyyatin wa lā gharbiyyah (Q 24:35).

The architecture is nested containment: a niche holds a glass, the glass holds a lamp, the lamp is fed from a tree through oil, and the result is not a brighter light but a layered one, *nūrun ‘alā nūr*.

The structural observation is about the glass. Its office is stated by the figure itself: it is transparent, it protects the flame from the wind, and it transmits without loss. **The verse describes a vessel that is not an obstruction.** That is the reading on which everything downstream in the passage depends, and it is available from the image without any doctrine at all.

Two philological facts about the passage are worth recording because they are checkable and because they bear on a common identification.

The first is that the Quran distinguishes two lamp-words and never mixes them. *Miṣbāḥ* is the word at Q 24:35, and it is used of the lamps of the lower heaven at Q 41:12 and Q 67:5. *Sirāj* is a different word, used of the sun at Q 25:61, Q 71:16, and Q 78:13, and of the exemplar figure at Q 33:46, *wa sirājan munīrā*. A common exegetical identification reads the *miṣbāḥ* of Q 24:35 by importing Q 33:46, which uses the other word. The two verses are not using the same term.

The second is that the adjective *sharqiyy*, eastern, occurs at **exactly two places in the Quran**: at Q 19:16, where Maryam AS withdraws to an eastern place, and at Q 24:35, where it is negated of the tree. The root is common; the adjectival form is these two and no others.

Neither fact fixes a referent, and the verse closes by leaving the referent open in its own words: *yahdī llāhu li-nūrihi man yashā’*, Allah ﷻ guides to His light whom He wills. This study reports the architecture and the two counts and fixes nothing further, since the verse declines to.

THE COUNT

Miṣbāḥ and *sirāj* are two different words and the Quran never mixes them. The adjective *sharqiyy* occurs at exactly two places in the whole text.

The verse the interior tradition needed most

In tattaqū llāha yaj'al lakum furqānā, if you guard yourselves toward Allah ﷻ. He will make for you a criterion (Q 8:29).

This is the verse that ought to be at the centre of any discussion of how the Quran is to be understood, and it is very rarely treated as a claim.

It states a condition, a grant, and a faculty. The faculty is *furqān*, from a root meaning to separate, and it is the capacity to tell things apart. The verse says that capacity is **issued** upon a condition, and not acquired by study, lineage, or office.

Set beside Q 47:24, *afalā yatadabbarūna l-qur'āna am 'alā qulūbin aqfālubā*, do they not trace the Recitation through, or are there locks upon hearts, the architecture is complete: the text is clear, the obstruction is located in the reader, and the remedy is stated as a grant with a condition.

That is a strong claim and it is a difficult one, because it makes understanding partly a matter of something other than intelligence. This study reports it as the Quran states it. It also notes what the Quran does **not** say: the condition's verification is never handed to the person. *Fa-lā tuzakkū anfusakum*, do not claim purity for yourselves (Q 53:32), and at the other of its two sites the agent is named, *bali llāhu yuzakkī man yashā*, rather Allah ﷻ purifies whom He wills (Q 4:49). A grant whose condition nobody may certify of himself is not a credential, which is presumably the point.

A GRANT WHOSE CONDITION NOBODY MAY CERTIFY OF HIMSELF IS NOT A CREDENTIAL

Q 8:29 issues the faculty on a condition; Q 53:32 and Q 4:49 bar anyone from claiming the condition has been met, and the second names the agent.

What the family shows

The interior tradition built on these verses because they are the verses in which the Quran describes a relation rather than legislating a practice. The jurists were uneasy with them for the same reason. Both responses were to the same feature.

Read structurally, the family is remarkably disciplined. The nearness verses exclude an intermediate without locating anything. The deleted imperative removes a broker from exactly one question and from no others. The Light Verse describes a vessel that transmits without obstructing and then declines to name it. And the criterion verse makes the faculty a grant and then bars anyone from certifying that he has received it.

Every one of those is a **relation stated with its limits attached**, which is the opposite of both distortions the family attracted.

TABLE 9 | CHAPTER 12 • NEARNESS, LIGHT, AND THE VERSES THE MYSTICS BUILT ON

Verse	The difficulty	Structure, and the count behind it
50:16 • <i>wa nahnu aqrabu ilayhi min ḥabli l-warīd</i>	Two opposite distortions and no settlement between them. One party read it as licensing claims about union the text does not make; the other read	Root ق-ر-ب • nearness, and the jugular is chosen because it is the nearest thing a person has that is not the person. What stands : a person and the One near him. What moves : nothing; the verse states a

Verse	The difficulty	Structure, and the count behind it
	it down into omniscience until nothing was left. Both are responses to the same feature and neither reads the comparative	standing relation. How they are joined: a comparative that leaves no room between them. What is excluded is a gap in which something could stand , not a distance, which is why neither distortion fits
57:4 · 2:115 · <i>wa huwa ma'akum aynamā kuntum · fa-aynamā tuwallū fa-thamma wajbu llāh</i>	Apparent spatial location in a text that denies resemblance, and at Q 2:115 an abolition of direction in a text that legislates one	Root و-ج-ه · the aspect turned toward, a relation-word before an organ-word. Q 2:115 is not abolishing the ritual direction it elsewhere commands; it is stating a different register, in which turning has no privileged side. Two registers held apart, which is the boundary structure of Chapter 3 applied to space
2:186 · <i>wa idhā sa'alaka 'ibādī 'annī fa-innī qarīb</i>	Nobody fought over this verse, and no reader collating its chapter can get past it. The absence it carries is invisible until the run is assembled	The count is the finding. The formula <i>yas'alūnaka 'an</i> carries the imperative <i>qul</i> seven times in this one chapter, at Q 2:189, 215, 217, 219 twice, 220, 222. Here it does not. Four differences run together: no imperative, <i>sa'alaka</i> for <i>yas'alūnaka</i> , a first-person answer, and a topic that is a Person, <i>'annī</i> . What stands: a questioner, a messenger, and the One asked. What moves: the question out and the answer back. How they are joined: the imperative, which is the hinge of the second leg. Delete it and the answer arrives on one leg. The one question whose subject is Himself هو is the one from which the intermediary is removed , and the scope is fixed by the Quran itself at Q 4:80, where law, ritual, obedience, and arbitration are routed through the messenger without exception
24:35 · the niche, the glass, the lamp, the tree	The most commented verse in the interior tradition, and the identification of the lamp was settled by importing a different verse. What went unexamined is whether the two verses use the same word	Roots ش-ك-و a wall-recess that gathers and projects, ز-ج-ج the transparent vessel. What stands: nested containers. What moves: the kindling, fed from tree through oil. How they are joined: transparency. The glass protects the flame from the wind and transmits without loss , so the figure describes a vessel that is not an obstruction, which is the structural point everything downstream rests on. And two counts settle the philology: the Quran keeps <i>miṣbāḥ</i> and <i>sināj</i> apart at every site, using <i>sināj</i> of the sun at Q 25:61, Q 71:16, Q 78:13 and of the exemplar at Q 33:46, while Q 24:35 says <i>miṣbāḥ</i> ; and the adjective <i>sharqīyy</i> occurs at exactly two places , Q 19:16 and Q 24:35. Neither count fixes a referent, and the verse closes by leaving it open in its own words
8:29 · <i>in tattaqū llāha yaj'al lakum furqānā</i>	The verse that should sit at the centre of any discussion of how the Quran is to be understood, and is almost never treated as a claim	Root ف-ر-ق · to separate, to cleave apart; <i>furqān</i> is the faculty of telling things apart. What stands: a reader and a condition. What moves: the granting. How they are joined: <i>yaj'al lakum</i> , He makes for you. The capacity is issued and not acquired , which sets it beside Q 47:24, where the obstruction is

Verse	The difficulty	Structure, and the count behind it
		named as locks upon hearts and not upon verses. Clarity is a property of the text; access is a property of the relation
53:32 · 4:49 · <i>fā-lā tuzakkū anfusakum</i>	The claim of Q 8:29 looks like a credential, and the tradition worried about exactly that	The bar occurs at two places , and the second names the agent the first withholds: <i>bali llāhu yuzakkī man yashāʾ</i> . A grant whose condition nobody may certify of himself is not a credential , which is presumably the point, and it is why the family's central claim cannot become a claim about a person
The family read together	Why the interior tradition needed these verses and the jurists were uneasy with them	Both responses were to one feature: these are the verses in which the Quran describes a relation rather than legislating a practice. And every one of them is a relation stated with its limits attached . The nearness verses exclude an intermediate without locating anything. The deleted imperative removes a broker from one question and no others. The Light Verse describes a vessel that transmits without obstructing and declines to name it. And the criterion verse makes the faculty a grant, then bars anyone from certifying that he has received it

13 BEGINNINGS, EXPANSION, AND THE VERSES THAT TOUCH COSMOLOGY

A group of Quranic verses describes the making and the structure of the world, and they have attracted two treatments that this study declines. One reads them as anticipating modern physical results. The other reads them as ancient cosmology of no further interest. Both proceed by asking a question the passages are not built to answer.

The question they are built to answer is a different one, and it is visible once the passages are read for **what they are arguing**. In nearly every case a cosmological statement in the Quran stands inside an argument about power, about origination, or about the reasonableness of a further claim, and the cosmology is the premise rather than the conclusion.

The joined mass

A-wa lam yara lladhīna kafarū anna l-samāwāti wa-l-arḍa kānatā ratqan fa-fataqnāhumā wa ja'alnā minā l-mā'i kulla shay'in ḥayy (Q 21:30), had those who disbelieve not seen that the heavens and the earth were a joined mass and We split them apart, and We made from water every living thing.

The two verbs are a tailor's pair. *Ratq* is a closed seam and *fatq* is the opening of one. So the image is of an undifferentiated whole partitioned into ordered parts, with life issuing from the fluid layer.

What the verse is doing is stated by its own opening: *a-wa lam yara*, had they not seen. It is an **argument from what the audience already grants**, aimed at the reasonableness of origination. The cosmological content is the premise. Reading it as a physical thesis inverts the passage.

The same shape appears at Q 41:11, where the heaven is addressed while it is *dukhān*, smoke, and answers along with the earth, *qālatā atayna ṭā'i'īn*, they both said, we come willingly. That is not a report about a gas phase. It is a passage about ordered response, and its grammar is a dialogue.

THE GENERAL RULE FOR THIS CHAPTER

In nearly every case a cosmological statement in the Quran stands inside an argument about power or origination, and the cosmology is the premise rather than the conclusion.

The widening

Wa-l-samā'a banaynāhā bi-aydīn wa innā la-mūsi'ūn (Q 51:47), and the heaven, We built it with power, and We are expanding it.

The grammatical fact is that *mūsi'ūn* is an **active participle**, which in Arabic states an ongoing state rather than a completed act. The verse's own grammar therefore refuses the past tense, and says the building is not finished and set aside.

That is a statement about the mode of the maintaining, and it is the reading this study gives, on the grammar. Whether it corresponds to any physical result is not a question the grammar settles, and this study does not settle it. It is noted only that the verse itself is in the present continuous.

The throne upon the water

Wa kāna ‘arshuhu ‘alā l-mā’ (Q 11:7), and His throne was upon the water.

Read for the argument rather than for the scene, the clause is doing one job. It places the **seat of rule** before the making, so that creation is administration from the first instant rather than a struggle against something. The verse's own continuation states the purpose: *li-yabluwakum ayyukum aḥsanu ‘amalā*, that He may test which of you is best in deed. A cosmogonic clause with a moral purpose clause attached is not a cosmological claim being made for its own sake.

The days

Khalāqa l-samāwāti wa-l-arḍa fī sittati ayyām appears at Q 7:54, Q 10:3, Q 11:7, Q 25:59, Q 32:4, Q 50:38, and Q 57:4. And Q 41:9-12 gives a sequence that appears to sum differently: two days for the earth, four days for its sustenance, two days for the heavens.

The apparent conflict is a counting problem and it has a plain resolution: the four days of Q 41:10 are stated as a total *fī arba‘ati ayyāmin sawā’an li-l-sā’ilīn*, four days complete for those who ask, and the two of Q 41:9 are naturally read as included within them rather than added to them. That reading is old and it is not this study's contribution. What this study contributes is the observation that the passage's own purpose is stated in its frame, which is a rebuke about attributing partners, and that the arithmetic is not the passage's subject.

There is also the matter of what a *yawm* is in these passages, and the Quran itself supplies the caution: at Q 32:5 and Q 22:47 and Q 70:4 the term is attached to three different processes with three different measures, which Chapter 10 discussed. A term used that way is not a fixed interval.

The seven, and the earths

Sab‘a samāwātīn ṭibāqā recurs, and Q 65:12 adds *wa mina l-arḍi mithlabunn*, and of the earth their like. Nothing in the Quran glosses the seven, and Chapter 10 gave the general result about counts.

What can be said structurally is that the passages using the seven are, without exception, passages about ordered layering and about the reach of a governing command. Q 65:12 continues *yatanazzalu l-amru baynabunn*, the command descends among them. The number stands inside a statement about administration, which is the same position the throne occupies at Q 11:7 and the establishing occupies at Q 7:54.

The two seas, once more

Chapter 3 used Q 55:19-20 to teach the instrument and Chapter 9 gave the word. It belongs in this chapter too, because it is the clearest case of the general rule.

Maraja l-baḥrayni yaltaqiyān, baynabumā barzakhun lā yabghiyān. Read as oceanography it is an observation about haloclines. Read for the argument, it is the Quran's model diagram for a distinction that enables a relation, and the surrounding verses make the register plain: the passage is a litany of favours, and both seas are named as yielding food and ornament at Q 55:22. Neither is the defective one.

Why this family is in the study at all

Because the difficulty attributed to it is almost always manufactured by the reading. A passage arguing from what the audience grants, toward the reasonableness of origination or the reality of government, is being asked whether it anticipates a result the audience could not have granted. The question is anachronistic in both directions: it is unfair to the passage and it is unfair to the reader who wants to know what the passage says.

What the passages say is consistent and it is not small. The world was undifferentiated and was partitioned. Life issues from the fluid layer. The making was in stages. The heaven is being maintained in an ongoing state. Rule precedes the making. And the ordering of the layers is where the command travels. Every one of those is stated with an argumentative purpose attached, and this study reports the purpose along with the statement, which is what reading the whole passage produces.

THE ANACHRONISM RUNS BOTH WAYS

A passage arguing from what its audience grants is being asked whether it anticipates a result the audience could not have granted. That is unfair to the passage and unfair to the reader.

TABLE 10 | CHAPTER 13 • BEGINNINGS, EXPANSION, AND THE VERSES THAT TOUCH COSMOLOGY

Verse	The difficulty	What the passage is arguing
21:30 · <i>kānatā ratqan fā-fataqnāhumā</i> , and life from water	Two treatments, both anachronistic. One reads it as anticipating a physical result; the other as ancient cosmology of no further interest. Neither asks what the sentence is doing	Roots ق-ت-ق a closed seam and ق-ت-ق the opening of one: a tailor's pair, one undifferentiated whole partitioned into ordered parts. And the verse states its own move in its first clause, <i>a-wa lam yara</i> , had they not seen. What stands : what the audience already grants. What moves : the partitioning. How they are joined : an argument from the granted to the contested. The cosmology is the premise and origination is the conclusion , so reading it as a physical thesis inverts the passage
41:11 · a heaven addressed while it is <i>dukhān</i> , and answering	Read as a report about a phase of matter, which the grammar does not support	The passage is a dialogue : <i>qālatā atayna ṭā'ī'in</i> , they both said, we come willingly. What stands : two addressees. What moves : a command and a response. How they are joined : willing compliance. The subject is ordered response, not a state of a gas
51:47 · <i>wa innā la-mūsi'ūn</i>	Read forward into a physical result, or backward into vagueness, with the grammar rarely cited by either party	Root ع-س-ع · width, capacity, room. And <i>mūsi'ūn</i> is an active participle , which in Arabic states an ongoing state rather than a completed act. The verse's own grammar refuses the past tense : the building is not finished and set aside. That is a statement about the mode of the maintaining, and whether it corresponds to any physical result is not a question the grammar settles and is not settled here
11:7 · <i>wa kāna 'arsbuhu 'alā l-mā'</i>	Read as a scene and asked what the water was	Read for the argument, the clause places the seat of rule before the making , so creation is administration from the first instant rather than a struggle against something. And the verse's own continuation states the purpose, <i>li-yabluwakum</i>

Verse	The difficulty	What the passage is arguing
		<i>ayyukum aḥsanu ‘amalā</i> . A cosmogonic clause with a moral purpose attached is not cosmology offered for its own sake
41:9-12 against the six days	An arithmetic that appears not to sum: two days, then four, then two, against six elsewhere	The four are stated as a complete total , <i>fī arba‘ati ayyāmin sawā’an li-l-sā’ilin</i> , so the two are naturally read as included rather than added, a reading long available and not this study’s contribution. What is contributed is the frame: the passage’s own subject is a rebuke about attributing partners , and the arithmetic is not what it is about. And the Quran itself cautions against treating <i>yawm</i> as a fixed interval by attaching it to three processes with three measures
65:12 · seven heavens, and of the earth their like	A count with no gloss, filled from both directions	Nothing in the Quran glosses the seven, and the general result of Chapter 10 applies: given and left. What can be said structurally is that every passage using it concerns ordered layering and the travel of a command , and Q 65:12 continues <i>yatanazzalu l-amru baynahunn</i> . The number stands inside a statement about administration, the same position the throne occupies at Q 11:7 and the establishing at Q 7:54
55:19-22 · the two seas, once more	Read as oceanography and argued over haloclines	The chapter’s clearest case of the general rule. What stands : two waters, each with its character. What moves : <i>yaltaqiyān</i> , they meet, an active verb. How they are joined : the barrier. And the register is stated by the passage itself, a litany of favours in which both seas yield food and ornament at Q 55:22, so neither is the defective one. The barrier is not what prevents the meeting; it is what makes a meeting possible
The family read together	Whether these verses are difficult at all	The difficulty is almost always manufactured by the question. A passage arguing from what its audience grants is being asked whether it anticipates a result the audience could not have granted, which is anachronistic in both directions. What the passages say is consistent and not small: undifferentiated then partitioned, life from the fluid layer, making in stages, ongoing maintenance, rule preceding the making, and command travelling through the layers. Every one is stated with an argumentative purpose attached , and reading the whole passage produces the purpose along with the statement

14 DEATH, THE INTERVAL, AND THE TWO COUNTINGS

The most-cited internal contradiction in the Quran is about death, and it can be stated in two lines.

Q 40:11 has the damned say *rabbānā amattanā thnatayni wa ahyaytanā thnatayn*, our Lord ﷻ, You made us die twice and gave us life twice. Q 44:56 says of the people of the garden *lā yadhūqūna fihā l-mawta illā l-mawtata l-ūlā*, they do not taste death therein except the first death. And Q 2:28 gives a sequence with one death in it: *wa kuntum amwātan fā-ahyākum thumma yumūtukum thumma yuhyīkum*, you were dead and He gave you life, then He causes you to die, then He gives you life.

Two, one, and one, apparently in the same text about the same subject.

Three different firsts, and the trap between them

The resolution begins by noticing that the word *first* is doing three different jobs in this material, and that merging any two of them manufactures the contradiction.

First-of-ordinance. *Alladhī khalaqa l-mawta wa-l-ḥayāta li-yabluwakum ayyukum aḥsanu ‘amalā* (Q 67:2), He who created death and life, that He may test which of you is best in deed. Death is named **before** life in the sentence's own order. That is an ordinal on the order of the making, and it says that death was instituted, and instituted prior to the content that runs inside it. It says nothing whatever about any individual's trajectory, and it is not a counter.

First-of-face. *Al-mawtah al-ūlā* at Q 44:56 and Q 37:58-59. Here the ordinal is fixed by an identical ordinal on a neighbouring root. *Al-nash’ah al-ūlā*, the first origination, at Q 56:62, stands against *al-nash’ah al-ākhirah*, the latter origination, at Q 29:20. The pair *first* and *latter* in the Quran's usage names the near face and the far face of one field, not two dates on a calendar. So *al-ūlā* at Q 44:56 is functioning as a **name** and not as a counter. And that is why Q 44:56 can give it as the only death without contradicting anything: the far face carries no *mawt* term at all.

First-of-tally. *Amattanā thnatayni* at Q 40:11. This is a genuine counter, it counts to two, and it is the only genuine counter in the material.

The trap lives between the three. Read the ordinance-verse as a tally and one gets a doctrine about how many deaths there are. Read the face-verse as a tally and one gets a contradiction with the tally-verse. Kept apart, the three say different things and none conflicts with the others.

THE TRAP

The word *first* does three different jobs in this material. Merging any two of them manufactures the contradiction; kept apart, the three say different things and none conflicts with the others.

The counter is marked by its speaker

There is a further feature of Q 40:11 that settles it and that the citation almost always omits.

The verse is speech. It is not the Quran's own statement about souls in general; it is what the damned say, and the Quran reports it. The next verse gives the reason they are in that position: *dhālikum bi-annahu idhā*

du'ya llāhu waḥdahu kafartum wa in yushrak bihi tu'minū, that is because when Allah ﷻ alone was invoked you disbelieved, and if others were associated with Him you believed.

So the count is reported from inside a class, with the class's own cause attached in the following verse. A count spoken by a class about its own experience does not have to be the general count, and the Quran does not present it as one.

KEY POINT

The Quran quotes a great deal that it does not assert. A reader who takes reported speech for stated doctrine will find contradictions everywhere, and this is the clearest case of it in the whole inventory.

The interval

Wa min warā'ihim barzakhun ilā yawmi yub'athūn, and behind them is an interposition until the day they are raised (Q 23:100).

Chapter 9 gave the word and Chapter 3 gave the structure. What belongs here is the observation that the Quran describes the interval extremely sparingly and that most of what is commonly believed about it comes from the transmitted literature rather than from the text. What the text supplies is that there is an interposition, that it stands until the raising, and that the request to return is refused in the clause immediately before, *rabbi rji'ūni... kallā*.

That is a small amount of information stated with precision, and the honest report is that it is a small amount.

The present tense

A group of verses puts the fire and the garden in a tense that the standard future-oriented picture does not accommodate, and collating them is what makes the difficulty visible.

Wa inna jahannama la-muḥīṭatun bi-l-kāfirīn (Q 29:54), and hell is encompassing the disbelievers: an active participle, a present state.

Yawma naqūlu li-jahannama hali mtala'ti wa taqūlu hal min mazīd (Q 50:30), the day We say to hell, are you filled, and it says, is there any more.

Alā bi-dhikri llāhi taṭma'innu l-qulūb (Q 13:28), by the remembrance of Allah ﷻ do hearts come to rest: also present.

Set together, the two last verses form a pair that neither reading of the pair alone will produce. **An appetite with no terminus is set against a state that has one.** The question at Q 50:30 is unanswerable by design, because a thing that asks *is there any more* has no condition under which it would stop asking. And Q 13:28 names the one condition under which a heart stops.

This study does not resolve the tense question into a doctrine, and the Quran holds both registers. What it reports is that the present-tense verses exist, that they are numerous, that they are not marginal, and that at least one pair among them is doing deliberate work that the future-only reading cannot see.

A PAIR THAT NEITHER HALF PRODUCES ALONE

An appetite with no terminus at Q 50:30, set against a state that has one at Q 13:28. The unanswerable question is unanswerable by design.

And the verse about coming to it

Wa in minkum illā wāriduhā, and there is not one of you but will come to it (Q 19:71).

The root و-ر-د names arriving at water, the approach of a caravan to a well, and *wārid* is the one who comes to the water rather than the one who enters it. The following verse says *thumma nunajjī lladhīna ttaqaw*, then We deliver those who guarded themselves. So the verse states an approach and the next verse states a deliverance, and the two readings the tradition produced, entry followed by rescue and approach without entry, correspond to two live senses of one root.

This study reports the root's range and does not adjudicate between them, because the Arabic supports both and the difference is a matter of what happens rather than of what the word means.

TABLE II | CHAPTER 14 · DEATH, THE INTERVAL, AND THE TWO COUNTINGS

Verse	The apparent contradiction	Where it dissolves
67:2 · <i>khalāqa l-mawta wa-l-ḥayāh</i> , with a purpose clause attached	Death named before life in the sentence's own order, which reads as a doctrine about how many deaths there are	Root ح-ي-ي against م-و-ت, and the ordinal here is on the order of the making . It says death was instituted, and instituted prior to the content that runs inside it, and it says nothing whatever about any individual's trajectory. This is first-of-ordinance and it is not a counter . Reading it as a tally is where the whole contradiction begins
44:56 · 37:58-59 · <i>lā yadhūqūna fihā l-mawta illā l-mawtata l-ūlā</i>	The first death given as the only death, in a text that elsewhere counts two	The ordinal is fixed by an identical ordinal on a neighbouring root: <i>al-nash'ah al-ūlā</i> at Q 56:62 stands against <i>al-nash'ah al-ākhirah</i> at Q 29:20, and in Quranic usage that pair names the near face and the far face of one field , not two dates. So <i>al-ūlā</i> here is functioning as a name and not a counter , which is why Q 44:56 can give it as the only one without contradicting anything: the far face carries no <i>mawt</i> term at all. This is first-of-face
40:11-12 · <i>amattanā thnatayni wa aḥyaytanā thnatayn</i>	The only genuine tally in the material, and the source of the whole dispute when read as the Quran's general statement	Two features the citation almost always omits. The verse is speech : it is what the damned say and the Quran reports it, not a statement about souls in general. And the cause is attached in the next verse , Q 40:12, giving the reason they are in that position. What stands : a class. What moves : its own reckoning of its own experience. How they are joined : the cause named immediately after. A count reported from inside a class is not presented as the general count. This is first-of-tally
2:28 · <i>wa kuntum amwātan fa-aḥyākum thumma</i>	A sequence with one death in it, set against a tally of two	Merging any two of the three firsts manufactures the contradiction; kept apart, they say different things

Verse	The apparent contradiction	Where it dissolves
<i>yumītukum thumma yuhyīkum</i>		and none conflicts with the others. The trap lives between them , and naming the three is the whole resolution
23:100 · <i>wa min warā'ihim barzakhun ilā yawmi yub'athūn</i>	An interval about which a great deal is believed and very little is stated	The word names an interposed bar or isthmus, and the reading is the two-seas reading at a second register: the interposition keeps two states distinct rather than preventing a relation between them . What the Quran supplies is small and precise: an interposition, standing until the raising, with the request to return refused in the clause immediately before, <i>rabbi rji'ūni... kallā</i> . The honest report is that it is a small amount , and most of what is commonly believed comes from elsewhere
29:54 · 50:30 · 13:28 · the present-tense verses	Collated, they will not fit the standard future-oriented picture, and separately none of them looks like a problem	Q 29:54 is an active participle, <i>muḥīṭatun</i> , a present state. And Q 50:30 and Q 13:28 form a deliberate pair that neither half produces alone . <i>Hal min mazīd</i> , is there any more, is a question with no condition under which it would stop being asked; and <i>alā bi-dhikri llāhi taṭma'innu l-qulūb</i> names the one condition under which a heart stops. What stands : an appetite and a heart. What moves : asking, and coming to rest. How they are joined : the presence or absence of a terminus. The tense question is not resolved into a doctrine here, and the Quran holds both registers
19:71 · <i>wa in minkum illā wāridubā</i>	Every one of you will come to it, read as universal entry and as universal approach, with both positions old	Root و-ر-د · arriving at water, the approach of a caravan to a well; a <i>wārid</i> is the one who comes to the water rather than the one who enters it. And the next verse states a deliverance, <i>thumma nunajjī lladhīna ttaqaw</i> . The two readings the tradition produced correspond to two live senses of one root , so the root's range is reported and the difference is about the event rather than about the word. Not adjudicated here

15 THE COVENANT, THE REFUSAL, AND THE TRUST

A cluster of passages near the opening of the Quran, and recurring throughout it, describes the installation of the human being: an office announced, an objection raised, a demonstration given, a prostration commanded, a refusal made with an argument, a covenant taken that nobody remembers, and a trust accepted by the one described as least equipped to accept it.

Each of those has produced its own literature and each is difficult in a different way. Read together they turn out to be a single account with a consistent shape, and the shape is one this study has already met repeatedly: **an office conferred, with a limit attached, on a recipient described by what he lacks.**

The objection nobody expected

Wa idh qāla rabbuka li-l-malā'ikati innī jā'ilun fī l-arḍi khalīfah, qālū a-taj'alu fihā man yufsidu fihā wa yasfikū l-dimā' (Q 2:30), and when your Lord ﷻ said to the angels, I am placing on the earth a successor, they said, will You place in it one who corrupts in it and sheds blood.

Two difficulties are usually raised. How do the angels know what has not yet happened? And why is an objection recorded at all?

The second question answers the first. The passage does not treat the objection as illegitimate; it answers it, and it answers it in a specific way. *Innī a'lamu mā lā ta'lamūn*, I know what you do not know. And then, immediately, the Quran does something other than argue. It **demonstrates**: *wa 'allama ādama l-asmā'a kullihā thumma 'arādahum 'alā l-malā'ikati fa-qāla anbi'ūnī bi-asmā'i hā'ulā'i in kuntum šādiqīn* (Q 2:31). The names are taught, the objecting party is asked, the party cannot, and the human being is asked and can.

An epistemic objection is answered by exhibiting a capacity rather than by asserting an authority. That is the passage's method and it is worth noticing, because it is the same method the Quran uses at Q 4:82 when it hands the reader a coherence test rather than a claim of authority.

As to how the objection could be raised at all, the Quran does not say, and this study does not fill it. What can be observed is that the objection is not treated as prophecy in the passage; it is treated as an objection, and it is met.

The office comes first

There is a structural fact about Q 2:30 that is easy to walk past and hard to overstate.

The office of *khalīfā*, successor or deputy, is announced **before any prophet, before any book, and before any law**. It is the first thing in the Quran's account of the human situation. And its provision is written into the account of the descent itself: *qulnā hbiṭū minhā jamī'an, fa-immā ya'tiyannakum minnī hudan* (Q 2:38), We said, go down from it all of you, and when guidance comes to you from Me.

The office is also conferred by name later and with the same domain. *Yā dāwūdu innā ja'alnāka khalīfatan fī l-arḍi fa-ḥkum bayna l-nāsi bi-l-ḥaqq* (Q 38:26). And its limit is stated in the same verse: *wa lā tattabi'ī l-hawā fa-yuḍillaka 'an sabīli llāh*, and do not follow desire, for it will lead you astray from the path of Allah ﷻ. Office and warning in one sentence, which is the pattern of Chapter 11 applied to a different holder.

And the ownership above the office is stated separately and unambiguously: *qul allāhumma mālika l-mulki tu'tī l-mulka man tashā'u wa tanzi'u l-mulka mimman tashā'* (Q 3:26), You give dominion to whom You will and take it from whom You will. **What is reserved is not the office; it is the ownership**, and the Quran uses two different words for them.

THE ORDER IS THE ARGUMENT

The office of *khalīfa* is announced before any prophet, before any book, and before any law. It is the first thing in the Quran's account of the human situation.

The prostration, and why it is not what it looks like

Wa idh qulnā li-l-malā'ikati sjudū li-ādama fa-sajadū illā iblīs (Q 2:34), and when We said to the angels, prostrate to Ādam AS, and they prostrated, except Iblīs.

The difficulty is obvious in a text whose central claim is that prostration belongs to Allah ﷻ alone. The classical responses distinguished a prostration of worship from a prostration of greeting or of acknowledgment, and this study has nothing to add to that distinction philologically.

What the structural reading adds is that the passage itself frames the act as **compliance with a command** rather than as an evaluation of the recipient, and it does so by the way it records the refusal. Iblīs does not say the human being is unworthy of worship. He gives a **comparative argument about substance**: *anā khayrun minhu, khalaqtanī min nārīn wa khalaqtahu min ṭīn* (Q 7:12), I am better than he, You created me from fire and created him from clay.

That is the key to the whole scene and it is available without any doctrine. **The refusal is not a refusal to worship a creature. It is a refusal to accept a ranking, on the ground of what the two parties are made of.** The command was about compliance and the response was about composition, which is a category shift, and the Quran's own comment on it names the mechanism: *istakbara wa kāna mina l-kāfirīn* (Q 2:34), he was arrogant.

Read that way, the scene is not about the status of the human being at all. It is about whether an office conferred by a command can be refused on the ground of the recipient's material, and the answer given is that this reasoning is the failure rather than the objection.

THE REFUSAL IS ABOUT COMPOSITION, NOT WORSHIP

I am better than he, You created me from fire and created him from clay. The command was about compliance and the response was about substance, which is a category shift.

The oath, and the clause the swearer attaches himself

Qāla fa-bi-'izzatika la-ughwiyannahum ajma'īn, illā 'ibādaka minhumu l-mukhlashīn (Q 38:82-83), he said, by Your might, I will lead them all astray, except Your servants among them who have been made pure. And the same at Q 15:39-40.

This is one of the strangest constructions in the Quran and it is rarely remarked. **The adversary states his own limit, unprompted, in his own oath, twice.**

The class named is *al-mukhlaṣīn*, and the form is decisive. It is a passive participle: those who have been **made** sincere, not those who have made themselves so. Chapter 2 gave the general result about the seven doors, and this is one of them read from an unexpected side: the exception is again held on the far side, and here it is the adversary himself who says so.

The class-token recurs at a place that settles a long-argued verse. Q 12:24 says of Yūsuf AS *wa la-qad hammat bihi wa hamma bihā lawlā an ra'ā burhāna rabbih*, and she desired him, and he would have desired her had he not seen the proof of his Lord ﷻ. The classical argument over what the second clause concedes is old and it is real. And the verse's own closing clause is *innahu min 'ibādīnā l-mukhlaṣīn*, he was of Our servants who have been made pure. **The verse places its subject inside the class the adversary named as beyond his reach, in the same sentence as the difficulty.** Whatever the disputed clause means, the Quran bounded it before any commentator arrived, and the court's own verdict is recorded independently at Q 12:51, *ḥāsha lillāh mā 'alimnā 'alayhi min sū*.

THE STRANGEST CONSTRUCTION IN THE FAMILY

The adversary states his own limit, unprompted, in his own oath, twice. And the class he names is a passive participle: those who have been **made** pure.

The covenant nobody remembers

Wa idh akhadha rabbuka min banī ādama min ḡubūribim dhurriyyatahum wa ashbadahum 'alā anfusihim a-lastu bi-rabbikum, qālū balā shahidnā (Q 7:172), and when your Lord ﷻ took from the children of Ādam AS, from their loins, their descendants, and made them testify concerning themselves, am I not your Lord ﷻ; they said, yes, we testify.

The difficulty is the obvious one: a covenant to which everyone is a party and which nobody recalls looks like no covenant at all.

The Quran gives the reason in the same breath, and this is Key Two operating on one of the deepest verses in the text. *An taqūlū yawma l-qiāmati innā kunnā 'an hādihā ḡhāfilīn*, lest you say on the Day of Standing, we were heedless of this. And the next verse forecloses a second excuse: *aw taqūlū innamā ashraka ābā'unā min qablu*, or you say, our fathers associated before us.

So the covenant's stated office is **evidentiary**, and it is laid against two named excuses: personal ignorance and inherited practice. It is not offered as something to be remembered. It is offered as something against which two specific defences will not run.

That reading is reinforced by what the Quran says the human being is constituted with. *Fa-aqim wajhaka li-l-dīni ḡanīfan, fiṭrata llāhi llatī faṭara l-nāsa 'alayhā* (Q 30:30), the original constitution upon which He constituted people. A constitution is not a memory. It is something one grows according to, and it can be built over.

The trust

Innā 'araḡdnā l-amānata 'alā l-samāwāti wa-l-arḡdi wa-l-jibālī fa-abayna an yaḡmilnahā wa ashfaqna minhā wa ḡamalāhā l-insānu innahu kāna ḡalūman ḡabūlā (Q 33:72), We offered the trust to the heavens and the

earth and the mountains and they declined to bear it and were afraid of it, and the human being bore it; he was indeed unjust and ignorant.

The word *amāna* in this sense occurs once in the Quran. What the trust is has been argued for as long as the verse has been read.

Two observations from the method, and both come from reading the passage rather than the word.

The purpose clause is attached, in the next verse. *Li-yu'adhdhiba llāhu l-munāfiqīna wa l-munāfiqāti wa l-mushrikīna wa l-mushrikāti wa yatūba llāhu 'alā l-mu'minīna wa l-mu'mināt* (Q 33:73). The trust's stated function is that the classes separate. Whatever it is, it is an instrument of differentiation, which is the same office the Quran attaches to the number at Q 74:31 and to the change of direction at Q 2:143.

The two adjectives describe a condition rather than deliver a verdict. *Zalūm* and *jahūl* are usually read as a rebuke of the acceptance, which makes the verse strange, since the acceptance is also what the passage is about. Read against the Quran's own account of the human condition they describe the **precondition of bearing**: *yā ayyuhā l-nāsu antumu l-fuqarā'u ilā llāhi wa-llāhu huwa l-ghaniyyu l-ḥamīd* (Q 35:15), you are the ones who hold nothing, and Allah ﷻ is the one who needs nothing. A trust is borne by someone who holds nothing of his own; that is what makes it a trust rather than a possession.

There is a further verse that reads directly against this one and is rarely set beside it. *Mathalu lladhīna ḥummilū l-tawrāta thumma lam yaḥmilūbā ka-mathali l-ḥimāri yaḥmilu asfārā* (Q 62:5), the likeness of those charged to bear the Torah and then did not bear it is the likeness of a donkey carrying books. **The same root, ج-م-ح, carries both halves of that verse and also carries the trust at Q 33:72.** Bearing a trust and reducing a bearing to a carriage stand on one root, and the Quran lets the contrast do the work.

THE ADJECTIVES DESCRIBE A CONDITION, NOT A VERDICT

A trust is borne by someone who holds nothing of his own. That is what makes it a trust rather than a possession, and Q 35:15 states the condition in one clause.

The forgetting, and the words that were received

Wa la-qad 'ahidnā ilā ādama min qablu fa-nasiya wa lam najid lahu 'azmā (Q 20:115), We made a covenant with Ādam AS before, and he forgot, and We found in him no firm resolve.

And then, after the fall: *fa-talaqqā ādamu min rabbihi kalimātin fa-tāba 'alayh* (Q 2:37), Ādam AS received words from his Lord ﷻ, and He turned to him.

The structural observation is small and it closes the chapter. The verb at Q 2:37 is *talaqqā*, received; the words came from the Lord ﷻ and were taken up, and the turning follows. **The repair, like the office and like the criterion and like the trust, is issued and not devised.** That is the same shape the study has met in every chapter of Part Two, applied here to the first case of it, and it is why the account of the human installation is coherent rather than a series of separate puzzles.

THE SHAPE OF THE WHOLE STUDY IN ONE VERB

Talaqqā, received. The repair, like the office and the criterion and the trust, is issued and not devised.

TABLE 12 | CHAPTER 15 • THE COVENANT, THE REFUSAL, AND THE TRUST

Passage	The difficulty	Root and structure
2:30-33 • the office announced, and the objection	Two difficulties, usually raised separately: how the angels know what has not happened, and why an objection is recorded at all	The second answers the first. The passage does not treat the objection as illegitimate; it answers it by demonstration , <i>innī a'lamu mā lā ta'lamūn</i> , followed at once by the naming exhibition. What stands : an office and an objection. What moves : a teaching and a testing. How they are joined : a capacity exhibited rather than an authority asserted, which is the method the Quran uses again at Q 4:82. How the objection could be raised the Quran does not say, and it is not filled here
2:30 • 2:38 • 38:26 • 3:26 • <i>khalīfa</i>	Read as a status-claim about the human being, and argued in those terms	Root خ-ل-ف • coming after, succeeding, standing in place of; a <i>khalīfa</i> is by construction a stand-in , which entails someone stood in for. The order is the argument: the office is announced before any prophet, any book, and any law , and its provision is written into the descent itself at Q 2:38. Conferred by name later at Q 38:26 with a warning clause in the same verse, office and limit delivered together. And Q 3:26 uses a different word for what is reserved: what is reserved is the ownership, not the office
2:34 • 7:12 • the prostration, and the refusal	Prostration to a creature in a text that reserves it, answered classically by distinguishing worship from greeting, with the refusal itself left unexamined	The refusal is the key and it is not about worship. <i>Anā khayrun minhu, khalaqtanī min nārīn wa khalaqtahu min ṭīn</i> : a comparative argument about substance . What stands : a command. What moves : compliance, refused. How they are joined : a category shift, since the command was about compliance and the response was about composition. The Quran names the mechanism itself, <i>istakbara</i> . The scene is not about the standing of the human being; it is about whether an office conferred by command can be refused on the ground of the recipient's material
15:39-40 • 38:82-83 • the oath, and its exception	One of the strangest constructions in the Quran and rarely remarked: the adversary states his own limit, unprompted, in his own oath, twice	Root خ-ل-ص • to become pure, unmixed, cleared of what is foreign. And the form is decisive: mukblaṣ is the passive participle , one who was made sincere, not one who made himself so. So the exception is again held on the far side, and here it is named by the one it excludes. Nobody enters that class by announcing that he is in it
12:24 • <i>hammat bibi wa hamma bibā lawlā an ra'ā burhāna rabbih</i>	The oldest live dispute in the Yūsuf AS narrative, argued over what the second clause concedes, with the verse's own	The verse closes on the class-token: <i>innabu min 'ibādīnā l-mukblaṣīn</i> . The Quran places its subject inside the class the adversary named as

Passage	The difficulty	Root and structure
	closing clause almost never brought into it	beyond his reach, in the same sentence as the difficulty. Whatever the disputed clause means, the text bounded it before any commentator arrived. And the court's own verdict is recorded independently at Q 12:51, <i>ḥāshā lillāh mā 'alimnā 'alayhi min sū'</i>
7:172-173 · <i>a-lastu bi-rabbikum</i>	A covenant to which everyone is party and which nobody recalls looks like no covenant at all	The reason is given in the same breath and a second excuse is foreclosed in the next verse: <i>an taqūlū yawma l-qiyāmati innā kunnā 'an ḥādhā ghāfilīn</i> , and <i>aw taqūlū innamā ashraka ābā'unā min qablu</i> . The covenant's stated office is evidentiary , laid against personal heedlessness and inherited practice. It is not offered as something to be remembered, and Q 30:30's <i>fiṭra</i> is a constitution one grows according to , not a memory, which can be built over
33:72-73 · the trust	A trust borne by one the same verse calls <i>ẓalūman jahūlā</i> , read as a rebuke of the acceptance, which makes the verse strange since the acceptance is what the passage is about	Root أ-م-ن · safety, and thence what is deposited in safekeeping; the word occurs once in this sense. The purpose clause is attached in the next verse: the trust's stated function is that the classes separate , the same office the Quran attaches to the number at Q 74:31 and the direction-change at Q 2:143. And the two adjectives describe the precondition of bearing , which Q 35:15 states in one clause, <i>antumu l-fuqarā'u ilā llāh</i> : a trust is borne by one who holds nothing of his own, which is what makes it a trust rather than a possession
62:5 · the donkey carrying books	A harsh image aimed at a scholarly custodial class, read as invective	The root is the argument. ج-م-ح carries both halves of the verse, <i>ḥummilū</i> charged-to-bear and <i>lam yaḥmilūhā</i> failed-to-bear, and the same root carries the trust at Q 33:72 , <i>ḥamalabā l-insān</i> . Bearing a trust and reducing a bearing to a carriage stand on one root, and the Quran lets the contrast do the work. The sharpness is compression, not insult
20:115 · 2:37 · the forgetting, and the words received	A covenant broken and a repair, usually read as two separate moments in a narrative	Root ل-ق-ي in form V · <i>talaqqā</i> , to receive what is extended. What stands: a fallen party. What moves: words, from the Lord ﷻ. How they are joined: reception, with the turning following. The repair, like the office and the criterion and the trust, is issued and not devised , which is the shape of every grant in this study applied to the first case of it, and it is why the account of the human installation is one coherent thing rather than a series of separate puzzles

PART THREE • WHAT REMAINS

16 WHAT THE TEXT KEEPS

Everything before this chapter has been an argument that most of the difficulty is in the reading. This chapter is about what is left when the reading is repaired, and the honest answer is that something is.

The residue is small and it is marked

Run the whole method across the whole inventory and a residue survives it. It has three parts and they are different in kind.

The first part is what the text declares withheld. These were treated in Chapter 4 and they recur here because they are the core of the residue. The content of the disconnected letters. The nature of the Spirit, refused in the answer's own words and doubled by the Quran's threefold refusal to identify it with the angels. The number and the *raqīm* of the cave, refused with an explicit instruction attached. The hour, whose timing is stated as known to Allah ﷻ alone at Q 7:187 and whose suddenness is asserted six times. And the meaning of the ambiguous verses, at Q 3:7, where the withholding is the verse's own subject.

The second part is what the text leaves unfixed without declaring it withheld. The identity of the two-horned traveller. The identity of the people of al-Rass. Which prayer is the middle one. The identity of the figure sent to Maryam AS, which the Quran declines by refusing the whole question of the Spirit at Q 17:85 and by coordinating *rūḥ* with *malā'ika* three times. The referent of the light in the Light Verse, left open in the verse's own closing clause. These are not marked as forbidden. They are simply not stated, and the honest report is that they are not stated.

The third part is what a structural reading cannot reach in principle. Whether the readings are true. What the manner of an event was where the text speaks about agency rather than manner. What any person's standing is before Allah ﷻ. This study reaches none of those, and the reason is not modesty but the character of the instrument: a reading that composes is a reading that holds together, and holding together is not the same as being true. That distinction is worth one instance rather than three assertions. The reading of Q 20:5 offered in Chapter 5, that the establishing marks a transition from making to governing, composes cleanly: the parties, the act, and the joining stand apart, and the sequence of the passage supports it. It is also compatible with a rival that composes just as well, that the clause marks the completion of an act rather than the opening of a regime, and nothing in the three-part test discriminates between the two. The instrument has done its whole work there and has not decided the question. A reader who wanted it to decide has asked it for something it does not have.

The contested legal verses

Four passages in the inventory are live juristic disputes across schools and centuries, and they belong here rather than in Part Two, because what a structural reading can offer about them is structure and nothing more.

Q 4:34 contains a disciplining clause inside a passage about marital discord. Three textual observations can be made without adjudicating anything. The clause stands third in a stated sequence and not first. The passage's next verse, Q 4:35, immediately routes an unresolved case **out of the household** to two arbiters, one from each family. And the standing instruction elsewhere in the same chapter is *wa 'āshirūhunna bi-l-ma'rūf* (Q 4:19). What the disputed clause licenses, how it is bounded, and how it stands against the Prophet's ﷺ own reported practice are questions argued across the schools and across the centuries, and this study does not enter

that argument. The structural observation is that the passage terminates in external arbitration rather than in household authority.

Q 9:5 is read in isolation as a general war-verse. Two textual observations. Q 9:4 excepts the parties who kept their terms, *fa-atimmū ilayhim ‘abdahum ilā muddatihim*, complete their treaty to its term. Q 9:6 grants asylum on request and extends safe-conduct after refusal, *wa in aḥadun mina l-mushrikīna stjāraka fa-ajirhu ḥattā yasma‘a kalāma llāhi thumma ablighhu ma’manah*. The verse is bracketed on both sides, and the passage as it stands concerns named treaty-parties in a specific breach. What later juristic frameworks built on it is a long and contested reception history, and this study neither endorses nor adjudicates any part of it.

Q 24:31 and Q 33:59 concern dress and are argued on the range of specific terms, on the scope of a stated purpose clause, and on the relation between a general instruction and a historically situated one. All three of those are live and none is settled by anything in this study's method. The observation available is that both verses attach a stated reason, and that the reasons attached are different from each other.

In all four cases the study's position is the same and it is stated once. **A structural reading can show what a passage's parts are and how they are joined. It cannot decide a question of law**, because law is decided by a different kind of argument in which text, practice, precedent, and circumstance are all doing work. A reader who wanted this study to settle those verses has asked it for something it does not have.

THE POSITION, STATED ONCE

A structural reading can show what a passage's parts are and how they are joined. It cannot decide a question of law, because law is decided by a different kind of argument in which text, practice, precedent, and circumstance all do work.

Why a text would keep anything

It is worth ending Part Three on the question the residue raises, because a reader who has followed the argument this far will want it addressed rather than left.

A text that withheld nothing would be making a particular claim about its reader: that everything in it is available to anyone who reads carefully enough. A text that withheld everything would be making no claim at all. The Quran does neither. It states that it is clear, *kitābun mubīn*, and it states that access to it is conditioned, *lā yamassuhu illā l-muṭaḥḥarūn* (Q 56:79). It states that the obstruction is on hearts and not on verses (Q 47:24). And it states that the faculty for telling things apart is issued on a condition nobody may certify of himself (Q 8:29 with Q 53:32 and Q 4:49).

Put together, those four statements are a single position and it is coherent. **Clarity is a property of the text; access is a property of the relation between the text and the reader; and the second is not in the reader's gift.** A reader who finds a passage closed is told, by the text itself, where to look for the reason, and is told at the same time that he is not the one who certifies whether the condition has been met.

The seven doors of Chapter 2 are that position stated grammatically. At each of the Quran's absolute negations an exception is attached, and every key is on the far side: a permission granted, a will exercised, the One negating standing as His own exception, one who was approved, one who was permitted, and a class named by a passive participle. **There is no handle on the near side of any of them.**

That is not the description of a text that ran out of things to say. It is the description of a text that treats a limit as a thing worth building, marking, and defending, which is the same treatment it gives to everything else it considers important.

THE FOUR STATEMENTS ARE ONE POSITION

Clarity is a property of the text. Access is a property of the relation between the text and the reader. And the second is not in the reader's gift.

TABLE 13 | CHAPTER 16 • WHAT THE TEXT KEEPS

What is left	Why it resists	Where it stands
The declared withholdings · the disconnected letters · the Spirit at Q 17:85 · the sleepers' count at Q 18:22 · the hour at Q 7:187 · the ambiguous verses at Q 3:7	Not resistant to a better method. Marked as withheld by the text itself , defended, and in several cases explained as to shape	Reported as the text reports them. The letters stand beside the claim and their content is not offered; the Spirit question is refused in the answer's own words and doubled by three coordinations; the count is refused and the refusal legislated; the hour's timing is stated as known to Allah ﷻ alone with its suddenness asserted six times
The unfixed referents · Dhū al-Qarnayn · al-Rass · the middle prayer at Q 2:238 · the figure sent at Q 19:17 · the light at Q 24:35	Not marked as forbidden. Simply not stated , and in two cases the passage says in its own first clause that it will not be stating them	Left where the text leaves them. The honest report is that they are not stated, and filling them would substitute a later consensus for a silence the text placed in its own text
The limits of the method · whether the readings are true · the manner of events · any person's standing before Allah ﷻ	A limit of the instrument rather than a modesty. A reading that composes is a reading that holds together, which is not the same as being true	Stated once and applied throughout. The instrument reaches coherence and stops there, and a coherent reading may still rest on a premise a reader declines
4:34-35 · the disciplining clause	A live juristic dispute across schools and centuries, turning on text, practice, precedent, and circumstance together	Three textual observations and no adjudication: the clause stands third in a stated sequence, Q 4:35 immediately routes an unresolved case out of the household to two arbiters one from each family, and Q 4:19 sets the standing instruction. The passage terminates in external arbitration , and the juristic question is not entered
9:4-6 · read in isolation as a general war-verse	A long and contested reception history built on a passage lifted from its brackets	Two textual observations and no adjudication: Q 9:4 excepts the parties who kept their terms, <i>fa-atimmū ilayhim 'ahdabum ilā muddatibim</i> , and Q 9:6 grants asylum on request and extends safe-conduct after refusal , <i>thumma ablighbu ma'manah</i> . The passage as it stands concerns named treaty-parties in a specific breach
24:31 · 33:59 · the covering verses	Argued on the range of specific terms, on the scope of a stated purpose clause, and on the relation between a general instruction and a situated one. None of the three is settled by anything in this method	The observation available is that both verses attach a stated reason, and the reasons differ from each other . Live questions, and left live

What is left	Why it resists	Where it stands
Why a text keeps anything	The question the residue raises, and the one a reader will want addressed rather than left	Four statements form one coherent position. The text is clear, <i>kitābun mubīn</i> . Access is conditioned, Q 56:79. The obstruction is located on hearts and not on verses, Q 47:24. And the faculty is issued on a condition nobody may certify of himself, Q 8:29 with Q 53:32 and Q 4:49. Clarity is a property of the text; access is a property of the relation between text and reader; and the second is not in the reader's gift
The seven doors · Q 2:255 twice · 6:59 · 27:65 · 72:26-27 · 34:23 · 37:159-160	Whether the limits are the residue of a text that fell short	That position stated grammatically. At each absolute negation an exception is attached, and every key is source-side: a permission granted, a will exercised, the One negating standing as His own exception, one who was approved, one who was permitted, and a class named by a passive participle. Most occur once in more than six thousand verses. There is no handle on the near side of any of them , which is the description of a limit built, marked, and defended rather than encountered

CONCLUSION

The argument of this study can be stated in a paragraph.

A recognizable list of Quranic passages has been transmitted as difficult for fourteen centuries, and a second list of comparable size can be assembled by a reader working the text on its own terms rather than by tracking controversy. Across both lists, the great majority of the difficulty is produced by three ordinary features of how the Quran writes. It argues without quoting its opponents, so a rebuttal reads as a riddle until the claim being rebutted is restored. It states the purpose of its hardest verses in the adjacent clause and scopes its own universals inside the verse that carries them, so a difficulty produced by stopping one clause early is a difficulty of citation. And it defines its own disputed words at other places in itself, so a lexical dispute is often a dispute a concordance ends. What survives all three is a residue that the text marks, defends, and in several cases explains the shape of.

Three results are worth carrying away from the detail.

The first is that a large amount of famous difficulty is settled by counting. All three occurrences of *every soul shall taste death* carry a class-marker in the same verse. Both occurrences of *you do not will unless Allah ﷻ wills* carry the human-will clause immediately before. The construction *third of three* occurs once, and its only sibling names a Meccan triad. The word *mubaymin* occurs twice. The phrase *the keys of the unseen* occurs once. Twenty-five of the twenty-nine chapters opening with disconnected letters carry a reference to the Book, the Recitation, or the Pen within the opening verse and the three that follow, and twenty-six on a criterion that admits the verbs of sending down. None of those is an interpretation. They are facts about a text that anyone can verify, and each of them dissolves or transforms a dispute that has run for centuries.

The second is that the Quran is consistently unwilling to let an office and a nature merge. It refuses the strongest identity construction to a title whose morphology points outward to an agent, and affirms the same construction of Allah ﷻ freely. It converts prophetic achievements into grants by putting the verbs in the passive and naming the Giver. It splits its guidance vocabulary into three morphological positions so that the Guide, the guided, and the conferred office of guiding cannot be confused. And it applies the same unwillingness to the person closest to the text, in thirteen verses that correct him and one that tells him the matter is not his at all.

The third is that the text's limits are built rather than encountered. At every absolute negation there is an attached exception whose key is held on the far side, in constructions that occur once or twice in more than six thousand verses. That is a design, it is checkable, and it is the clearest single indication in the material that the difficulty which survives careful reading is not the residue of a text that fell short. It is the part the text kept.

A reader who takes nothing else from these pages might take the smallest of the recommendations in it, which costs nothing and works immediately. **Read to the end of the passage before deciding what it says.** A surprising amount of what has been recorded as unintelligible in the Quran turns out to be intelligible one clause later.

THE ONE-SENTENCE RECOMMENDATION

Read to the end of the passage before deciding what it says.

METHODOLOGY AND DISCLOSURE

How the readings in this study were produced

The readings above were produced under a formal verification discipline rather than by ordinary exegetical judgment, and the difference is worth stating plainly because it affects what the reader should and should not take from them.

The discipline is a general-purpose verification architecture, developed over several years and applied here to scriptural material as one of several domains. Its working parts are three, and each corresponds to something the reader has already seen in operation.

A linguistic stage decomposes any claim into its irreducible parts and tests whether those parts are genuinely distinct. This is what Chapter 3 describes as the three parts of a claim, and the deletion test given there is the discipline's own test, stated without its apparatus. It is also the stage at which words are recovered to the physical images their roots name, which is the procedure Chapter 9 uses throughout.

A structural stage takes the decomposed claim and tests whether it closes: whether the parts stand apart and compose, or whether one of the three failures of Chapter 3 has occurred. The full apparatus at this stage includes a fixed roster of diagnostic checks applied in order, each of which prevents one specific way a claim can appear coherent while failing. Several of those checks are visible in this study without being named: the check against a measuring instrument being smuggled into the thing it measures, the check against a claim that holds only in one observer's frame, and the check against a conclusion asserted at a strength greater than its weakest supporting element.

A verdict stage assigns one of three outcomes and no others: the reading closes, the reading breaks with a named mechanism, or the reading is under-determined with the missing input named. There is no fourth outcome and no fractional grading. Where this study says a reading holds, or does not close, or leaves something unfixed, those are the three outcomes stated in plain English.

Three further disciplines govern the whole and are worth naming because they explain choices the reader will have noticed.

Every claim carries a stated warrant. The architecture requires that a claim be labelled at the strength it actually has, and forbids stating a corroboration as though it were load-bearing or a premise as though it were a result. That is why this study distinguishes throughout between what the text says, what a reading proposes, and what is assumed.

Consensus carries no evidential weight, in either direction. The number of scholars holding a position is not evidence for it, and it is equally not evidence against it. Positions are weighed on their own structure. That is why the classical commentaries appear in this study as witnesses to what a tradition held rather than as authorities that settle a reading, and why a majority position is neither adopted nor rejected on the ground of being a majority.

The instrument's own output is subject to its own tests. Nothing here is exempt, including the readings this study proposes. Where a reading is a reading rather than a demonstration, that is said.

What the earlier scriptures are doing in these pages

The Hebrew Bible, the Gospels, the rabbinic literature, and the pre-Islamic apocryphal writings appear throughout Part Two. They appear for one reason and it is stated at each occurrence: **the Quran is addressing the communities that hold them.**

The Quran names those communities, quotes their formulas in order to refuse or to confirm them, retells their narratives with clauses restored or removed, and expects hearers who know the material. That makes those texts evidence about the Quran's audience and about the argument the Quran is conducting. It does not make them instruments for deciding a Quranic reading, and this study never uses them that way. In every case above where such a parallel appears, the reading is carried by the Quran's own added clause, purpose statement, root usage, or grammatical change, and the reading stands whether or not a reader knows the parallel.

The ordering principle is simple and it is applied without exception. **The Quran interprets the Quran first.** Where an internal reading and an external parallel diverge, the internal reading holds and the divergence is noted.

A note on sources

This study carries no reference apparatus, and the reason is worth stating rather than leaving to inference. Its primary evidence is the Quranic text itself, cited by chapter and verse throughout, and its counts are executed against that text and reproducible from the statement of each count. Neither class needs a bibliography, because the source is named in every instance and is in every reader's hands.

A third class does not have that property. Traditional attributions, that a caliph wished a legal term had been made clearer, that a companion said he did not know a word, that a jurist answered a question about a verse with a formula that entered the schools, and that a delegation came to dispute the matters of one chapter, are given here as the tradition transmits them, without chains of transmission and without citation to the collections that carry them. They are witness material and they decide nothing: each is attached to a reading that stands or falls on the Quranic evidence beside it, and where a report is contested the hedge is printed in the sentence rather than left to the reader. A reader who wants to trace them will find them in the standard collections and commentaries under the verse in question. The references to earlier scriptures and to their interpretive literatures are handled the same way and are never load-bearing. Where a passage is quoted or its wording is the point, it is cited by book, chapter, and verse. Where the reference is to a manner of speaking rather than to a passage, that a literature speaks in a certain idiom, that a tradition eventually stated a rule about it, it is named by description and not cited, because a description is not a quotation and citing one passage would misrepresent a usage that runs through many.

The counts

Every count reported in this study was executed against the full Quranic text rather than recalled. The text used is a public machine-readable Uthmani transcription, and matching was performed after stripping diacritics and normalizing the several written forms of alif, hamza, and final tā', which is the standard preparation for this kind of search.

Two limitations travel with that method and are stated rather than glossed. Stripping the short vowels conflates a small number of forms that differ only in vocalization, which is noted at the one place in this study where it

matters. And a public transcription is reproducible rather than critical, so a count is a count over a standard text and not over a manuscript tradition.

The counts are the study's hardest evidence and they are offered in that spirit. A reader who doubts any of them can settle the matter in an afternoon, which is the condition under which such a claim is worth making.

What this study is not

It is not a commentary and it does not attempt coverage. It takes a defined set of difficult passages and applies a defined method to them.

It is not a work of law. Four passages in the inventory are live juristic disputes, they are treated in Chapter 16, and the treatment is structural and adjudicates nothing.

It is not a claim about any person's standing before Allah ﷻ, and it makes none anywhere.

And it does not claim to have exhausted its own subject. The method leaves a residue, Chapter 16 sets the residue out, and the residue includes several of the most famous items in the inventory. A study that had dissolved everything would have been doing something other than reading.

The record

The full working materials behind this study are public. They include the complete inventory of difficult passages with their treatments across four working volumes, the executed concordance records, and the underlying verification architecture with its own documentation and version history. They are maintained at the repository github.com/1000sapients/Trisduction.

A reader who wants to check a specific claim will find the working table for it there, and a reader who wants to see the architecture the readings were produced under will find that too. This study was written to stand on its own without either, which is why the apparatus has been kept out of the body and confined to this section.

APPENDIX A • TRANSLITERATION AND CONVENTIONS

Transliteration. Long vowels are marked with a macron: *ā, ī, ū*. Emphatic consonants are marked with a dot beneath: *ṣ, ḍ, ṭ, ṣ, ḥ*. The letter ‘ayn is written ‘ and hamza is written ‘. The definite article is written *al-* and is not assimilated in writing even where it assimilates in speech, so *al-shams* rather than *ash-shams*.

Roots. Arabic words are built on consonantal roots of three letters, occasionally four. A root is written with its consonants separated by hyphens, as *ص-م-د*, and the sense of a root is the common element across all the words built from it. This study argues in several places that the physical thing a root names is the key to a word built on it, and Chapter 9 sets out that procedure.

References. Quranic references are given as chapter:verse in the standard numbering. A reference such as Q 2:255 is chapter two, verse two hundred fifty-five.

Honorifics. *ﷻ* follows the name of Allah and means *glorified and exalted is He*. *ﷺ* follows the name of the Prophet Muhammad and means *peace and blessings of Allah be upon him*. AS follows the name of a prophet and means *peace be upon him*. RA follows the name of a companion and means *may Allah be pleased with him or her*. These are treated in this study as parts of names rather than as optional additions, and they are preserved in every citation and summary.

Terms used more than once

Aḥsan al-ḥadīth · the best discourse, the Quran's self-description at Q 39:23. *Barzakh* · an interposition, a bar or isthmus; the interval between death and rising at Q 23:100 and the barrier between two seas at Q 55:20. *Bayān* · making distinct, the faculty of separating one thing from another; given to the human being at Q 55:4. *Dhikr* · a reminding, a bringing back into speech of what was already held; the Quran's self-designation at Q 15:9. *Furqān* · a criterion, the faculty of telling things apart; stated as issued upon a condition at Q 8:29. *Ghayb* · what is beyond perception, the unseen. *Muḥkam* and *mutashābih* · firmly established and mutually resembling, the two classes of verse named at Q 3:7. *Nafs* · a self, a soul, an interior that holds contents; the term the Quran's death-law runs on. *Ta'wīl* · the interpretation or the outcome of a thing; the term at issue in Q 3:7. *Wajh* · a face, a surface, a presence; the term the Quran uses for what remains at Q 28:88 and Q 55:27, and which it never places under its death-law or its perishing-law.

APPENDIX B • THE EXECUTED COUNTS

Every count asserted in this study, gathered in one place so that a reader can check them without hunting through the chapters. Each was run over the full text of 6,236 verses across 114 chapters, after stripping diacritics and normalizing alif, hamza, and final tā'. Stripping the diacritics also removes the superscript alif, which matters at least twice: *sinājan* is written with a superscript alif at Q 25:61 and with a full one at its other three sites, and *maṣābīḥ* is written with one at both of its sites, Q 41:12 and Q 67:5. A reader who normalizes only the full alif will find three where the first row states four, and none where the second states two. Where a count depends on how a phrase is delimited, the delimitation is stated in the row, because a count whose criterion is unstated is not a count a reader can check. Three rows are marked *Referenced* in the last column: those counts were executed in the course of this work and are reported here for completeness, and no argument in this study rests on them.

TABLE 14 | THE EXECUTED COUNTS

Claim	Result	Where it is used
<i>Kullu nafsīn dhā'iqatu l-mawt</i> , every soul shall taste death	3 places: Q 3:185, 21:35, 29:57. Each carries a recompense, trial, or return clause in the same verse	Chapters 2, 5
<i>Wa mā tashā'ūna illā an yashā'a llāh</i> , you do not will unless Allah ﷻ wills	2 places: Q 76:30, 81:29. The human-will clause stands immediately before at both, Q 76:29 and Q 81:28	Chapters 2, 6
<i>Illā bi-mā shā'</i> , except what He wills	1 place in the whole text: Q 2:255	Chapters 2, 16
<i>Maḥātīḥ al-ghayb</i> , the keys of the unseen	1 place: Q 6:59	Chapters 2, 4, 16
The construction <i>al-ghayb illā</i>	1 place: Q 27:65	Chapters 2, 16
<i>Illā mani rtaḍā min rasūl</i> , except one He approved as a messenger	1 place: Q 72:27	Chapters 2, 16
<i>Illā li-man adbīna lah</i> , except for one He permitted	1 place: Q 34:23	Chapters 2, 16
<i>Illā 'ibāda llāhi l-mukblaṣīn</i> , except the servants of Allah ﷻ made pure	4 places: Q 37:40, 37:74, 37:128, 37:160	Chapters 2, 15, 16
<i>Illā 'ibādaka minbumu l-mukblaṣīn</i> , except Your servants among them, the made-pure	2 places: Q 15:40, 38:83. This is the second-person form, and both sites are the adversary's own oath. The class-token is the same passive participle in both phrasings, and the exception field is six sites across the two	Chapters 2, 15, 16
<i>'Ammā yaṣīfūn</i> , above what they describe	6 places: Q 6:100, 21:22, 23:91, 37:159, 37:180, 43:82. The exception follows exactly one of them	Chapters 2, 16

Claim	Result	Where it is used
<i>Muhaymin</i>	2 places: Q 5:48 of the Book, Q 59:23 of Allah ﷻ. No third	Chapter 1, Conclusion
<i>Sharqīyy</i> , eastern, as an adjective	2 places: Q 19:16, 24:35	Chapter 12
<i>Miṣbāḥ</i> , lamp, singular	1 place: Q 24:35. The plural <i>maṣābīḥ</i> stands at Q 41:12 and Q 67:5	Chapter 12
<i>Sināj</i> , lamp, the other word	4 places: Q 25:61, 33:46, 71:16, 78:13	Chapter 12
<i>Thālīthu thalātha</i> , third of three	1 place: Q 5:73. Its only sibling ordinal-in-a-count is <i>al-thālīthata l-ukhrā</i> at Q 53:20, also 1	Chapter 7
<i>Kataba ‘alā nafsīhi</i> , He wrote upon Himself ﷻ	2 places, both in one chapter: Q 6:12 and Q 6:54	Chapters 1, 5
The self-purification bar	2 places: Q 4:49 and Q 53:32. The first names the agent	Chapters 12, 16
<i>Qarḍan ḥasanan</i> , a goodly loan	6 places: Q 2:245, 5:12, 57:11, 57:18, 64:17, 73:20	Referenced
The mass form <i>‘alaq</i>	1 place: Q 96:2. The singulative <i>‘alaqa</i> at 4: Q 22:5, 23:14, 40:67, 75:38, each inside an ordered stage-chain	Chapter 9
Chapters opening with disconnected letters	29 chapters, of which 25 carry a reference to the Book, the Recitation, or the Pen within the opening verse and the three that follow. The exceptions are Q 19, 29, 30, 42. Admitting the verbs of sending down raises the figure to 26 and removes Q 42	Chapters 1, 4
<i>Wa mā ramayta idh ramayt</i> , you did not throw when you threw	1 place: Q 8:17	Chapters 2, 6, 7
<i>Wa mā qatalūhu wa mā ṣalabūh</i>	1 place: Q 4:157	Chapter 7
<i>Lā rayba fī-</i> , no doubt in it, either pronoun	14 places, of which 10 carry the masculine <i>fīhi</i> , Q 2:2, 3:9, 3:25, 4:87, 6:12, 10:37, 17:99, 32:2, 42:7, 45:26, and 4 the feminine <i>fīhā</i> agreeing with <i>al-sā’a</i> , Q 18:21, 22:7, 40:59, 45:32. Predicated of the Book at three sites and of the appointed gathering at ten, and once, at Q 17:99, of an appointed term	Referenced
<i>Bi-idhnī llāh</i> inside Q 3:49	2 occurrences in that verse. The verse carrying four is Q 5:110, in the first-person form <i>bi-idhnī</i>	Chapter 8

Claim	Result	Where it is used
<i>Yas'alūnaka 'an</i> with the imperative <i>qul</i> , in Sūrat al-Baqarah	7 imperatives across 6 verses: Q 2:189, 215, 217, 219 twice, 220, 222. Q 2:186 carries the formula and no imperative	Chapter 12
<i>Fi sittati ayyām</i> , in six days	7 places: Q 7:54, 10:3, 11:7, 25:59, 32:4, 50:38, 57:4	Chapter 13
<i>Amāna</i> , the trust, in the sense of a thing deposited	1 place: Q 33:72. The plural <i>amānāt</i> is absent from the corpus in that form	Chapter 15
The equality-negation forms of س-و-يـ	18 places: Q 4:95, 5:100, 6:50, 9:19, 11:24, 13:16, 16:75, 16:76, 32:18, 35:12, 35:19, 35:22, 39:9, 39:29, 40:58, 41:34, 57:10, 59:20	Referenced

One correction carried on the record. The count of chapters opening with disconnected letters was first drafted at two exceptions, the executed run returned three, and a later sweep over the criterion itself returned four, Q 42 joining Q 19, Q 29, and Q 30 once the word list was held to the three nouns the criterion names. The number moved twice, and both moves are recorded here rather than absorbed. The figure in Chapter 4 is the corrected one, and the correction is noted here because a distributional claim that moves under its own check is exactly the kind of claim whose movement should be visible. A second count was corrected the same way and is recorded with it: a permission clause was first written as standing four times inside Q 3:49, and the executed run returned two, the verse carrying four being Q 5:110 in the first-person form. The figure was right and the address was wrong, which is the characteristic shape of a recalled number, and it is the reason every count in this study is executed rather than remembered.

One limitation stated. Stripping the short vowels conflates *mukblaṣīn*, those made pure, with *mukbliṣīn*, those making themselves sincere, since the two differ only in a vowel the stripping removes. The count of the *mukblaṣ* field is therefore a count over the combined field, and the distinction requires a pointed text. Nothing in this study's argument turns on the split, and the argument at Q 37:160 rests on the participle's form-class, which is not affected.

APPENDIX C • THE INVENTORY BY FAMILY

The passages treated in this study, gathered by the family they belong to, for a reader who wants to locate a specific verse.

TABLE 15 | THE INVENTORY BY FAMILY

Family	Chapter	Principal passages
The text's own limits	4	2:1 and 28 parallels · 3:7 · 39:23 · 17:85 · 18:9-26 · 74:30-31
Hands, face, and throne	5	48:10 · 3:26 · 11:37 · 68:42 · 20:5 and 7 parallels · 3:185, 21:35, 29:57 · 28:88 with 55:26-27 · 5:116 · 6:12, 6:54
Decree and the human act	6	76:29-30 · 81:28-29 · 8:17 · 2:7 · 16:93 · 14:4 · 4:155 · 61:5 · 25:31, 7:178, 32:24 · 28:56 · 13:39 · 6:2
Word, Spirit, and the creed	7	5:17, 5:72 · 42:9 · 4:171 · 5:73 · 53:20 · 112:2-3 · 6:101 · 3:45 · 3:59 · 43:4 · 3:55 with 39:42 · 4:157-158 · 5:116 with 5:75
The stories half-told	8	2:67-73 · 18:9-26 · 18:60-82 · 18:83-98 · 2:102 · 38:34 with 3:26 · 2:243 · 27:16 · 3:49
Words that defeated the lexicographers	9	112:2 · 4:12, 4:176 · 18:9 · 19:13 · 2:238 · 7:46 · 108:3 · 96:2 · 23:100, 55:20
Numbers without a gloss	10	74:30-31 · 18:22 · 18:25 · 32:5, 22:47, 70:4 · 12:4 · 69:17 · 65:12 · 97:3 · 9:36
The verses that correct the Prophet ﷺ	11	66:1 · 80:1-2 · 9:43 · 8:67 · 93:7 · 3:128 · 17:74 · 33:37 · 40:55, 47:19 · 48:2 · 4:105 · 94:2
Nearness, light, and the interior verses	12	50:16 · 57:4 · 2:115 · 2:186 with 2:189, 215, 217, 219, 220, 222 · 24:35 · 33:46 · 8:29 · 47:24 · 53:32, 4:49
Beginnings and expansion	13	21:30 · 41:11 · 51:47 · 11:7 · 41:9-12 · 65:12 · 55:19-22
Death and the interval	14	40:11-12 · 44:56 · 2:28 · 67:2 · 56:62, 29:20 · 23:100 · 29:54 · 50:30 · 13:28 · 19:71
The covenant, the refusal, and the trust	15	2:30-34 · 2:38 · 38:26 · 3:26 · 7:12 · 15:39-40, 38:82-83 · 12:24 with 12:51 · 7:172-173 · 30:30 · 33:72-73 with 35:15 · 62:5 · 20:115, 2:37
What the text keeps	16	7:187 · 3:7 · 17:85 · 18:22 · 56:79 · 47:24 · 8:29 · 4:34-35 · 9:4-6 · 24:31 · 33:59

PRIMARY SOURCES

This list carries primary texts only. It is short because the study cites few, and the reason it cites few is stated in the note on sources: the Quranic text is its evidence, the counts are executed against that text and reproducible from the statement of each count, and the traditional attributions it carries are given as the tradition transmits them and decide nothing.

The Qur’ān. The ‘Uthmānī text in the reading of Ḥafṣ ‘an ‘Āṣim, in the Kufan verse-numbering that yields 114 chapters and 6,236 verses, which is the numbering used for every reference in this study. Every count in Appendix B was executed against a fully pointed digital transcription of that text, under the normalization the appendix header states. A reader reproducing a count should use a text in the same reading and numbering, since a different reading tradition will divide some verses differently and shift a reference by one.

The Hebrew Bible. Cited at five places, and quoted at one. Exodus 7:3 and Exodus 8:15, the divine hardening and the self-hardening in one narrative. Psalm 2:7, the clause of generation. Isaiah 10:15, the axe that boasts against the one who hews with it, the single verbatim quotation, given in the wording of the Authorized Version of 1611. Isaiah 45:1, where a Persian king is called the anointed of the Lord.

The New Testament. Cited at two places, and quoted at one. Mark 1:11, the voice at the baptism, quoted in the wording of the Authorized Version. Philippians 2:13, the working of both the willing and the doing.

What is deliberately absent. No commentary, no ḥadīth collection, no rabbinic or patristic volume, and no work of modern scholarship appears in this list, because the study cites none of them by page or by chain. Where it reports what a tradition held, it reports it as a tradition and marks it as such; where a report is contested, the hedge is printed in the sentence. Those reports are witness material. Every reading in this study stands or falls on the Quranic evidence beside it, and a reader who removes the whole witness layer will find the arguments intact.

Composed 2026. The full working materials, the complete inventory with its treatments, the executed concordance records, and the verification architecture with its documentation are maintained at github.com/1000sapients/Trisduction.